

Exile in Postwar Japan: Memories of Japanese Canadians

(Draft, Stan Kirk, July 6, 2025)

Part 1: Historical Contexts of the Exile

Chapter 1: Historical Context in Canada—Events Leading to the Exile

Japanese Canadians in Canada Before World War II

The first recorded Japanese immigrant to Canada, Manzo Nagano, arrived alone in 1877. Although significant numbers of Japanese did not start to come until the late 1880s, once the flow started, their numbers increased rapidly. Most of these early immigrants worked on the west coast of British Columbia as laborers in the forestry, fishing, mining and agricultural industries, but as their communities began to take shape, many also established small businesses ranging from export-import companies to grocery and drug stores to barbershops. Eventually there were small Japanese communities in almost every region of the west coast of BC, but the vast majority settled in the Vancouver area. Most were concentrated in two main settlements, one located on Powell Street in the east side of Vancouver and known as Little Tokyo, and the other in the nearby fishing town of Steveston near the mouth of the Fraser River now part of the Vancouver suburb Richmond.

Despite facing racial discrimination from white British Columbians manifesting itself as disenfranchisement, exclusion from white collar professions, increasingly stringent immigration restrictions and open hostility, their numbers continued to grow. As they increased in number and became successful in the limited economic sectors in which they were permitted to participate, resentment and prejudice against them also increased.

As Japanese military expansionism grew bolder during the 1930s and news of Japanese atrocities in China spread, many Canadians became increasingly alarmed and started to wonder if Canada would also become a direct military target of Japan. Prejudice against people of Japanese descent (hereafter also called *Nikkei*) was further stoked by rumors that they were primarily loyal to the Japanese emperor and military government, and indeed were preparing to act as spies for Japan and help facilitate a future Japanese attack on Canada's west coast. As a result, demands for their expulsion from Canada intensified.

Uprooting and Internment During the War

In 1941, there were about 22,000 Nikkei in Canada, of whom about 8000 lived in the Vancouver area. Most of the others were living in scattered villages along the west coast of British Columbia or on Vancouver Island. The bombing of Pearl harbor on December 7, 1941, as well as attacks against British colonies such as Hong Kong and British Malaya, triggered a series of extraordinary measures by the Canadian government against them. Invoking the *War Measures Act*, the government declared a 160-kilometer wide 'security zone' along the BC coast and ordered all Nikkei within this zone to be forcibly uprooted and moved eastward. In addition, the government confiscated all their property including homes, businesses, fishing boats, land, bank accounts and so on, promising to hold them in trust until the war ended, but in fact selling them

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off later for a fraction of their market value. While a few families with sufficient financial means were allowed to move on their own to approved locations east the security zone, the vast majority were forcibly moved to internment camps in remote mountain areas in the interior of BC. Many of the men who were of working age were initially assigned to road construction crews in various locations in the BC interior and the province of Ontario, while the elderly, the infirm, the women and the children were moved directly to the camps. Those men who resisted or protested too strongly were sent to POW camps in Ontario. By October 1942, about 12,500 Nikkei had been moved to the internment camps, 3600 had moved to the prairie provinces to work on sugar beet farms, 2150 (young men) had been sent to road construction camps and 750 had been sent to POW camps (Timmons 12).

Living conditions in the camps varied but were generally harsh, especially at the beginning. In contrast to the mild climate of the BC coast, winters in the mountainous interior were extremely cold and the buildings lacked proper insulation and heating. However, the Nikkei in these camps resiliently labored together to repair and upgrade their housing and environment. They even got help from some church groups and sympathetic Canadians of other ethnic groups such as Indigenous peoples and Doukhobors, and their living conditions gradually became somewhat more bearable.

While the adults were deeply traumatized by their forced uprooting and severe new situation in the camps, they tried their best to shelter the children from this harsh reality, and, as much as possible, provide them with a near-normal childhood. One very difficult problem facing them almost immediately concerned the children's education. While the BC government reluctantly agreed to provide primary education, it refused to provide kindergarten and high school education. Fortunately, teachers from several mainstream church groups stepped in to help fill the gap, particularly the United Church, the Anglican Church, the Catholic Church and the Buddhist Church. These churches consulted together and decided which camps each church would be in charge of. The Greenwood camp was assigned to the Catholic Church, the Kaslo camp to the United Church, the Sandon camp to the Buddhist Church, and the camps around Slocan to the Anglican Church (Timothy Nakayama, p.12). Then each church sent teachers into the camps to start kindergarten and high school education programs.

The teaching staff of these kindergartens consisted of missionaries who had returned from Japan just prior to the war, professional teachers who had previously been teaching in the church-run kindergartens in and around Vancouver, and several Nikkei assistants. In the case of the Slocan area camps, one of the main driving forces in the founding and continuation of the kindergartens was a very enthusiastic and energetic lady named Margaret Foster who had previously been teaching in Anglican kindergartens for Nikkei children in Vancouver. When the internment began, she and Alice Cox, a missionary returnee from Japan, went along with the first trainload of Nikkei to Slocan and set about establishing kindergartens in the camps. One of her Japanese assistants later wrote about her interaction with the children as follows:

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She had the ability to bring out the best in every child. I can still recall the expression on each child's face as she talked with him or her. She made each of them feel so special. Those were happy days for the children, in spite of the unsettling times for the Japanese Canadians. How fortunate they were to have received so much love and nurturing at such an early age. I am sure one of the happiest memories for many of those children...are those camp days spent with Miss Foster (Moritsugu, p.136).

As a result of the beautiful nature surrounding the camps, the efforts of parents to create a normal childhood environment for their children, and the high-quality educational programs offered in the camps by the various churches and teachers, most of the children came to have very happy memories of their time in the internment camps. For the adults however, incarceration in the camps continued to be a bitter and disillusioning experience. As time dragged on, morale in the camps dropped and the influence of the more nationalistic members increased.

The Undesirable Choice between Dispersal or “Repatriation”

As the war neared its end, the Canadian government had to decide what to do next with the Japanese Canadian internees. There was intense political pressure from British Columbia politicians to prevent them from moving back to their communities on the BC coast. Consequently, in stark contrast to the Japanese Americans, who were allowed immediately after the war to return to their homes and livelihoods on the west coast, the Japanese Canadians were prohibited from doing so, and, in the form of a “loyalty test,” were given two very undesirable choices: 1) disperse to various locations “east of the Rockies” or 2) agree to be “repatriated”¹ to Japan. This “loyalty test” was administered between February and August of 1945 by police officers and other government officials who visited the internment camps. Those who agreed to disperse east of the Rocky Mountains and enter government determined jobs were to be deemed “loyal,” while those who refused this option and instead agreed to be sent to Japan were to be deemed “disloyal.” This second option also required renunciation of citizenship for those who had become naturalized Canadian citizens and even those who were born-in-Canada citizens. Those adults who chose to go to Japan would be given 200 dollars each plus 50 dollars for each child (under 16 years old) in addition to free passage (Timmons, p.12). By August of 1945, a total of 10,347 Nikkei (6884 adults who had signed the form and their 3503 dependents under 16 years old), making up about 40 percent of the Japanese Canadian population, were on the list of those who had supposedly volunteered to be “repatriated” to Japan (Sunahara, p. 109).

The government claimed their choice was made willingly, and in some cases it was, but in reality many made the decision reluctantly under duress and in some cases out of a deep sense of desperation. Most felt that they had no other realistic choice, one of the main reasons being that,

¹ I use the word “*repatriation*” in quotation marks because of the contradiction of a country repatriating its own citizens to a foreign country. While some of those sent to Japan still held Japanese citizenship, most were either naturalized Canadian citizens or born-in-Canada citizens.

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due to the confiscation and selling off of their property and other assets, and due to the prohibition against returning to the BC coast, they had almost nothing with which to restart and rebuild their lives. Especially for those who were older and had spent their lives fishing or working in the forestry industry, there were strong doubts that they would be able to acquire new job and living skills in the unknown environment of eastern Canada. Rumors of hardships and discrimination faced by some Nikkei who had already moved east aggravated this anxiety.

Another compelling reason for many to go to Japan was their deep concern and desperation to ascertain the welfare of their relatives in Japan, especially elderly parents or children who had been sent to Japan for education before the war and were stranded there. Due to the impossibility of communicating with relatives in Japan during the war (except for the rare messages from family members conveyed through the Red Cross), many were desperate to learn whether their family members were still alive and how they were faring, and returning to Japan seemed to be the only way to do so.

Illness and the infirmities of old age within some families made it virtually impossible for them to move east, at least on the government's hasty schedule. When the government officials refused to show flexibility for such cases, the only apparent option was for the younger healthier family members to move east and leave their ailing elders in the camps, thus effectively breaking up their families. This unbearable situation caused more Nikkei to agree to be sent to Japan. In addition, some elderly Nikkei wanted to return to Japan so they could die in their hometowns.

Some Nikkei, of all ages, felt so betrayed and unjustly treated by the Canadian government that they just wanted to get out of Canada. Yet others worried that, if they moved to eastern Canada, they would again face discrimination there and possibly even be uprooted again.

There were also those who genuinely chose to go to Japan voluntarily. Some of these had always intended to return to Japan and had been sending back money to buy fields and houses there in preparation for their return. In addition, there were some who were part of a nationalistic faction which was loyal to imperial Japan and believed until the very end that Japan would win the war. Some had grown more nationalistic due to their harsh treatment in the POW camp at Angler and the influence of other nationalistic Japanese Canadians being held there. Sunahara² points out that the extremely low morale in the internment camps after three years of internment strengthened this faction and enabled them to intimidate and coerce others into making the decision to go to Japan. In his autobiography, David Suzuki describes how some in the Slocan City camp who did not choose to go to Japan were called dogs and how his mother was ostracized by some other women in the camp when they learned that the Suzuki family had decided to stay in Canada.³

² Sunahara (p. 106) Sunahara, Ann Gomer. *The Politics of Racism: The Uprooting of Japanese Canadians During the Second World War*. Toronto: James Lorimer & Company 1981, 2000 and (Kage, p. 62) Kage Tatsuo (transl. Kathleen Chisato Merken). *Uprooted Again: Japanese Canadians Move to Japan After World War II*. Victoria: TI Press, Toronto: Taijin Press, 2012.

³ Suzuki, David. *David Suzuki: The Autobiography*. Vancouver: Greystone Books, 2006. (p. 21)

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Not unexpectedly, there were also disagreements within families about whether to choose exile or not. For example, some older Japanese Canadians wanted to go to Japan for reasons such as the above, while their children, who had been born and raised in Canada, spoke little Japanese, and in most cases had never been to Japan, had no desire to go to what was for them a foreign country. Yet in the end, most reluctantly acquiesced to going to Japan with their parents.⁴ In some cases, families did split up, with the older children deciding to move to eastern Canada and the parents going to Japan with the younger children.⁵

Later, as they received more news about the atomic bombings, the surrender of Japan, and the dire conditions in post-war Japan, many regretted their choice to be moved to Japan and tried to cancel it. However, the Canadian government refused to accept any cancellation requests made after Japan's surrender on September 2, 1945.

Growing Opposition and Legal Challenges, Departure to Japan

After the war ended, the government tried to move ahead quickly with the “repatriations” but was slowed down by red tape and bureaucratic hitches in chartering the ships. There had already been spirited opposition in parliament from the small but vocal socialist party, and reservations had been expressed even by some members of the two mainstream political parties. In addition, perhaps due to the eye-opening experience of World War II and the horrors of Nazi racism in Europe, there was within Canadian society a growing awareness of civil rights and sympathy towards Japanese Canadians. Eventually a significant number of religious organizations, labor unions, civil rights organizations, and liberal-minded members of the press united in protest against the “repatriation” of Japanese Canadians as a clear violation of their fundamental rights as Canadian citizens. They even challenged it legally all the way to the Supreme Court. Although the court ruled that the government was allowed to deport first generation Nikkei who still held Japanese citizenship and even those who had become naturalized Canadian citizens, it also ruled that it was illegal to deport their Canadian-born children who were still under sixteen years old. This seriously complicated the government's plans. The matter was finally appealed to the British Privy Council, which ruled, on December 2, 1946, that the “repatriation” plans were legal under Canada's *War Measures Act* and the *National Emergency Powers Act*, a law which extended some of the government's special powers following the expiration of the War Measures Act.⁶

⁴ For a more detailed discussion of the various overlapping reasons why so many chose to be sent to Japan, see Sunahara p.105-109).

⁵ Kage, *Uprooted Again*, p. 109.

⁶ For a thorough scholarly discussion of the protracted court battles and the legal maneuvering of the Canadian government side, see Eric M. Adams and Jordan Stanger-Ross. *Challenging Exile: Japanese Canadians and the Wartime Constitution*. (UBC Press, 2025)

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Meanwhile, however, during this process, public indignation and outcry continued to increase. Despite its legal victories, the government finally gave in to the growing public outrage and discontinued the “repatriations.” However, 3,964 people of Japanese descent had already been sent to Japan in five groups, using three ships chartered by the Canadian government. The *Marine Angel* departed Vancouver on May 31 carrying 668, the *General Miggs* on June 16 with 1106 and on August 2 with 1377, and the *Marine Falcon* on October 2 with 523 and on December 24 with 290. Of these passengers of Japanese descent, 34 percent were Japanese nationals whose average age was 51.6 years, 15 percent were naturalized citizens of Canada whose average age was 56.5 years, and 51 percent were Canadian-born citizens, whose average age was 16.7 years (Timmons, p. 70).

A small subgroup of the children and teenagers had previously been sent to Japan before the war in order to receive a Japanese education, and hence already had some familiarity the language and local customs of their parents’ ancestral villages (Kage, 43ff). However, most of the Canadian-born children and teens had never set foot on Japanese soil so were being moved to a country that was almost completely foreign to them. Even those who had been studying Japanese language in Canada had experienced little contact with the local dialects of the villages they were being sent to.

Most of this book will convey the recollections of these exiles who at the time were children or teenagers. However, before that, in order to give historical context to their remembered experiences and understand them more deeply, the next chapter will describe the historical situation and living conditions that awaited them in postwar Japan.

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Chapter 2: Historical Context in Japan — Conditions Awaiting Colonial Civilian Returnees and the Exiles from Canada

While the almost 4000 Japanese Canadians sent to Japan in 1946 comprised close to 20 per cent of the total Japanese Canadian population, their number was a mere drop in the bucket when viewed in the context of the massive inflow of Japanese decommissioned soldiers and colonial citizens being hastily repatriated to Japan at the same time. To lay the groundwork for better understanding the severe conditions awaiting Japanese Canadian exiles upon their arrival and how they were treated in their ancestral villages, this chapter will first briefly summarize the general historical situation of postwar rural Japan. Then it will describe the rapid repatriation of the large number of Japanese military personnel and colonial civilians and how they were received as a backdrop for better understanding the situation of the much smaller group of exiles simultaneously arriving from Canada. Finally, it will compare the characteristics and circumstances of the colonial civilian returnees with those of the exiles in order to more deeply grasp and appreciate the recollected experiences of the latter, which form the focus of this book.

Agricultural conditions in Japan before and during World War II.

Agricultural villages throughout Japan had been enduring varying degrees of poverty from long before World War II. Government investment and gradually rising rice prices had resulted in modest improvements during the early 1930s, but military conscription to support Japan's imperial military activities, especially in the later 1930s and early 1940s, significantly reduced the number of young farm laborers, resulting in much lower agricultural output and a ten per cent decrease in cultivated land. Consequently, significant food shortages were already apparent even at the beginning of the war and grew more severe as the tide of battle turned against Japan.

To make matters worse, towards the end of the war numerous urban dwellers (mostly women and children) were fleeing the cities for the countryside to escape American bombing. This influx of urban refugees dramatically swelled the village populations, exacerbating the strain on the rural economy and, most importantly, food supplies. By the war's end, allied bombing had destroyed most of Japan's transportation system and merchant fleet, cutting off access to fertilizers and other agricultural input products, thus further depressing agricultural production. Unexpectedly severe weather made things worse, especially in 1945, causing another precipitous drop in agricultural production. This was the dire situation at the end of the war,⁷ and it was about to become even more extreme due to another extraordinary event—the rapid mass influx, mainly to the countryside villages, of millions of defeated Japanese soldiers and colonial civilians from Manchuria, China, Korea, Taiwan, and other reaches of the Japanese empire.

⁷ For a more detailed description of the historical context of Japanese agricultural decline before, during, and after the war, see Allinson, Gary D. *Japan's Postwar History*, 2nd ed (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 2004)

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Massive Repatriation of Japanese Military Personnel and Colonial Civilians

At the end of the war, there were 3.7 million Japanese military personnel scattered throughout the colonies and various locations of battle, many suffering from battle shock, malnutrition, and various diseases. In addition, approximately 3.2 million Japanese civilians had been living in the colonies as administrators, businessmen, farmers, and various other occupations. Their numbers also included many children born and raised abroad, a large proportion of whom had never set foot in their parents' homeland.

Japan's military defeat and loss of its imperial authority immediately put these colonial civilians at grave physical risk, particularly in those areas of China and Korea where Japanese imperial rule had been particularly oppressive and violent. It therefore became a matter of urgent necessity for the Allied forces not only to completely demobilize and return the military personnel to Japan, but also to evacuate these civilians from the colonies as rapidly as possible and repatriate them to the Japanese homeland. It was a massive undertaking but, while often characterized by chaotic and at times inhumane conditions, was accomplished with surprising speed. Between October 1, 1945, and December 31, 1946, in an extraordinary logistical feat, more than 5.1 million Japanese soldiers and civilians were returned to the Japanese homeland (Dower, p. 54). The most intense wave of military and civilian repatriation, including approximately 1,110,000 repatriates from Manchuria and hence referred to as "the million-person repatriation," occurred between May and the end of October 1946.

The deportation of Japanese civilians from Manchuria combined with the repatriation of military men from Southeast Asia to create a flow of an average of 5500 refugees a day to Japan in the summer of 1946. In September 1946, the peak of repatriation, 56 ships containing 67,000 returnees arrived in Japan (Watt, p. 52).

The Repatriation Centers

In order to process this massive rapid influx as well as the simultaneous outflow of Koreans, Chinese, and other colonial subjects who had been living in Japan and were returning to their home countries, 15 regional repatriation centers were established at various ports of entry.⁸ They were set up to perform various functions, one of which was to protect the homeland from the dreaded infectious diseases to which Japanese soldiers and civilians had potentially been exposed outside of Japan such as cholera, typhus, smallpox, leprosy, anthrax, and others. Immediately upon arrival at the centers, the repatriates were routinely sprayed with DDT powder as a precaution against louse-born typhus, an unpleasant and demeaning experience for many. Their clothing was also immediately disinfected and they were inoculated against various diseases (Watt, p. 72, 92).

Next, they were issued repatriate identification papers which they would need later to receive rations and other government services, and arrangements were made for transit to their home

⁸ The repatriation center at Uraga was established to receive those coming from the Pacific regions, so this was where the exiles from Canada were processed.

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villages. The time spent in the repatriation centers varied. At first the goal was to get the returnees through the centers within 24 hours, but the processing time gradually became longer and extended to several days.

The living conditions in the repatriation centers varied between the centers and over time, but in many cases were quite chaotic and desperate. Dower relates the following description of the repatriation center at Uraga:

Accounts from the repatriation camps convey a stark impression of chaos and demoralization. A contemporary description of the Kamoi Repatriation Center in Uraga captures this. Opened in November 1945 to handle civilian repatriates from the Pacific, the camp was intended to accommodate 1300 hundred people but quickly became responsible for three times that number, about half of whom were children. The camp administration was incapable of staving off malnutrition. Its typical menu consisted of a meager daily ration of mixed rice and wheat, accompanied by bean paste soup for breakfast, cooked cabbage for lunch, and cooked cabbage and white radish for dinner. Many of the repatriates had no place to go. Stealing became commonplace, and gambling absorbed the energies of many of the men. The journalist Kuramitsu Toshio wrote in January 1946 that four doctors, eighteen nurses, and four medical aids served the center, with critically ill people being sent to one of six neighboring hospitals as expeditiously as possible. Despite this, fifteen to twenty people died in the camp of malnutrition and other causes every day (Dower, p. 56).

Gradually the centers become better organized and expanded their functions to include more services, one of which was facilitating contact between the repatriates and their relatives.

The most urgent concern of most [repatriates] was to find out about the welfare of their families and hometowns in Japan. Some repatriation camps set up information centers with maps showing which areas of Japan had been most severely damaged in the war and also facilitated the repatriates receiving news from their relatives about how they were doing.

There were also consultation centers for people facing specific problems (Watt, p. 74).

Outside the camps, a radio program, called Returnee News, was set up in January 1946 to provide contact information to the relatives of incoming repatriates such as the names of their boats and ports of entry. It was followed in June by another program called Missing Persons which continued successfully for several years. Notice boards were also put up throughout the country where people could post notices seeking information about missing relatives (Dower, p.57-58).

Once the processing in the repatriation centers was completed, arrangements were made for the transit of the repatriates to their home cities or ancestral villages in various parts of Japan. Tickets and seats were provided on special trains for repatriates as well as food or meal tickets (Watt, p. 75).

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Cold Reception of Returning Soldiers and Colonial Civilians

During the heyday of empire building and waging war, the soldiers had been sent off from Japan with optimistic fanfare as heroes for their service to the empire. However, after defeat they returned humiliated and extremely demoralized, with many suffering severe psychological effects from the horrendous battle conditions they had endured. One would have expected them to be welcomed back with at least some gratitude for their sacrifices on behalf of country and empire, but for many, such was not the case. The Japanese in the homeland had become extremely disillusioned with the military government that had led the country into such a disastrous war and humiliating defeat. By extension, they also came to view their once glorified soldiers as disgraced participants in the failed imperialistic military campaigns. Hence, the military returnees were often shocked by the disdainful reception they had to endure from their countrymen.

Even hardened veterans, however, were often ill-prepared for the shock of returning home. The communities that had sent them off with parties and parades and kept them supplied with comfort packages and 'thousand-stitch' belly-warmers often did not welcome them back. They were, after all, losers. Their unkempt appearance seemed a mockery of the heroic ideals and imagery that had saturated wartime propaganda... Many ex-servicemen found themselves regarded not just as men who had failed disastrously to achieve their mission, but also as individuals who had, it was assumed, participated in unspeakable acts.

References to the reproachful glances that acquaintances and strangers alike directed at them became a familiar refrain in veterans' letters to the press (Dower, pp. 59-60).

How about the civilian returnees? Their rapid and massive evacuation from the colonies and transport to Japan was also often chaotic and excruciating, but most were successfully returned and processed within a period of 16 months between September 1945 and December 1946 (Watt, p. 2). The authorities hoped that the civilian repatriates would be successfully reintegrated into their former homeland communities, and in some cases this happened. However, like the returning soldiers, many were shocked by an unexpectedly cold reception from their former fellow villagers and in some cases even their close relatives. Instead of being welcomed as fellow countrymen who had served abroad in the glorious work of their country and its empire, they now found themselves being distanced and treated with suspicion and contempt.

Reasons for the Cold Reception of Repatriates from Colonies

Watt repeatedly points to several factors behind the unexpectedly cold reception experienced by so many of the Japanese military personnel and colonial repatriates. Here, these factors are further arranged and categorized as underlying cultural factors and concrete historical factors.

Underlying Cultural Factors

One fundamental underlying cultural factor was the longstanding and ingrained Japanese belief in the uniqueness of their racial and cultural identity and the resulting sense of what it means to

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be truly Japanese. This notion of “Japanese uniqueness” has long caused many Japanese to strongly differentiate themselves from others, even from neighboring Asian peoples.

Downplayed by the government when Japan was colonizing Asia and trying to establish a pan-Asian empire, it regained currency with Japan’s defeat and loss of empire, resulting in homeland Japanese even differentiating and stigmatizing their fellow Japanese citizens returning from the colonies. After living for years away from the homeland and its cultural and social norms, civilians in the colonies came to be perceived and treated by homeland Japanese as somehow less than “real Japanese” which was an “all or nothing category” (Watt, p. 6, 7). Watt further notes that “the press and other sources began to discuss the plight of the repatriates from the moment they arrived, sometimes expressing sympathy for them, sometimes drawing attention to the perceived threat they posed, but almost always emphasizing their difference from the “homeland” Japanese. (Watt, p. 78).

A related cultural factor was the clear spatial and geographic demarcation in the Japanese mind between ‘inside’ and ‘outside,’ which naturally extends to a human demarcation between “insider” and “outsider.” During the colonial period, the Japanese homeland and the colonized lands were distinguished by the terms “nai-ichi” (inside land) and “gai-ichi” (outside land), and, by extension, Japanese living in the homeland were referred to as “nai-ichi-nin” (people of the inside land) and Japanese living in the colonies as “gai-ichi-no-hito” (people of the outside land) (Watt, p. 34). This did not seem to translate into a particularly negative perception of Japanese civilians living in the colonies during the imperial period when they were positively extolled for their contributions to the imperial project, but following defeat and loss of the empire, it facilitated an ambivalent attitude towards them as a kind of outsiders.

Another underlying social factor contributing to the negative attitudes toward colonial repatriates, especially lower ranking ones, was the lingering perception that many of those who had left Japan as colonial settlers possessed headstrong and difficult personalities which had factored in their move away from the homeland in the first place. This common stereotype raised the suspicion that they would again become potential sources of disharmony and trouble in their village societies.

In some situations, leaving Japan for the colonies had solved a problem at home. This was true of poor villagers throughout Japan whose move to Manchuria solved a perceived problem of too many farmers and not enough land within the Japanese homeland. Some families attempted to rid themselves of troublesome family members by sending them to the colonies and their return brought the original problem home with them. The reputation of colonial Japanese before defeat conditioned their reception at home. Metropolitan Japanese easily transferred prewar and wartime prejudices against unattached women and adventurers in the colonies to their postwar incarnations as *hikiagesha* (repatriates). Returnees suspected of having been transformed or contaminated in ways that might threaten the home society faced special problems upon their return.” (Watt, p. 60).

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Concrete Historical Factors

In addition to the above underlying socio-cultural factors, there were also some concrete and overt historical factors that directly affected how the returnees were treated by their homeland countrymen. One such factor was the drastic differences between the kinds of suffering they had experienced during the war. The homeland Japanese had suffered tremendously from both conventional and atomic bombing while enduring severe hunger and oppression by the authorities among other hardships. In contrast, those Japanese living in the colonies, being geographically removed from the intense war raging over Japan, were in most cases experiencing relatively good living conditions and in some cases were unaware that Japan was even losing the war. For many of these, their suffering only began in earnest after the surrender when they suddenly became objects of retribution by the formerly oppressed colonial subjects. Admittedly, their post-surrender sufferings in the colonies were genuine and often extreme (dispossession of their property and in some case rape and even murder), but these were very different in kind from what was being suffered by the homeland Japanese throughout the war. Watt explains that, in the minds of the homeland Japanese “only narratives of Japanese suffering that took place on the home islands of Japan qualified as legitimate national remembrances of suffering in World War II” (Watt, p. 13.). Elsewhere she elaborates,

At home, people expressed concern about “overseas brethren” but they maintained a kind of unwillingness to recognize overseas experiences of war’s end as part of the national experience of defeat or equivalent to the sufferings of people in the metropole during and at the end of the war... People [in the homeland] tended to turn away from stories of defeat in the colonies... Their suspension in that period sealed [overseas Japanese] outside the stories of defeat within Japan” (Watt, p. 54)

As in the case of the military personnel, the tendency to likewise associate colonial civilians with Japan’s defeat and disgrace also negatively affected their reception back to the homeland. During the imperial period and through much of the war, these civilians had been widely respected for their role in building and administering the empire. After defeat, however, this admiration turned to disdain for their perceived role as partners in the failed imperial project (Watt, pp. 11, 17, 18).

Another concrete historical factor was the hygienic danger posed by the massive influx of repatriates from colonial territories. Despite the robust measures taken at the repatriation centers to disinfect and inoculate them, they were still viewed by many as potential hygienic threats. The level of concern varied according to the colonies from which they were returning, being lowest in the case of those coming from Taiwan, which had been the most successfully and peacefully administered colonial country and hence had achieved a level of public hygiene almost equal to the Japanese homeland. The Korean colony, which was more resistant to Japanese colonization and hence much less easily administered, was considered somewhat less hygienic, and Chinese and other more outlying colonies were considered dangerously unhygienic, resulting in the

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returnees from these areas being perceived as a serious hygienic risk to the homeland (Watt, pp. 15-17, 71)

The various kinds of violence suffered by many colonial civilians at the hands of former colonial subjects at the end of the war, while arousing some feelings of sympathy, also contributed to additional stigmatization of many repatriates, especially those returning from colonies where anti-Japanese violence was most reported to have occurred. Such violence included looting of their homes and theft of their property, physical beatings including sexual violence against women, and in some cases even murder. Some repatriate women especially were kept at arm's length due to fear of sexual contamination by foreign men (Watt, p. 207).

Additionally, the sudden severe impoverishment of most colonial civilians at the end of the war led them to be viewed with both pity and disdain upon their repatriation. During the colonial period most had achieved varying levels of economic success. However, the circumstances of their sudden and rapid evacuation from the colonies became a grim economic equalizer that placed most repatriates in abject poverty upon their return to the homeland.

Upon defeat, many were immediately evicted from their homes which were immediately looted by locals. Some longtime colonial civilians in Korea, naively assuming they would be able to retrieve their belongings at a later time, carefully packed, labelled, and stored them before leaving. However, the American administrators “apparently disposed of this property at will, designating the carefully labelled belongings as ‘abandoned’ and the using them as exchange for goods and services provided by Koreans or selling them as souvenirs” (Watt, p. 44).

The destitution of the returnees shaped views as well. Forced to leave homes, businesses, and personal possessions behind, the overseas Japanese arrived with only what they could carry on their backs and cash limited by the allies to 1000 yen, an amount that was slightly less than what an average family would spend on food in a month in 1946. People at home, most on the edge of starvation in a country devastated by conventional and atomic bombing, viewed these refugee-like beings with a mixture of pity and contempt. At best, the colonial returnees looked like yet another mouth to feed and at worst a potential menace. (Watt, p. 60).

The stigmatization of the colonial repatriates extended also to their children and affected them deeply. As in the case of the adult repatriates, the strong notion of Japanese uniqueness and the related notion of insider versus outsider were strong underlying factors behind how the children of repatriates were received. Although most had received a Japanese education in the colonies, their being raised outside of Japan resulted in their character and manners being perceived as being different and not genuinely Japanese. This distinction from homeland Japanese children was further underscored by their use of the standard Japanese they had learned in school and their inability to speak the local dialects of their ancestral villages. Watt notes that “colonial girls in particular had a reputation for more independent thought and behavior than girls in Japan. The lack of a regional accent, a weak or nonexistent tie to a hometown within Japan, and perceived behavioral differences sometimes added up to a failure to reach the bar of

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authentic Japaneseness” (Watt, p. 58). This sense of being different from other Japanese would continue to haunt many of them long beyond the period immediately following their move to Japan.

People who had returned from the colonies as children or teenagers were particularly affected by having their childhood experiences in the colonies invalidated and their authenticity as Japanese called into question by their peers....They survived the violent end of war, but, rejected in some cases as insufficiently Japanese, chafed within its borders in a kind of reverse exile....Repatriated children later wrote of their spiritual alienation from “ordinary Japanese people” and their sense that they remained on the edge of Japaneseness (Watt, p. 10).

It must also be acknowledged that the attitudes of the homeland Japanese towards the colonial repatriates were not completely monolithic. Those from prominent families in Japan with financial means were often better accepted and reintegrated more successfully. Even those who were less privileged had some genuinely sympathetic advocates, including members of the media who portrayed them positively and urged the homeland Japanese to view and treat them more sympathetically (Watt, p. 79). Some even suggested that the repatriates could play an important role in internationalizing postwar Japan and rebuilding it as a member of the international community.

Their knowledge of foreign countries was a plus. With their many years, sometimes decades of business experience overseas, repatriates were in a terrific position to be leaders of Japan’s future international trade... They would become more culturally polished and interact with other countries based on respect and understanding (Watt, p. 87).

Living Conditions Faced by the Colonial Repatriates Upon Return to Japan

In addition to having to endure the above-described attitudes of their homeland countrymen and the resulting stigmatization and social distancing, the colonial civilian returnees, many of whom had been living in relative ease and affluence in the colonies, now found themselves in a far different world where they had to find ways to survive in extremely inhospitable conditions.

The most pressing situation in postwar Japan was severe poverty and hunger. Dower notes that, by the last months of the war, “most Japanese were preoccupied with merely obtaining the bare essentials of daily subsistence. Simply putting food on the table became an obsessive undertaking.” He vividly describes the Japanese diet near the end of the war as follows:

It was a rare family anywhere that regularly ate white rice as a staple. The most common household diet consisted of barley and potatoes, but even these had fallen into short supply... Authorities in Osaka recommended an emergency diet that suggested how precarious daily subsistence had become. Based on a research report by local army officials, the emperor’s loyal subjects were encouraged to supplement their starch intake by introducing such items as acorns, grain husks, peanut shells, and sawdust to their household larder (Sawdust, it was explained, could be broken down with a fermenting

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agent, transformed into a powder, and mixed in a ratio of one to four with flour to make dumplings, pancakes, or bread). For minerals, people were encouraged to introduce used tea leaves and the seeds, blossoms, and leaves of roses to their diet. Protein deficiencies could be remedied by eating silkworm cocoons, worms, grasshoppers, mice, rats, moles, snails, snakes, or a powder made by drying the blood of cows, horses, and pigs. Well sterilized, it was reported, mice and rats tasted like small birds, but it was important to avoid eating their bones since it had been demonstrated that this caused people to lose weight (Dower, p. 91).

Following the war, emergency food shipments from the US helped avoid a complete humanitarian disaster, but severe hunger continued to be a daily reality for most Japanese. The situation was exacerbated by runaway inflation. These conditions continued to prevail between 1946 and 1949 as measures by the Occupation forces and government to combat them were ineffective.

As a result of the desperation for food and ineffective government relief measures, the black market flourished and a system of bartering for food became widely established. People from the agricultural villages would carry large bags packed with farm produce to the cities on crowded trains or in some cases on foot and trade the contents for non-perishable consumer items. Likewise, city dwellers would travel by train to and from the countryside to trade nonperishable items for desperately needed foodstuffs. Materials commonly exchanged for foodstuffs included kimonos and other clothing, shoes, cigarettes, cash, and precious items such as jewelry that had been treasured family heirlooms (Allinson 49). The painful sense of loss felt over precious items successively bartered away for food came to be famously expressed by the term “bamboo shoot lifestyle,” which compared peeling off one by one the layers of a bamboo shoot (a common Japanese food) to the “peeling off” of clothing and other valuable items in exchange for food. The term “onion lifestyle” was similarly used but with the added implication of shedding tears as each layer of the onion was peeled off (Dower, p. 95).

A secondary result of the near starvation conditions was the widespread increase of diseases caused by malnutrition, one of the most common being Berberi, the symptoms of which included numbness and extreme weakness in the limbs. In addition, despite the strong hygienic measures taken at the repatriation centers to prevent diseases in the colonies from entering Japan, various types of contagious diseases, which had already been rampant during the war, flourished due to the squalor and malnutrition that prevailed in the immediate postwar period. Common examples included dysentery, cholera, typhoid fever, smallpox, scarlet fever, diphtheria, meningitis, polio, encephalitis and others. Tuberculosis was especially feared and caused more deaths than all the other diseases combined (Dower, p. 103, 104).

Another major characteristic of postwar Japanese society was the almost complete breakdown of law and order, which, while not caused solely by the near famine conditions, was exacerbated by it. Even before the end of the war, fields were being raided by people desperate for food.

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By 1944 theft of produce still in the fields led police to speak of a new class of “vegetable thieves” and the new crime of “field vandalizing.” That year, officials in Osaka prefecture estimated that 46 per cent of all economic crimes in their jurisdiction involved food.

Entrepreneurial individuals formed illegal “procurement troops” that specialized in obtaining rural produce for sale in the cities (Dower, p. 90-91).

The breakdown of law and order became much worse after the war ended as many Japanese soldiers, embittered and disillusioned by defeat as well as the cold reception and economic helplessness they experienced upon return to Japan, completely lost any semblance of military discipline.

In the wake of defeat discipline collapsed... The emperor’s loyal soldiers and sailors seemed to have metamorphosed overnight into symbols of the worst sort of egoism and atomization. Officers as well as enlisted men engaged in looting, sometimes on a grand scale, and police reports expressed fear that public disgust would extend upward to “grave distrust, frustration, and antipathy toward military and civilian leaders,” even “hatred of the military” in general (Dower, p. 59).

Trains, in some cases already filled to capacity with passengers (including repatriates returning to their home villages), became microcosms of extreme public disorder and ruthless survivalism as demobilized soldiers and black-market traders carrying their large bags of goods between the cities and agricultural villages competed fiercely for entrance and seating space. Dower mentions that “Men on black market runs to the countryside took over whole train cars, where they sang till drunkenness overcame them.” (Dower, p. 146).

Interestingly, the extent and severity of the economic desperation and public disorder that prevailed in the immediate post war years were soon reflected in the play of Japanese children. The most common games included “yamiichi gokko” (black market play), and “panpan asobi” (mimicking Japanese prostitutes and their American military customers). In other games children played the roles of vagrants and thieves, for example, “handcuff play” and “catch a thief.” Another genre of games specifically reflected the kinds of disorder commonly seen occurring on trains:

In mid 1947, a teacher in Osaka reported that his pupils seemed absorbed in playing “train” games.... In “Repatriate Train,” children put on their school knapsacks, jammed together on the dais, shook and trembled, and got off at “Osaka.” “Special Train”—obviously a takeoff on the railway cars reserved for occupation personnel—allowed only “pretty people” to get on. A “conductor” judged who was favored and who wasn’t. A button missing? Rejected. Dirty face? Rejected. Those who passed these arbitrary hurdles sat in leisure on the train. Those rejected stood by enviously. In “ordinary train,” everyone piled on, pushing and shoving, complaining about being stepped on, crying out for help. Every so often, the conductors balancing on the edges of the platform announced that the train had broken down and everyone had to get off. It was, the teacher lamented, a sorry spectacle to behold: from playing war to playing utter confusion (Dower, p. 112).

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Such were the dire conditions facing most of the Japanese colonial civilians as they streamed back into postwar Japan in 1946. Generally speaking, these were similar to what the exiles sent from Canada would have to face and as they arrived and settled in their ancestral villages, but there were also some differences between the two groups which would make living conditions even more adverse for the exiles.

Comparison of the Colonial Repatriates and the Exiles from Canada

It has already been noted that the 4000 exiles sent by Canada to Japan during 1946 were a minute number when compared with the more than five million returning colonial civilian repatriates who were pouring into Japan at the same time. In addition to their numbers, there were other noteworthy differences between the exiles and the colonial returnees.

One such difference was the relative geographical distance separating them from Japan before and during the war. Most of the colonial civilians had been living in colonies relatively near Japan such as Korea, Taiwan, and China so were physically closer to the Japanese homeland and hence would have found it easier to travel to Japan in prewar days. While some Japanese Canadians moved back and forth fairly frequently between Canada and Japan (for example, many of the fishermen from Mio) and some had the means to send their children to Japan for their education, many had rarely or never made the long trip back across the Pacific to Japan since migrating to Canada. For their Canadian-born offspring, Japan was a distant and almost foreign country. Over time, this contrasting degree of geographical separation would have affected the degree of each group's sense of social and cultural connection to Japan.

Their social status and level of privilege in their countries of residence were also different. Not only the higher status colonial civilians who occupied government and corporate administrative positions, but even those who had migrated to the colonies as farmers, small businessmen, and laborers enjoyed a social position and lifestyle superior to that of their colonial subjects. They were a privileged minority. In inverse contrast, even those Japanese migrants to Canada who had become naturalized Canadian citizens and their Canada-born children constituted a socially inferior and oppressed minority class that was excluded from engaging in most of the respected occupations in Canada.

A related point of contrast was the extent of their assimilation into the society of the countries where they were living. Most of the colonial civilians had made little effort to associate closely with the society of their colonial subjects, who they viewed as inferior. Rather, their tendency was to impose Japanese culture and values on the colonial societies. The Japanese Canadians, on the other hand, due to their inferior social position and the discrimination and exclusion they were facing, needed to find ways to gain acceptance into mainstream Canadian society. Hence many, though not all, made varying degrees of effort to assimilate. Many had become naturalized Canadian citizens. A few had even gone to war for Canada in World War I in an attempt to demonstrate their loyalty and gain full citizenship rights. In addition, a significant number had converted from Buddhism to Christianity though the zealous proselytizing of mainly Methodist

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and Anglican missionaries, thus adopting the main religion of Canada. The fact that so many converted to Christianity suggests that their cultural ties to Japan had already become weak. As for those who remained steadfast Buddhists, Japanese Buddhism in North America had itself been influenced by the Christian culture, even incorporating some of the nomenclature and liturgical customs of the Christian churches. Hence, if the homeland Japanese suspiciously viewed colonial civilians as culturally tainted by living outside their motherland, they must have perceived the migrants living in Canada as even more so.

Another difference was how they had been contributing to Japan. So long as the Japanese empire was growing, the colonial civilians of all ranks and occupations were generally respected and appreciated by the homeland Japanese for contributing to Japan and its imperial project. On the other hand, while many Japanese Canadians had financially contributed to their ancestral towns and temples, they had been living outside the empire in a land that was hardly distinguishable from the US (to Japanese eyes) and had officially become an enemy country during the war. Hence, instead of being generally appreciated as contributors to the wellbeing of Japan, they were perceived as participants in the economy of a country foreign and hostile to the empire of Japan.

A difference that seems to have worked in favor of the exiles upon their arrival in Japan was that, coming from a modern non-tropical country like Canada, they would have been perceived as posing less of a hygienic threat to Japan than most of the colonial civilians who had been living in areas of the empire that were perceived as less hygienically advanced. This appears to be suggested by the report of Lieutenant Orr who wrote that they were spared from some of the more extreme decontamination measures experienced by others upon arrival at the repatriation center.

Despite the significant differences mentioned above, the Japanese Canadian exiles and the colonial civilian repatriates (particularly those of average social rank), had much in common. One common aspect of their backgrounds was why many of them had left Japan in the first place. With the exception of those colonial civilians who had been appointed to administrative positions, most members of both groups were from the lower social strata of rural Japan and had left for similar reasons such as crowded poor villages, poor working conditions in the manufacturing sectors, friction with family members or fellow villagers, in some cases a sense of adventure or wanderlust, or a last chance (in the case of some women) to get married and start a family. The resulting antisocial stereotypes of those who had migrated away from Japan would negatively affect how they (and their offspring) would be received by their ancestral village members.

Another basic similarity was that most members of both groups were being driven to postwar Japan by circumstances largely beyond their control. The colonial civilians, despite enjoying a privileged existence even during the war, after the surrender suddenly found themselves having lost their superior status and needing emergency evacuation to the homeland due to the hostility of their former colonial subjects. Most of the exiles from Canada, despite wishing to stay in

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Canada, could no longer see a future for themselves in a country that had forcibly uprooted, dispossessed, incarcerated, and then prohibited them from returning to the west coast. Hence, most members of both groups, after experiencing severe trauma in their countries of sojourn (though at different times), were now being moved to Japan against their real wishes to stay where they were, or because those wishes had been irreparably dashed.

A related similarity was the extreme destitution of both groups upon arriving in Japan, despite whatever wealth they might have built up while abroad. Again, with a few exceptions, both had been forcibly dispossessed of everything they had worked so hard to gain while overseas. Japanese Canadians had their property confiscated at the beginning of the war and sold off by the Canadian government, and what they had left in their former homes was often looted. Many of the colonial Japanese were driven from their homes at the end of the war and their property was looted and their goods stolen, or in the case of some in Korea, taken out of storage and sold off by the American forces stationed there. Thus, members of both groups arrived in Japan dispossessed and almost penniless. Both would undergo further impoverishment upon arrival due to the strict laws severely limiting the amount of money and goods they were allowed to bring into Japan and by the runaway inflation that took hold after the war.

However, the exiles from Canada were slightly better off materially: Unlike many of their colonial civilian counterparts who had suddenly been completely dispossessed of their property and goods at the end of the war, they at least had the goods they had been allowed to pack and bring with them from Canada.⁹ In addition, after arriving in their ancestral villages, many would continue to receive good clothing and other nonperishable goods sent by their relatives and friends still in Canada. This would create the illusion among the extremely poor local villagers that those who came from Canada were more well off than in fact they actually were.

A somewhat ironic similarity shared by the exiles and the colonial civilians was that the kinds of trauma they had undergone overseas, while somewhat different from each other, were even more starkly different from the wartime sufferings experienced by the homeland Japanese population. The homeland Japanese had experienced the horrors of both conventional and atomic bombing, malnutrition, and widespread disease. The wartime suffering of the exiles in Canada had included overt racial prejudice and exclusion, forced uprooting, dispossession, incarceration, and so on. The colonial civilians, because of their superior social status in the colonies, had fared better, even during the war. Yet, after surrender, they also suffered forced uprooting, dispossession of their properties, and forced displacement due to the hostility of their former subjects. Hence, the wartime sufferings both the Japanese Canadian exiles and the Japanese colonial repatriates, despite some differences with each other, at least shared some

⁹ Timmons p 73 quoting Patricia Roy: "Whereas refugees had often fled with only the poor clothing on their backs, the Canadians had arrived 'dressed like gentlemen' and carrying plenty of baggage." (Patricia E. Roy et al., *Mutual Hostages: Canadians and Japanese During the Second World War* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1990), 189.

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similarities. However, the wartime sufferings of both of these incoming groups differed much more drastically from the even more severe kinds of wartime suffering experienced by the homeland Japanese civilian population, and this would hinder the homeland Japanese from sympathizing and identifying with them.

The children of both the exiles from Canada and the colonial civilians also had much in common. While colonial civilian children enjoyed a much more privileged existence than did the Japanese Canadian children, most of the children of both groups had received some form of Japanese schooling to varying degrees and hence could speak, also to varying degrees, the standard Japanese used in educational and public contexts. Yet, while they would have had some exposure to whatever Japanese dialect might have been spoken by their parents at home (if the parents had roots in the same region of Japan), most had not learned much of the local dialects of their parents' ancestral villages, especially if their parents come from different parts of Japan. Hence, upon arrival in Japan, most children of both groups were unable to speak the local dialect, which would cause them to be viewed more as outsiders and less as genuine Japanese.

From the above points of comparison, one could reasonably predict that if, in addition to being an extreme economic burden, the returning colonial civilians were generally viewed as a social threat for having become culturally tainted and thus "less Japanese," and less able to fit harmoniously into homeland Japanese society, the exiles from Canada would have been perceived as even more culturally tainted and even more foreign, and thus as even more of a social threat. This would quite naturally result in them being even more coldly received in their ancestral villages than the colonial returnees.

Awareness of this historical, economic, and social context helps us understand more clearly the recollections of those Japanese Canadians who experienced exile in postwar Japan as children and teenagers and why they were received and treated as they were. Against this historical background, the remaining chapters will focus on the recollections of Japanese Canadian exiles who, as children or teenagers at the time, found themselves suddenly thrust into the harsh foreign world of postwar rural Japan.

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Part 2: Exile and Return: The Recollections of the Exiles

Chapter 1: Experiences Recalled by Exiles Interviewed by Kage

In *Uprooted Again*, Tatsuo Kage reported his main findings based on interviews with 25 exiles between 1988 and 1991. Unsurprisingly, the exiles' recollections varied according to their different locations in Japan, ages, and individual personalities. Yet, there were some common experiences and emotions that repeatedly emerged from the recollections reported by almost all of them and hence can be seen as major common themes of experiencing exile in postwar Japan and, in the case of some, experiencing return and readjustment to Canada. This chapter will summarize these major themes, primarily utilizing Kage's reporting of his interviews with the exiles.

The Journey to Japan

The journey to Japan for those exiles who were still in the internment camps around Slocan Lake began with a two-day train trip from the Slocan city station to Vancouver. Once in Vancouver, with their freedom of movement greatly restricted, they waited to board the ships that would take them to Japan. Due to bureaucratic bungling, in some cases the boarding did not proceed smoothly and according to schedule, but eventually they were aboard and on their way. While some had been intending and looking forward to going to Japan from even before the war, most felt otherwise and some recalled shedding tears of grief as they passed under what is now the Lions Gate Bridge and watched Vancouver recede in the background.

Despite narrow sleeping quarters on the ships, the food was by most reports delicious and plentiful, and the crew members were kind and accommodating. Unfortunately, most of the passengers suffered varying degrees of seasickness, some for the entirety of the voyage (Kage, 24, 30, 104, 126) and had to be cared for by the others. After a journey of about 10 to 12 days on average, they arrived at Yokosuka. As they approached Japan, they were first greeted by Mount Fuji rising in the distance—a view most of the children had previously seen only in pictures. As they got closer they noticed increasing numbers of fishing boats. However, the first reaction reported by many as they approached the port at Yokokusa was abject shock at the utter destruction of war.¹⁰ Upon entering Tokyo Bay they could see the wreckage of sunken ships all around them, and they realized how badly Japan had been defeated.

The Repatriation Center at Uruga

Upon arrival at Yokosuka the exiles and their luggage were transported by barge from the ship to shore and then onto trucks bound for the nearby Uruga Repatriation Center, a former naval training grounds and barracks where they would stay on average about two weeks. Upon

¹⁰ Timmons, p. 78

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disembarking, teenager Yukihiro Mizuyabu felt a sense of freedom for the first time. It would be short-lived.

The physical layout and functions of the Uraga repatriation center were described as follows by Oscar Orr, a Canadian army Lieutenant-Colonel stationed in Tokyo at the time of the first arrivals from Canada:

The repatriation center at Uraga consists of six large camps at various points around the peninsula, and a central reception point capable of handling and processing as many as 10,000 persons per day. The center is under command of... the [US] Eighth Army, and all steps such as inoculation, delousing, customs examination, payment discharge, bathing, etc., are carried out in a mass production assembly line system (Kage, 24).

Regarding the management of the center, Orr commented that “Everything runs smoothly and there was not a hitch in any of the arrangements. The whole operation is carried out by the Japanese civilian authorities under the control and supervision of the U.S. Army.” It must be noted that this glowing evaluation is at odds with the much darker description (quoted by Dower, p. 56) in the previous chapter which portrayed the Uraga repatriation center as beset by overcrowding, squalor, stealing, malnutrition, sickness, extreme boredom, and numerous deaths.

Orr also reported positively that the Japanese Canadian exiles were exempted from most of the hygienic measures imposed on returnee soldiers and gave the impression that preparations for the exiles’ transport to their ancestral villages was proceeding expeditiously and according to plan:

The Canadian repatriates were not required to go through all the stages imposed on returning troops; for example, their baggage was not examined by the customs, nor was any disinfecting resorted to. They were, however, each given a typhus and cholera inoculation on landing, and will be kept in the camps until tomorrow, when arrangements will be made to give them all railway tickets to their destinations. The railway station is about a mile from the camp and the baggage is now all in camp and will be transported to the railway station in trucks. The unloading of the baggage was a big task. The men among the repatriates worked three shifts until six o’clock yesterday morning getting it up.

(quoted by Kage, 24)

Why the much rosier description of the Uraga Repatriation Center by Orr than that quoted by Dower in the previous chapter? Was it because the situation at repatriation center was being described at different times? The report described by Dower refers to January, 1946, about four months before the exiles from Canada started arriving, and it is known that the the repatriation centers did become better organized over time. Or, was it because, as Orr’s report mentioned, the Japanese Canadians were spared from some of the more extreme hygienic measures endured by demobilized Japanese soldiers and colonial repatriates? Or, were they housed in an area of the camp with better conditions than those related by Dower? Was Orr deliberately shielded from seeing the terrible conditions reported by many? In any case, it is clear from the recollections of the Japanese Canadian exiles themselves, as reported to Kage, that the reality they experienced

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was much less positive than what Orr reported based on his observation of the first arrival. George Tsuruda, for instance, referred to the time in the center as “twelve hellish days” (Kage 104). George Miyagawa recalled that “‘What kind of place have we come to’ was the universal question... For the first time in my life, I saw grown men crying” (Kage, p. 83).

The exiles’ most vivid memories of Uraga concerned the shockingly poor quality of the food. Gene Yoshiyuki Kawakami recalled receiving “cookies” that were covered with a white substance that turned out to be mold” (Kage, 30) and that they “fished weeds and insects out of the soup and scraped the mold off the biscuits” (Kage, 37). Lloyd Kumagai told Kage, “We were really shocked by the food. All we got in our bowls—they were army bowls—was rice boiled with barley” (Kage, 62). George Miyagawa recalled that, “As for the meals, the ‘rice mixed with barley, dried fish, miso soup and pickles was abysmal.” He added that he did not eat the food for several days until compelled by hunger (Kage, p. 83). George Tsuruda recalled having been well fed on the ship, but at the repatriation center receiving only “dried army biscuits crawling with insects, and soup with unidentifiable floating objects.” Due to fear of cholera they could only drink boiled water. Yukihara Mizuyabu said that the only kind of meat they received consisted of small pieces of whale meat in soup which he found inedible and, when the Mizuyabu children were given some brown biscuits at a meal, “they threw them aside after one bite, finding them hard and tasteless, far from being the chocolate cookies they resembled” (Kage, 126-127).

Sleeping conditions at the repatriation center were very crowded and dirty, with each person allotted a space with one blanket on a filthy tatami floor (Kage, pp. 37, 69). George Miyagawa recalled that “many families were jammed into a large room in a two-story building. The floor was covered with straw-filled mattresses, with no space to walk between them. (Kage p. 83). George Tsuruda felt like he was suffocating under the mosquito nets they had to use (Kage, p.104).

These dismal conditions were exacerbated by the extremely high price of any food that might be available for purchase (usually on the black market), the deportees’ lack of cash due to severe restrictions against bringing in foreign currency that allowed them no more than 1000 yen, and devastating exchange rates which made the small amount of money they did have rapidly lose most of its value. The money which they had received from the Canadian government was only dispensed in small installments which were clearly insufficient.¹¹

Another hardship in the repatriation center was a sense of isolation and the near impossibility of communicating with relatives in Canada due to a very poorly functioning civilian mail service, so they had to rely on the mail service of the occupation forces in Japan which also was not very expeditious (Kage, 31-32). Likewise, it was extremely difficult to make contact with

¹¹ Consequently, exiles who arrived after the first group were strongly advised in advance to bring a supply of goods such as foodstuffs (including sweets), bedding, clothing, medicines, vitamins and other daily necessities that would help them through this initial difficult period in Japan, as well as items like tobacco and lighters, etc., that could be used to barter for food and other necessities (Kage, p. 25-6, 30-31).

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their relatives in Japan, with whom they had not communicated since before the war (Kage, p. 62).

Extreme boredom was yet another unpleasant characteristic life in the repatriation center. George Miyagawa recalled, “Neither were there any amusements at the time, nothing at all to divert the mind” (Kage, p. 83). George Tsuruda, in slight contrast, recalled that his only pleasant memory of the repatriation center was of some entertainment consisting of dancing and music, apparently provided by government or local volunteer groups (Kage, 104).

The Arduous Journey by Train to Ancestral Villages

After completing the various medical procedures and paperwork, the exiles were taken by train from the repatriation center to Shinagawa station in Tokyo and transferred to the special “repatriate trains” which would convey them to their ancestral villages in various parts of Japan. Most were headed southwest to the Shiga, Wakayama, Hiroshima, and Kyushu prefectures, with smaller numbers going north and east. Haruyuki Mizuyabu recalled that “the environs of Shinagawa still consisted of heaps of rubble and scorched fields; no large buildings had remained standing.” More shocking views were awaiting them during their train journey.

Although the exiles and repatriates from the colonies were allotted special cars and seating on the repatriate trains, conditions became increasingly desperate and excruciating as the journey progressed. At each stop, hordes of people with bags full of goods, in many cases items to be used for bartering for food, tried to clamber aboard, usually through the open windows, and fought for space. The traditional Japanese custom of orderliness and waiting one’s turn had completely broken down. Passengers were warned to watch over their goods carefully to protect them from thieves. The interiors of the train cars became increasingly filthy due to the unruly crowds of passengers. Black soot from the train engines entered through the open windows as the trains passed through the long tunnels, sticking to passengers faces and clothing.

It was extremely difficult for passengers to get on and off the train when they needed to use a washroom. In addition to the unruly people throwing bags into the train and then piling aboard, the exiles were shocked by the sight of beggars, some barely clothed, approaching the train at every stop, and people living in caves (Kage, 54, 62-63, 87, 105). George Tsuruda recalled that “The train, at first empty, became overcrowded at the third station, so that the passengers could not even move their feet. People climbed in and out through the glassless windows, so that their faces became blackened with soot.” At Hiroshima, George had to leave the train to go to the toilet and was barely able climb back in through a window before the it departed (Kage,105).

Evidence of American bombing could also be seen throughout the journey, such as the twisted ruins of bombed factories and the devastation of the cities the trains passed through. Passengers headed for Shiga and Wakayama changed trains at Osaka, while those from more westerly regions such as Hiroshima and Kyushu continued on the final legs of their journey, where yet more vistas of devastation and squalor awaited them. The sight of Hiroshima, completely levelled by the atomic bomb, became an indelible memory for many.

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Arrival at Ancestral Villages: Reunions and Cold Receptions

The exiles, exhausted by their excruciating train journey, were in for more shocking experiences when they finally reached their ancestral villages. As it had been virtually impossible during the war for Japanese Canadians to make contact with their families or friends in Japan, in most cases it was on their arrival in the villages that they first learned who had or had not survived the war. Hence the first reunions with relatives were characterized sometimes by joyful relief, sometimes by grief and tears, and sometimes a combination of both. While some were warmly welcomed by their relatives and old friends, many were shocked to experience a very cold reception even from their closest relatives who bluntly made it clear that their coming was an unwelcome burden. Thus the children and teenagers, most of whom were unable to speak more than a little Japanese and were ignorant of the culture and local dialects, found themselves in an overcrowded, almost completely foreign, and in many cases unfriendly environment.

Lack of Lodging

Because the villages were already overcrowded with urban refugees who had migrated during the war to the countryside during the war, soldiers who had just returned from the battlefields, and civilians who had just been repatriated from the colonies, lodging was in extremely short supply. Hence, some exile families had to live, often for months, in storage sheds, granaries, barns, or other hastily constructed shelters, while others were cramped into rooms or small sections of a relative's house (Kage, p. 70, 84).

Near-famine conditions

As explained earlier, Japan had already been experiencing extreme food shortages due to the ravages of war and unusually bad weather. This problem was severely exacerbated in the rural areas first by the influx of urban refugees during the war, and then the massive wave of returning soldiers and colonial civilians after surrender. Even families who had rice and vegetable fields were only able to keep small amounts as most of the harvest was taken by the government for redistribution. Any rice that was available for purchase on the black market was extremely expensive and therefore out of the reach of most.

Hence, it quickly became evident to the exiles that the near famine conditions they had noticed in Tokyo and other urban areas extended also to the countryside, and, while the severity varied somewhat from region to region, many found themselves experiencing constant hunger. The foodstuffs that some had brought from Canada soon ran out and they were now compelled to rely on rations and compete like everyone else for scarce resources. Some relied on squash, one of the more readily available vegetables, as their main source of nutrition. The feelings of hunger caused some teenagers, who had moved to Japan reluctantly, to resent even more deeply their parents' decision to accept exile, thus increasing family tensions even more (Kage, 63).

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George Miyagawa recalled that, since his uncles were farmers, rice, miso, and soya sauce were available, but at the beginning they mainly survived on sweet potatoes and miso soup with dumplings made from wheat flour and water (Kage, 84).

There were some reports of elderly or frail exiles dying of malnutrition in the months after they returned to their ancestral villages. Some exiles in the Hikone area of Shiga sent a petition for financial assistance to the Canadian government explaining that the paltry financial support (200 dollars) provided to the exiles had been quickly used up and that some were already dying of malnutrition. Deaths of elderly exiles from malnutrition were also reported from Hiroshima (Kage 72).¹² Kage relates the tragic story of Kuniko Kawashita, a former teacher at Tashme internment camp, who fell ill and eventually died from lack of medicine and malnutrition in Kyushu several months after having received support for her medical expenses from friends in Canada (Kage, 72).

Ongoing difficult relations with relatives and villagers

The extreme poverty, overcrowding, and continuous hunger would persist for about three years before gradually ameliorating. Not unexpectedly, this persistent state of desperation further stressed the relations between many of the exiles, their Japanese relatives, and the people in the villages. Yukihara Mizuyabu recalled his family being verbally attacked by his aunt with whom they were living but added that it was an inevitable result of their living together in such cramped conditions (Kage, interview).

One thing causing particular resentment against the exiles was that, despite their current state of destitution, they had at least been relatively well nourished during their internment and during the ship journey to Japan, and hence appeared to be significantly healthier and better off than the locals who had been suffering the ravages of war and hunger for years. The high quality of the clothes they had brought from Canada, or in some cases had recently been sent by relatives still in Canada, was conspicuous and made them appear rich and strange, thus further stoking feelings of resentment (Kage, 37).¹³ Goods that some had brought to share with relatives quickly dissipated, resulting in them again being regarded as economic burdens (Timmons, p. 80). Feelings of xenophobia fueled by government propaganda during the war also played a role, often leading to deliberate harassment of some of the exiles who were shunned as foreigners and in some cases as enemies because they could not speak the local Japanese dialect well or failed to correctly follow local cultural norms (Kage, p. 71).

¹² Also Sunahara (127)

¹³ Timmons quoting a source in Roy: "Whereas refugees [from the colonies] had often fled with only the poor clothing on their backs, the Canadians had arrived 'dressed like gentlemen' and carrying plenty of baggage." Roy, Patricia E. Roy et al., *Mutual Hostages: Canadians and Japanese During the Second World War* (Toronto:University of Toronto Press, 1990), 189.

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Problems of Education and Bullying

The adjustment and education of the children also became a difficult issue for the exiles as they tried to settle down. The few children who had been sent to Japan to receive an education before the war already spoke Japanese at a near-native level and had experienced Japanese culture. For them, readjusting to Japanese village life and school life was relatively easy (Kage, pp. 43, 48). But these were a small minority; for the less-privileged majority, Japanese culture and language, especially the local dialects, were foreign, and the adjustment process was much more difficult (Kage, 64).

Young exiles over 16 were not allowed to enter the Japanese school system and hence could not even consider going on to university. Children under 16 were generally allowed to enter the Japanese school system to complete their required education, but some, whose births had not been registered with the Japanese consulate in Canada and so did not have dual Japanese citizenship, had to apply for Japanese citizenship in order to enroll (Kage, 63, 64).

Predictably, most struggled in school with the Japanese language, especially reading and writing, and therefore were moved back to a lower grade level than they had already achieved in Canada (Kage, 63). One example given by Kage is that of Robert Okabe, who was about 12 years old when he arrived in Japan, having spent his early childhood in Manitoba with little contact with other Japanese Canadians and minimal education in Japanese language. Therefore, he was placed in grade one and progressed by one grade each month (Kage, 89).

These exile children stood out from their classmates due to their language deficiency and because they were obviously older and bigger than their classmates. In addition, their western clothing and shoes set them apart and made them seem strange (Kage, 37). Such differences often resulted in bullying and exclusion. Some suffered verbal abuse, being taunted for being foreigners and told to “Go back to America!” Some had stones thrown at them (Kage pp. 70-71). Kage elaborates the example of Richard Takahara who had been born in 1941 so was able to begin elementary school in Japan at the normal age:

His mother kept his hair long, with the result that he stood out from the other boys, all of whom had “shaven heads,” and he was “dressed funny” in good clothes sent by his grandparents in New Denver. Inevitably, he was targeted by the bullies... The other children stole the luxury items he had brought to school, such as pencils with erasers attached to them, and gifts from his grandparents. His mother complained to the teacher, but nothing came of it. And then, since he lacked for textbooks, his mother had to borrow the books and write them out in longhand. Up to Grade Four or so, he had to fight in order to survive (Kage, 91).

Gene Kawakami reported being bullied in high school by his xenophobic teacher (a former soldier) because of his “un-Japanese” speech and behavior (Kage 38). Marge Ikebe recalled other students calling her names and throwing stones at her. When she refused to go to school, her teacher came to her and apologized for his inability to stop the bullying (Kage, p. 70). Some Japanese children were even encouraged by their xenophobic parents to actively bully the

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“outsiders” (Kage, 71). Fortunately, some of the bullied exile children were eventually able to turn the situation to their own advantage and even make friends among their Japanese classmates by teaching them western sports they had played in Canada (Kage pp. 63-4) such as baseball and helping them with their English studies.

Somewhat Better Situation of Children Who Had Studied in Japan Before the War

As mentioned above, a small subgroup of the exile older children and teenagers, although born in Canada, had been to Japan before the war, usually to receive a Japanese education. As a result, they could speak Japanese (including the local dialect) pretty well and were familiar with Japanese culture, so they adapted relatively quickly to life in Japan (Kage, 43ff). The pre-war Japanese education they had received was very militaristic and nationalistic for the purpose of raising loyal soldiers who would unquestioningly sacrifice themselves for country and emperor (Kage, 48). Some of them found, upon returning to Japan, that many of their former classmates had died in battle.

One such example, Yoshiaki Nakagawa, had gone to Japan soon after birth and was raised by his grandparents until he graduated from middle school at age 18, at which time he went back to Canada and studied English in night school. After returning to Kumamoto as an exile, he was shocked to learn that most of his former Japanese classmates had been sent to war and killed (Kage, 43-44). Similarly, Kiichi Miki, also educated in Mio, Wakayama, returned as an exile and learned that, of 105 former classmates who had gone to war, all but 10 had died (Kage, 45-46). Miki Nakamura was born in Vancouver in 1918 but grew up in Kagoshima, Kyushu. She explained:

In the 1930s, Japan caused the Manchurian incident, rushed into the Sino-Japanese Incident, and won a lot of victories. After graduation, I taught in an elementary school. We were so completely wrapped up in the war that, when Japan won a victory, we held flag parades by day and lantern parades by night. Everybody cooperated in the war effort, including homeland defense. We sewed *sennin-bari*. These were “one thousand stitch belts;” Each was a piece of white cloth that a soldier could use as a stomach wormer, sewn with a thousand red-thread-stitches. Every one of the stitches was made by a different woman wishing bravery and success for the soldier (Kage, 116-117).

Miki also made *Imon-bukuro* which were comfort bags sent to soldiers at the front, filled with small gifts such as daily supplies, games and gadgets, with a message of greeting and comfort. She added, “We were taught to dedicate our lives to the emperor, to the Nation, and I think we trained our pupils to live like that too. We flattered ourselves, thinking that the Japanese were the best people in the world. We got into a way of thinking that was super-nationalistic.” (Kage, 117).

Despite their easier adjustment to Japanese language and culture, these young exiles were not exempt from the same extreme physical and economic hardships faced by the others.

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Employment With the American Occupying Forces

Whether by fishing or agriculture, most exile families were unable to sufficiently provide for themselves and employment opportunities were extremely limited even in the cities. Thus, for many of those young exiles who were over 16 years of age (and hence ineligible to enroll in the Japanese education system), the most common way to augment their families' meager finances was to go and work for the Occupation forces and send a portion of their earnings to their parents (Kage, 128). The Occupation forces needed a wide variety of civilian workers who could speak English. Consequently, young Japanese Canadians were able to find employment at the bases as maintenance workers, construction laborers, tradesmen, office workers, barbers, technicians, researchers, translators, and interpreters, etc. (Kage 33-34). Not only was the pay somewhat better than in non-military jobs; they also were able to receive various foodstuffs and medicines that were otherwise unavailable to the general public (Kage, 55). Some experienced bigoted treatment such as racist name-calling by some members of the US military, but generally most reported being treated well and at in some cases very considerately and generously, and some even forged strong and lasting friendships with their American coworkers on the bases.

An interesting example is Yukihara Mizuyabu who for two years resisted the idea of working for the Americans as he held them partly responsible for his family's sufferings during the war:

It was difficult for me, because I had equated the Occupation forces with the powers responsible for all the misfortunes that had befallen our family since Pearl Harbor. If it wasn't for this feeling, I could have gone to work for them as soon as I arrived in Japan... But to me, the Occupation forces were the same as Mackenzie King and his regime in Canada" (Kage, 128).

After arriving in Mio, Wakayama, Yukihara's father ordered a small fishing boat to support the family. While awaiting its delivery, the family members worked for meager wages hauling firewood down a steep narrow path to the beach, from where it was transported to Osaka. After several months the boat was delivered, but then they had to wait for several more months for an engine, so in the meantime they used the boat without one. Despite their hard labors at various endeavors, they could not earn enough money to support the family, so out of necessity Yukihara finally decided to leave Mio and work for the American Occupation forces (Kage, 127-128). After starting, he "began to realize that they were not as bad as my own Canadian government" (Kage, 129).

George Tsuruda, who worked as an interpreter and translator at a base in Kagoshima recalled that some American soldiers bullied him, using the derogatory term "gook" for George and Japanese civilian employees. On the other hand, when it became apparent that his stomach could not tolerate the Japanese food he was being given, some soldiers started sharing their sandwiches with him. Thanks to his diligent work, the Americans came to trust and treat him with special consideration. Unfortunately, this sparked resentment among his Japanese co-workers and once his clothing was stolen while he was taking a shower. Fortunately, an American soldier ordered new clothing for him from the Sears catalogue and, on his last payday, a group of American

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soldiers took up a collection and bought him several sets of new clothing and a suitcase, an act of kindness which helped him allay the costs of returning to Canada (Kage, 105-107).

Transition to Work in the Private Sector

As the Japanese economy recovered in the early 1950s, there was a growing need in the private sector for employees who could speak English well. As most of the bases closed down after the Korean War, some of the Japanese Canadian civilian workers struggled to find new work and floundered economically, but others successfully transitioned to private sector employment, using their English and social skills to compensate their lack of a formal Japanese education. Tak Matsuba (whose story will be told in more detail in a later chapter) is an outstanding example of this. He had developed good relationships with his American coworkers through his outgoing and friendly personality and his willingness to help in any way possible whenever asked, and it was through an introduction from an appreciative American officer that he got his start to a successful career in the private sector:

At heart, I wish I'd had a better education, but it turned out that I didn't really suffer for lack of it. I was lucky. That is, the Japanese would join companies that they had taken exams for, so I didn't have that way of getting hired, but I built up my own contacts and after I'd been dealing with the same people for several years or so, they'd ask me to work for them... After the war, when conditions in Japan were looking up, not a lot of people knew both English and Japanese. So a lot of people asked me for favors. If they didn't know me, they'd get introductions from people I knew. When they asked me to write business letters and make phone calls in English, I always did; I never turned anybody down. That's how I made a lot of connections, so you can say I was fortunate. From time to time, I had to do something that was a real pain in the neck, but once you help somebody out, you can't very well refuse them the next time they ask for a favor (Kage, 40-41).

There were a few who continued to work long-term for the US armed forces (Kage p. 48-51). After his employment with the Occupation forces, Yukiharu Mizuyabu worked temporarily for a company that was building bases in Okinawa, but then again worked gainfully for the US army in Okinawa for nine more years before returning to Canada in 1961 (Kage, Mizuyabu interview).

Many of those who successfully transitioned to jobs in the private sector found themselves struggling to adapt to Japanese corporate culture and be treated as true equals in their workplaces. In most cases they were generally well-treated as colleagues and respected for their English skills, but many felt regarded at least to some degree as outsiders, even if their Japanese skills approached native level (Kage, 37-38). Gene Kawakami explained that his coworkers "treated me well at work, but there was a line that I couldn't cross... You never become a Japanese unless you grew up there... There's always a gap" (Kage, 37). His younger brother John found he was being criticized behind his back by his Japanese co-workers for being "un-Japanese," while his American co-workers also did not seem to be completely comfortable with him as they could not neatly categorize him as either Japanese or American (Kage, p. 38).

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Kazuyuki Ide recalled being criticized to his face by a superior for not following the customary Japanese procedures for consensus building and being too forthright and direct compared to his Japanese colleagues. As a result, most of his business proposals were rejected (Kage, 56). Yet, he and some other exiles who stayed in Japan eventually had very successful careers in major companies and in some cases started their own successful businesses (Kage, 55, 65).

Return of Some to Canada

From the day they arrived in Japan, many of the young exiles were longing to return to Canada, not merely to escape the harsh conditions of postwar Japan, but also to be reunited with their close friends and relatives who had remained in Canada after the war. However, this was impossible as one condition of their agreement to “repatriate” to Japan was to renounce their Canadian citizenship, and the Canadian government had officially branded those who agreed to exile, however reluctantly, as “disloyal.”

This barrier was finally removed in April of 1949 when the Canada ended restrictions on all the Japanese Canadians, allowing them to return to the west coast and giving them full citizen rights including the right to vote (Timmons, 100). The Canadian-born exiles in Japan were permitted to apply to the Canadian embassy in Tokyo for “clarification of citizenship,” upon which they were granted a certificate of citizenship from the Canadian government. However, despite this important legal step forward, the government continued to make returning to Canada very difficult by refusing the exiles any financial support or assistance with documentation needed for exiting Japan. Hence only a few were able to leave during 1949.

By 1950 the Japanese economy and living conditions were gradually improving. Yet, while some young Japanese Canadian exiles were growing more comfortable in Japan and managed to transition to gainful employment in private companies, others realized their career prospects within Japan were limited by their lack of a formal Japanese education, so started imagine better employment prospects in Canada. There were also some who felt that living in Canada would provide more freedom and educational prospects for their children (Kage, Yukihara Mizuyabu interview, 1991). Yet others were motivated by a more basic instinct to return to the land of their birth and, as mentioned above, were longing to reunite with friends and relatives. Many were motivated by various combinations of the above.¹⁴ Hence, the early 1950s saw many deciding to take advantage of their restored citizen rights to move back to Canada (Kage, 82).¹⁵

¹⁴ One option for overcoming the barriers to retuning, particularly for young men without financial means, was to join the Canadian army based in Japan. About 40 young men did so and were highly estimated for their enthusiasm. Many of them even fought for Canada in the Korean war. Some women also resorted to making use of the occupying forces as a means of leaving Japan but in a different way: They married American and other allied soldiers stationed in Japan (Timmons 86) and accompanied them on their return to their home countries.

¹⁵ Although the exact number is not known, it has been estimated that eventually about half of the exiles returned (Kage, 29).

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However, pulling up stakes yet again and moving back across the Pacific Ocean was not a simple matter that could be accomplished quickly. Due to lack of financial and administrative support from the Canadian government, lengthy preparations and expenses were involved. The ship fare alone amounted to about 350 Canadian dollars (a decent monthly salary in Japan at that time amounted to about 30 Canadian dollars) (Kage, 107). Also, to prevent them from becoming an economic burden on their arrival, the Canadian government required the returnees from Japan to be sponsored by relatives or friends in Canada, similar to the requirements facing first-time immigrants.¹⁶ Hence it often took months or even years from the time of the decision to return to the actual arrival in Canada.

A common pattern of return was for one family member to initially be sponsored by relatives or friends in Canada. That person, upon arrival, would then work hard and save money until they had enough to sponsor another family member, who would then, in a similar manner, eventually sponsor other family members. In this way, it often entailed a process extending over several years for whole families, or all those family members who intended to return, to be reunited in Canada. There were also some who, for various reasons, made the decision to move to Canada years later.

Readjusting to Canada

Unfortunately, the situation awaiting many of the returnees in Canada was less than favorable. Although the negative attitudes of many white Canadians toward non-white people had changed for the better due to awareness of the horrific results of racial prejudice overseas during the war in Europe, a strong element of anti-Japanese sentiment still lingered, particularly in British Columbia, and not everyone was pleased by the government's decision to allow Japanese Canadians to return. The discrimination was usually not as overt as it had been before the war and often manifested itself in more subtle forms such as quiet exclusion. Sometimes prejudice did occur more blatantly in the form of open racial insults and other overt verbal abuse. Many of those returning from exile faced silent discrimination when seeking housing and good employment, with the result that some gave up job hunting in Vancouver and moved elsewhere in search of better prospects. Yet many persevered and eventually found a way to succeed, though often in other parts of Canada or the US.

The language barrier additionally turned out to be a major obstacle for many of those who had been very young when their families went to Japan and hence had spent their entire childhood there. In contrast to their elder siblings whose mother tongue was English and who had struggled to learn Japanese and adjust to life in Japan, these younger returnees were moving from a country that felt to them like home to a country and a language that were almost completely foreign to them. This was at a time before the existence of government- and NGO-

¹⁶ Yukihiro Mizuyabu, *Japanese Canadian Redress, The Toronto Story*, Chapter 2: Our Expulsion Stories. <https://torontonajc.ca/torontostory/chapter2.html>

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sponsored English language and immigrant resettlement programs. Hence, the kinds of challenges faced by the returnees often had much to do with their age, with the younger ones especially struggling with English and Canadian culture.

George Miyagawa is an example of those who made the decision to return to Canada because of limited prospects in Japan due to lack of formal education. In November 1946, at the age of 15 and having only completed Grade Six, he moved to Tokyo where he got a job as an interpreter for a social club run by the British Commonwealth Occupation Force and then worked for an import-export company in Kobe for seven years. He said, "That was quite a good job in those days, but I realized that I couldn't get ahead in Japan because the competition was fierce and I didn't have enough formal education." So, he returned to Canada in 1956 at age 21. He could not find suitable employment, so after working for four months as a gardener, he moved to Sacramento where he worked on a farm owned by his younger sister's Japanese American husband. Failing to get permanent resident status in the US which still had race-based immigration quotas, he moved back to Canada and in 1957 joined the armed forces, the easiest employment opportunity at the time, and a year later married a Japanese national from Shiga prefecture. After a 25-year career with the Canadian Army, he worked for 11 more years in the civil service before retiring in 1995 (Kage, 82-85)

An interesting example of the younger returnees who had to struggle to learn English before finally achieving success is Richard Takahara. Born in 1941, he was still a small child when he went to Japan. He returned to Canada in 1955 at age 14. Due to his poor English ability, he was placed in Grade One and spent the first year working his way up to Grade Four, making it to Grade Seven in the second year. Fortunately, a kind teacher, Mrs. Underhill, took him under her wing and even allowed him to stay for free in a hotel owned by her and her husband. This resulted in more opportunities to practice his English. He also received special tutoring each night and Mr. Underhill had him join the cadet corps, an experience which further boosted his English. He graduated from High School in 1961, though a couple years older than his classmates. Various other experiences additionally contributed improving his English proficiency and he went on to study engineering at Southern Alberta Institute of Technology. He was then employed by the Ministry of Transport where he enjoyed a distinguished career that included being an instructor to new recruits and overseeing construction of radar facilities at Canadian airports. (Kage, 92-93).

George Tsuruda's story of return is one of eventual success due to a combination of financial assistance from others, hard work, and determination to improve his educational qualifications. In 1949 he applied to reinstate his Canadian citizenship and received his Canadian passport. Fortunately, with some unexpected financial assistance from American military friends, he was soon able to afford the ship fare. After arriving in Canada, he first worked at various sawmills and construction jobs. He sent most of his earnings to his family in Japan but also saved enough to a sponsor his younger brother to Canada and pay his passage. To qualify for better employment, he took correspondence courses while working. With his high grades he succeeded

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in entering the Air Force's school of electrical engineering, married a Japanese Canadian who had also been an exile, and went on to a distinguished 30-year career in the air force, followed by a 10-year career in international trade after retiring. He also was active in the Edmonton Japanese Canadian community.

An example of the subtle racial discrimination that confronted many of the returnees from exile is the story of Mary Otsuji. While working for the Occupation forces as a typist and interpreter, she had taken courses in business English and Psychology offered by the army and had also impressed her bosses by successfully selling liability insurance which enabled her to save money for her return to Canada. In 1950, at the age of 20, she returned to Canada, where, working as a maid, she attended night school taking courses in stenography and bookkeeping. She then tried to find office employment but was unsuccessful, apparently because of latent discrimination against nonwhite applicants. Several times, after confirming that a particular job opening was still available, she went for the interview, only to be told a suitable person had already been hired. She eventually gave up and found a job as a seamstress in a Chinese Canadian-owned clothing factory, where she was eventually able to transfer to an office job when the owner learned about her office experience in Japan (Kage, 100).

An example of someone who was reluctant to return but finally did so several years after the main wave of returnees had gone to Canada was the aforementioned Yukiharu Mizuyabu who was exiled at age 17 and hence more aware than the younger children of the injustices suffered by the Japanese Canadians in Canada. At first he vowed never to return to Canada due to his bitterness at how his family had been treated by the Canadian government. In 1951 he did the paperwork for regaining his Canadian citizenship but continued work for the US forces in Okinawa, finally returning to Canada in 1961. He gave three reasons for his decision to return: First, despite his deep anger at the Canadian government, he wanted his young children to "grow up in a country offering more physical space." Second, he had come to think that he should return and fight for his rights as a citizen which he felt were still not being fully honored by Canada, and third, he felt driven by a natural instinct to return to the place of his birth, comparing it to "a salmon swimming upstream to its birthplace"(Kage, 130).

Another person who returned somewhat later than most and was motivated mainly by the future of her children was Miki Nakamura. She was born in Vancouver in 1918 but had spent most of her childhood in pre-war Japan. She returned to Canada at age 20, marrying and having two sons before the war and thus was exiled to Japan as a married adult with children. While recalling how they struggled economically in postwar Japan, she expressed fond memories of community life and the way people looked out for each other in their poverty. Yet she was concerned about her children's lack of access to a good higher education, so in 1961 she and four of her children moved to Canada so that her children could have access to better educational opportunities and enjoy more freedom. At first she worked as a housekeeper, but after her husband and remaining three children arrived later under her sponsorship, they set up a grocery store business which they continued until retirement (Kage, 116-120).

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Marie Katsuno is an example of a returning exile who arrived much later than average, not moving to Canada until 1994. She was born in Vancouver 1923, so, like Miki Nakamura, was already a young adult when she was exiled to Japan, where she soon found work with the Occupation forces. After the Occupation ended, she got a good job with Northwest Orient Cargo Airlines, and then a US-based trading company. Later she enjoyed success in Japan as a free-lance interpreter and reporter working at various international meetings and conferences, yet all the while continuing to feel a kind of “homesickness” for Canada. She married a Japanese American who wished to move to the US after retirement but was unable to do so, so Marie sponsored his immigration to Canada where they moved in 1994 (Kage, 95-96).

Kage also relates the tragic story of Irene Kato, an example of the extreme difficulties some returning exiles faced when trying to sponsor their parents’ return to Canada. Soon after the Canadian government changed the law to allow Japanese Canadians to return, Irene moved back to Canada in December of 1949 with financial help from friends in Canada, leaving her parents behind in Japan. In 1950 she married, and the next year she and her husband began farming in Surrey. She soon applied to sponsor her parents’ move to Canada. The first application, based on “compassionate grounds,” was rejected, so she reapplied to bring her mother over as a “temporary visitor.” The application was successful, but tragically her mother fell ill and passed away before she could move to Canada. Irene then successfully applied to bring her father to Canada. He was just on the verge of leaving Japan (he had finished his preparations and had packed his suitcase) when he died as the result of an accident, so her protracted efforts to bring both parents to Canada ended tragically (Kage, 114-116).

Decision of Some to Stay in Japan

While many of the exiles decided to return to Canada, it is estimated that about half ended up staying in Japan (Kage, p. 20). Kage asked several exiles why they remained in Japan and received a variety of answers which often included a combination of factors. One of the most common reasons given was marriage to a Japanese spouse and having children in Japan who were already enrolled in the Japanese school system, making it more difficult pull up stakes and move (Kage 75-76). Another was that, thanks largely to demand for their English skill, they were fortunate enough to find a stable career path in Japan which they came to enjoy and did not want to relinquish (Kage, 65). Yet another reason given by some was that, over time, as their language skills improved, they had come to feel more secure and at least somewhat comfortable in Japan, even if they had not completely assimilated to the culture and were still treated to some degree as outsiders (Kage, p. 74-75). Some said that, due to their bitter memories of the unjust treatment they had received from the Canadian government, they still felt too much resentment towards Canada to ever want to return. Interestingly, Kage elaborates the unusual example of Hideo Nose, who, although having spent his whole childhood in Canada and was already in his mid-teens when he set foot in Japan for the first time, seemed to have deliberately assimilated to Japanese society and almost never entertained the thought of returning to Canada (Kage, 76-80).

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Tak Matsuba is an example of someone who stayed permanently in Japan in order to continue on a career track in the private sector that he was enjoying. As mentioned above, despite not finishing high school, he used his English ability, native wit, social skills, and willingness to help in any way possible when requested and thus built many strong relationships with the American officers, one of whom introduced him to his first job in the private sector. One thing led to another and eventually Tak had a very successful career assisting various companies in their international relations and projects, and, despite all his siblings and parents moving to Hawaii, he seems not to have ever given much thought to moving from Japan although his frequent business travels enabled him to visit old friends and attend internment camp reunions. After his retirement he continued to be active in the group of Japanese Canadians in the Kansai area (Kage, 40-41).

Kazayuki Ide was also one of those who stayed in Japan although not feeling completely at home there because their work for the Occupation forces led to success in the private sector. His first job for the Occupation forces was at Itazuke air base in Fukuoka where he was trained in a wide range of skills including dealing with military passengers, air traffic control, and air freight. Around 1957 he started working in supplies and transportation of goods for the officers' clubs, which gave him the opportunity to meet buyers who came to Japan. This led to work in the private sector, including for a trading company that was a supplier for the PXs at the bases. Later he worked for Nishitetsu Railroad and then spent seven years selling imported Ford vehicles. In the mid-1960s, he moved to Tokyo and started his own business which assisted an American Company that operated theaters. Although he never felt completely accepted or comfortable in the Japanese corporate culture and endured criticism for his non-Japanese workplace manners, he stayed in Japan and eventually ran a variety of businesses including gift stores, a wax museum, and game centers. In the mid-1950s, he married a Japanese and had a son.

Although he stayed in Japan permanently, he admitted to Kage that he never stopped thinking about returning to Canada, saying, "I've always thought that, wherever I live, it's just temporary... I want a permanent home, and the only way I could find one is to move back to Canada, maybe in the Vancouver area, or anywhere else in BC...(but) it would be very difficult for my wife." (Kage, 56) He added that, ideally, he would like to have an apartment in Canada so that they could live between both countries. (Kage, 54-56)

Michiyo Yamamoto is an example of the smaller number of exiles who stayed in Japan and continued to work long-term for the American military. 19 years old when she arrived in Japan, her English ability enabled her to find good employment with the Occupation forces. She felt that she was quite well paid and cited her need to make a living as one reason for staying in Japan. Even after marriage, she continued to work at the PX on an American base at Itazuke for 18 years. Her sisters returned to Canada one by one, but Marge herself did not seriously consider doing so, partly because of the need to make a living (which she was doing successfully in Japan), and partly because she was married to a Japanese national and had children. (Kage, 51).

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Lloyd Kumagai was one of those who, while always entertaining the thought of returning to Canada, never did, largely because of good employment in Japan and marriage to a Japanese national. While working for the Occupation forces as an interpreter, he took night courses at the university in Sendai, with the intention of eventually working for a trading company or airline. After transferring to Tokyo and working for two years at a base there, he found employment at Pan American Airlines and married a Japanese. He was sent to London as the resident Pan American Representative just before the 1960 Olympics. Later he switched to Japan Airlines and eventually started his own travel agency specializing in trips to Australia. When asked by Kage if he had ever considering returning to Canada, he replied:

At the time, I was always unhappy, wondering about going back, wishing that I could. But I feel it was fortunate that Pan American left me in Japan. If I'd settled for jobs with the Occupation, and there hadn't been any work after that, I think I would have come back to Canada... When I was working for Pan American, I got married to a Japanese, so that was another reason for staying in Japan. Besides, the conditions were improving, and I'd gotten better at using the language, so I was getting to be just like one of them" (Kage, 61-65).

Marge Ikebe is an unusual case as she left Japan and spent several years living in Canada and the US before returning to Japan and settling down permanently. Marge was fortunate to be well educated. After finishing Japanese middle school, she attended Canadian Academy in Kobe and Doshisha University in Kyoto. In 1957-1959 she studied at the University of British Columbia, and in 1960 married Nobuo Ikebe who had been born in Japan but was working in Vancouver for a Tokyo-based trading company. They subsequently transferred to Los Angeles where they lived for about eight years, after which they returned to Japan where she cared for her ill mother-in-law and worked for an auditing firm until she retired in 1989 (Kage, 71).

Despite having spent so much time in North America, Marge said she preferred living in Tokyo where she had spent the longest amount of time as she liked the well-ordered society and comfort although experiencing some difficulties in social relations. Yet, despite her outspoken and direct personality, she did not feel that she was treated as an outsider, noting that foreign women are more likely to be accepted with their differences than foreign men. Despite having many friends in North America, she told Kage that, as she faced old age and the need for medical care, she intended to stay in Japan with her Japanese husband (Kage, 75).

Redress Meetings, Starting Association of Japanese Canadians in Japan

Many exiles who had been friends in the internment camps and intended to stay in touch had unfortunately lost contact with each other during the process of being exiled to Japan. The redress explanation meetings held in various places in Japan in 1988 thus became an opportunity to re-unite with old friends with whom they had not been in touch for more than 40 years, and an association of exiles to maintain contact and share information with each other was started in that year Tokyo, followed by another one in Kansai (Kage, 60).

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Marge Ikebe, an exile who had spent several years in Canada and the US before returning to Japan, attended a meeting of the association in Tokyo in 1988. Noticing that many of the elderly members did not know how to do the paperwork for receiving their redress compensation, she made it her mission to help them, travelling several times to Kansai to do so and also responding to requests for assistance from the Canadian embassy in Tokyo (Kage, 74).

Over time, active membership in the Association of Japanese Canadians declined and in the mid-1990s it evolved into a mainly social club. Eventually the group in Tokyo disbanded although, according to Katie Tanaka, as of 2005, women from Tokyo continued to gather regularly at her home in Kamakura. The Kansai group continued longer, which Kage attributed to “the involvement of enthusiastic leaders such as Tom Mizuguchi and Tak Matsuba”¹⁷ (Kage, 60-61).

Their Ambiguous Sense of National and Cultural Identity

A very interesting question about those who stayed in Japan concerns their own sense of national and cultural identity after having lived in Japan and away from Canada so long. Did they eventually come to feel more Japanese than Canadian, and if so, to what degree did they feel Japanese and/or Canadian? One would naturally expect answers to these questions to vary depending on factors such as one’s childhood memories of Canada, one’s age at the time of moving to Japan, the kinds of experiences one had after moving to Japan, one’s individual personality, and so on.

Kage got a wide spectrum of responses regarding these issues. Some felt within themselves that they had become just like Japanese but were sometimes reminded by the Japanese around them that they still had an element of foreignness, whether in their mannerisms or their way of speaking Japanese, even if they spoke it at a native level. Others said they felt that they still had elements of both identities, while some expressed their felt identity as neither Japanese nor Canadian, but something “in-between” that just superficially appears to be Japanese (Kage, 67).

Marie Katsuno was exiled as a young adult and stayed in Japan after the Occupation until finally moving to Canada many years later. Born in Vancouver 1923, she was already 23 when exiled. She felt frustration when she first arrived in Japan, but with her positive spirit of adventure decided to try to make the most of the situation. After working for the Occupation forces, she found employment with Northwest Orient Airlines in Tokyo before working for Seattle-based trading where she met her husband, a second-generation Japanese American. Later, as Japan’s economy continued to improve, she found work as a freelance interpreter and reporter for international conferences. In 1994 she and her husband moved to Vancouver.

At a 1992 exile homecoming held in Canada, she expressed positive feelings toward her experience of living in Japan and dealing with both cultures, while noting that she, already a

¹⁷ as reported in the May 2008 number of the *Nikkei Voice*, a bilingual newspaper based in Toronto.” Kage, 60-61).

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young adult when exiled to Japan, had not fully assimilated into Japanese culture. She also admitted that she frequently felt homesickness and longing for Canada while living in Japan:

Many Japanese Canadians went to Japan at an early age and could therefore become integrated into life there. They have assimilated into it and are very well accepted. In my age bracket, however, we strive to blend and harmonize two different cultures. This has been a stimulating and often enjoyable experience for us over the years... I have always felt very Canadian, and I look across the Pacific Ocean towards Canada as my other home—sometimes even with a feeling of homesickness. (Kage 96).

Lloyd Kumagai, who led a successful career in Japan and seemed to be quite well integrated, was sometimes reminded by the offhand comments of Japanese people that he was still somehow different from Japanese:

Even if I forget that I'm a Canadian, people around me say that "Lloyd is a Canadian," and they know that in the business world. In Japan, people I meet for the first time say, after we've finished talking business, "Were you born in a foreign country?" or "Have you ever lived for a long time abroad?" I don't know if it shows in the way I speak Japanese, or the way I look, but there must be some reason for questions like that (Kage, 67).

Kage also briefly notes the comments of a few other exiles who stayed in Japan which indicate a strong sense of ambiguity and ambivalence toward their felt identity. George Nakano described it as "We're in between. We're not Canadians and we're not Japanese," John Kawakami as, "I'm Japanese, but not Japanese," and Tom Mizuguchi as "Neither one nor the other." (Kage, 67)

Kage included the outlier example of Hideo Nose who, in his quest to fit into Japanese society and gain approval from the Japanese people around him, deliberately made strong efforts to perfectly master Japanese language and achieve complete assimilation with Japanese culture, even to the point of seeming to deny his original identity as a Canadian. Rarely feeling any wish to return to Canada, he considered Japan his "first homeland" and Canada his "second one" (Kage, p. 76-80). Kage noted of Hideo that, during the interview, "His demeanor, his mode of speech, and his outlook gave the impression that he was absolutely a mainstream Japanese of his generation; in other words, he showed no sign of being a Nissei" (Kage, 76). Even his Japanese wife said he lacked the characteristics commonly seen in other second generation Japanese Canadians in Japan and could pass for an ordinary Japanese. This apparent desire to deny one's Canadian identity and completely replace it with Japanese identity was unique among the exiles interviewed by Kage.

Building on the oral histories of the exiles interviewed by Kage, the remaining chapters of this book will focus on the life histories of Japanese Canadian exiles interviewed by Stan Kirk between 2016 and 2025.

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Chapter 2: Recollections of Exiles Interviewed by Kirk—Those Who Eventually Returned to Canada

Basil Izumi

Basil Tadashi Izumi was born April 25, 1937, in Vancouver General Hospital. He has two younger sisters, both of whom were born during the internment. The first, Megumi Grace, was born on April 22, 1944, in New Denver hospital, and the second, Emiko, on August 6, 1945, in Lemon Creek.

Basil's mother, May Ume Shiga, was born in Vancouver in 1915. Her parents were from Kochi Prefecture on the island of Shikoku. At some point after moving to Canada, they converted to Christianity at the Holy Cross Anglican Mission. May's mother soon became a pianist at the church and her father also worked there as the custodian. They settled in the Powell Street area and ran a small store.

Basil's father, Tadao John Izumi, was born in 1910 in Shimasato,¹⁸ a small coastal village in Wakayama. His parents owned land near Shimasato where they engaged in small scale farming. He came to Canada by himself when he was nineteen. At the invitation of a friend James Shingo Murakami,¹⁹ John attended the Holy Cross Anglican Mission and soon was converted and baptized. This was where he met and married with May. After arriving in Canada, he first worked briefly as a fisherman for Celtic Cannery but wanted to become a photographer so began an apprenticeship at the Campbell Studio where he developed a close relationship with the owner, Mr. Campbell. John and May lived in various places during their time in Vancouver including Powell Street, Cordova Street, and Nelson Street (east of Granville). It appears that they generally enjoyed their life within the Japanese Canadian community in Vancouver.

Basil attended Sunday school and kindergarten at the Holy Cross Mission and has one particularly pleasant memory of meeting his kindergarten teacher (and godmother), Miss Margaret Foster while commuting to the kindergarten on the streetcar. He has several pictures of his kindergarten classmates but does not remember them by name as he saw them again after being uprooted from Vancouver.

Uprooting and Internment

Basil had just graduated from kindergarten when the war started. His father John was initially sent with the other able-bodied young men to work on a road camp while Basil and his mother May were taken directly from Vancouver to the Slocan City internment camp in eastern BC. John joined them there later. Like most of the other Japanese Canadian children, Basil's

¹⁸ Shimasato is located quite far from Mio Village (where most of the Wakayama immigrants originated) but very near a traditional whaling village called Taiji, which has become internationally famous and controversial in recent years due to its annual dolphin hunt.

¹⁹ For a concise bio of Japanese Canadian photographer James Shingo Murakami, see [*Postview: The Newsletter of the Vancouver Postcard Club*](#), December, 2011, p. 5. Accessed June 13, 2025.

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memories of this period are very positive and mostly revolve around enjoying school²⁰ and nature and playing with his friends.

Cameras were among the property items that the government had confiscated from Japanese Canadians before the internment, and they were also officially banned from the camps. However, as time passed some of the officials in charge of the camps tended to become lax in enforcing these rules and turned a blind eye to some minor infractions, including the possession of cameras and taking photos.²¹ Mr. Campbell, John's employer in Vancouver, brought John's cameras to the camp and gave them to him. John wanted to move around and record life in the various camps with his cameras, and it seems he was able to receive official permission to do so, so over the remainder of the internment period the Izumi family moved from camp to camp in the Slocan Late area. Their first move was to New Denver, followed by Nelson Ranch, Harris Ranch, and lastly Bay Farm.

Exile to Japan

John and May were among those Japanese Canadians who made the difficult choice of exile to Japan. Their reasons for doing so and which of them made the final decision are still rather unclear to their children. The eldest daughter Megumi speculates that it was John who made the decision as seems to be indicated by his diary:

I'm not sure why. Perhaps it was Father who decided as Mother had been born and raised in Canada. She had siblings there. She had neither close relatives nor acquaintances here in Japan.... Father's parents were still alive in his hometown... It is written here in his diary... Every day he was wrestling with the decision whether to stay in Canada or return to Japan, and finally made a sudden gut-decision to return. He wrote about it here in his diary. I think he really wrestled with the decision and wasn't sure what to do.

Basil does not recall hearing his parents talking at the time about the reasons why they chose exile. He does not remember them being particularly worried about the welfare of relatives in Japan, one compelling reason for many other families to accept exile. Years later his mother told him that she was the one who made the decision, and he speculates, "I guess she chose to go to Japan because she was pissed off at how the Canadian government had treated us. No matter how hard my two aunts and grandmother tried to stop her from going, unfortunately we went."

The Izumi family went to Japan aboard the General Meigs, the largest of three ships chartered by the Canadian government for the deportations of Japanese Canadians. Basil was nine years old at the time, Megumi was two, and the youngest child, Emiko, experienced her first birthday during the trip. Basil recalls being sea sick during the voyage to Japan. One day, after he began to feel better, he wandered up to the galley and met a black man working there who befriended him. Subsequently, Basil would occasionally go up and see him late at night and he would give Basil something to eat. "Whenever I missed my meal, he was there and I just had to go and see him and he would feed me. It didn't happen very often." Basil doesn't remember much else about the voyage.

²⁰ Moritsugu (2001) contains numerous testimonials from students and teachers about the hardships and the good memories regarding the schools in the internment camps, and how well the teachers did in spite of their challenging circumstances.

²¹ Kunimoto (2004), 135-6 describes some possible reasons for this.

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The ship arrived in Yokosuka and the exiles were transferred to Uraga Repatriation Center, where they stayed while arrangements were being made for transportation to John's home village, Shimosato. Basil recalls that the weather was very hot. He remembers seeing the wreckage of airplanes and ships which had been bombed and sunk in the harbor. The quality of the food they received at the repatriation center was extremely poor. He recalls, "The part that scared the hell out of me was seeing wiggly bugs in the food. It was a kind of stew with rice, and on top of that they had *fukujinzuke* pickles—my first time to taste *fukujinzuke* which I still make from time to time. We were fed biscuits that were really hard like dog biscuits—it was a good thing I had strong teeth back then. We survived the food and fortunately did not get food poisoning or anything like that."

Megumi has a very vague memory of the repatriation center, specifically being surrounded by a lot of people whose way of speaking seemed very strange to her. She even remembers the people's faces though she does not recall the bad food. She also remembers looking up at the moon, longing for Canada and crying. Several days later they made the journey by train to John's home village in Wakayama, Shimosato.

Basil has few memories of the trip or the conditions in the train, but does recall that when the train went through a tunnel there was a very strong unpleasant smell of coal smoke which came in through the windows. He also recalls making one stop somewhere during the journey and transferring to another train.

Early Childhood in Shimosato

After arriving in Shimosato they lived with John's parents. May, who had been born and raised in Canada, experienced an extremely difficult relationship with John's mother. Megumi recalls her mother trying hard to please her mother-in-law, and in particular an occasion when May dressed herself and her daughters in kimonos, perhaps in an attempt to win her approval. These efforts failed, and within a few months May left the family in Shimosato and went to work as a translator, simultaneous interpreter, and typist for the American Occupation Forces at various bases in Osaka, Kyoto and Otsu.

When Basil's family moved to Japan, his Japanese speaking level was still not very high, and he couldn't read *kanji* (Chinese characters). Studying Japanese had been officially forbidden in the camps although done secretly. He recalls that they did have "a sort of underground Japanese schools" in the internment camps which used really old school textbooks, but he didn't progress beyond the primary level. Due to his limited Japanese, he was moved back to grade one although he was nine years old (at that time Japanese kids started grade one at eight years of age, so he was only one year behind). He says, "I was ok at math, but *soroban* was a lost cause for me and I never used it again." He doesn't think he had a particularly difficult time communicating with teachers or classmates: "I was more English orientated, but held my own in Japanese."

After May left, John continued to live with the children in Shimosato but was often away from the home due to his photography business and other activities. Basil remembers his father "coming and going" but does not recall specifically what kind of work he was doing. John had enjoyed a successful career as a photographer in Vancouver and had taken numerous photos of life in the internment camps, and he was able to continue his photography work after returning to Shimosato. Cameras were precious items in postwar Japan so people with money requested his services and paid him well. The sisters recall him converting a closet in his parents' house into a

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photo developing room. He was good at taking photographs of people in natural settings but not qualified to take formal portrait photographs in Japan. Megumi explains:

He could not do formal portraits such as weddings because that required the photographer to be able to specially arrange the bride's kimono...Japanese photographers must be able to pay attention to small details such as arranging the hem and sleeves of the kimono and doing so in such a way as to properly show the pattern and so on, but Father did not know how to do that. So, instead he was hired by various people to take photos that showed them in natural situations. He took color photographs and he added colors to black and white photographs, and he received high satisfaction from his customers.

Apparently John was very strict and short-tempered towards the children, angrily scolding them when they tried to enter his photo developing room. He was often out of the house due to his photography business and his frequent drinking with relatives and friends. Megumi says, "It was really hard for us kids. Father, although he was busy with his work, often went drinking with village people. Many of his relatives lived nearby and he would take them by train to Katsura, which was several stops away. I heard they would go there to drink and spend money."

Some of children's strongest memories of Shimosato concern their paternal grandmother. To them she was a stern and frightening figure and did not help much with their care. At first, most of her anger was directed at her daughter-in-law May, perhaps due in part to the strict expectations Japanese mothers-in-law in that time had of their daughters-in-law. May, who was born and raised in Canada, seems to have found these expectations impossible to live up to, no matter how hard she tried.

When May left the family to work for the occupying forces, her mother-in-law became more upset and directed much of her anger at the children. Basil recalls her being prone to angry outbursts. Emiko recalls often being scolded by her for just eating food and remembers her even refusing to give the children treats sent to them by their mother: "Grandmother would not allow us to eat even one of the canned cookies mother sent for us after she had left for Osaka. We had cousins in Katsura, so she gave the cookies to them instead, even though Mother had sent them for us. We never forgot that."

In contrast, the sisters' early memories of their older brother Basil and his care of them are very fond. Because May had left and John was often out of the house, Basil took on much of the role of a surrogate parent, such as standing in line to receive food rations for the family, feeding his sisters, and even changing and washing their diapers. Megumi specifically recalls Basil mixing a flour-like material with water to make a chewy substance and giving it to her as a kind of chewing gum. She adds, "Basil really took care of us, really! ...We remember receiving sweets and so on from Basil. Basil always went to receive the rations. Once, as a prank, he tricked us into biting into some soap he had received that he pretended was a kind of sweets."

Basil does not recall experiencing any serious shortage of food during this time, nor of his family being resented by his relatives and other people in the village as many other exiles were. He says,

"If my relatives resented us, it went over my head. I didn't pay too much attention — I just did my usual things — went to school, went fishing, swam in the ocean, did some skin diving, made a homemade spear gun, and caught *ise ebi* (a kind of shrimp). I was able to feed myself with seafood. Sometimes I caught abalone. I was able to swim and catch a lot of stuff. Another time I went fishing in the river. I noticed that I'd caught something and

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brought it up, and at first I thought it was a snake, but the people around me told me that it was an *unagi* (eel), so I took it home and ate it.”

Even as a nine-year-old, in Japan, he was proud of being Canadian, and his trademark was his Toronto Maple Leafs sweater which he wore proudly. He explains:

In those days they did not distinguish between Canada and America and called me an American. I resented being called an American rather than a Canadian, and at least once got into a fight about that. At that time I had long hair, so I had my dad cut it off and I became a bozu (shaved head) like the other kids because the other kids could pull my hair in a fight if it was longer. I got into the normal fights that normal kids get into, but I do not recall being picked on for being a foreigner. I just resented being called an American.²²

Fortunately, he was strong and athletic and found that his baseball skills gained him some respect from the other kids.

Basil's Return to Canada

Perhaps because he was several years older than his sisters, Basil struggled the most trying to adjust to life in Japan. His sisters recall often noticing him reading English books by himself and believe that he was having an especially difficult time fitting into village society. They think this was exacerbated by the severe treatment he received from both his father and his grandmother as the eldest child. His parents eventually realized he was not fitting in well and decided to send him to live with relatives in Canada. He remembers his father saying he thought it would be a good idea for him to return to Canada before he forgot English and became too entrenched in Japan. Megumi says:

Japan seemed to Basil totally different from Canada. The pressure on him was severe. We (his sisters) were still really small...but Basil was seven years older than me so I'm sure it was much harder on him. There was no one to protect us, and mother had left... Mother and father were both absent, so Basil used to wander around aimlessly among the adults. He could understand when someone was angry at him, but not when he was being praised. At that time Father was very strict toward Basil. I remember him being angry... Basil had nowhere to go.

Hence, in 1949, at the age of 12, after three years of living with his father and younger sisters in Shimosato, Basil returned to Canada, sponsored by his grandmother and aunts. At that time Megumi and Emiko were five and four years old respectively. May made arrangements for him to travel to Canada with three young men who were going to Kelowna, which is located near Vernon where his grandmother and aunts were living. The ship stopped over for one day at Hawaii, then landed in San Francisco. During this voyage, Basil experienced the very surprising coincidence of meeting the same black man who had worked in the galley and had befriended and fed him during the voyage to Japan on the *General Meigs* several years earlier. Amazingly, he still remembered Basil. Basil and his three companions stayed in San Francisco for several days until they could get a booking on the train (Southern Pacific Line) from Oakland to

²² Basil seems to downplay the discriminatory and racist nuance of being an '*America-jin*', perhaps because of his young age at the time. Older child-exiles who were called this strongly took it as an intentional bullying insult and some were severely traumatized and avoided going to school, for example, George Kawabata (Tanaka, 21).

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Portland, where they transferred to Northern Pacific Line and went on to Vancouver, and finally on to their destinations in Kelowna and Vernon.

Life in Canada

Basil stayed with his grandmother and aunts in Vernon from 1949 till they moved to Vancouver in 1954. He says, "At first, during the internment, they had been at Mento Mine outside of Lilloet, BC, at one of the *self-supporting sites*. My other aunt had stayed in east Lilloet along with my grandmother and grandfather. My grandfather had passed way from old age in Lilloet in 1944. When the war ended, both my aunts' families and my grandmother moved to Vernon, BC. There were quite a few Japanese Canadian families there before the war working as farmers and orchardists and growing fruits of all sorts." While living in Vernon, Basil, his aunts and grandmother used to attend All Saints Anglican Church and walked about an hour and a half to get there.

During his time in Vernon, Basil learned that his father's old friend, James Shingo Murakami, who, like Basil's aunts and grandparents also spent the war years in Lilloet, had recently moved to Vernon where he had set up a new photography business. Basil occasionally went to the shop and visited with Murakami, who gave him news about how his father was doing in Japan. Basil recalls that there were also some Japanese Canadians living outside Kelowna, a larger town not far from Vernon. There, in contrast to Vernon, anti-Japanese sentiment was much stronger. One of them later told Basil that he didn't go into town unless necessary due to the severe racism which was even worse than in Vancouver.²³

When Basil's aunt and grandmother moved to Vancouver in 1954, he moved with them, but soon found well-paying work in the forestry industry in the town of Devine and dropped out of high school. He explains, "The sawmill there was worked by a lot of Japanese who had come from the camps around Lilloet³ as well as some who came to Canada after the war. Later they built a planer mill in Devine. In 1954 I went up there and started working. I was seventeen years old, it was my first major job, and I stuck it out for five years."

In 1959, Basil stopped working in the mill and left Devine for Vancouver in order to finish high school in a school that specialized in adults who had interrupted their education. He completed the remaining two years of high school in one year, then went to North Vancouver High School to take his senior matriculation (grade 13). Then he enrolled in the teacher's college in UBC. He earned his teacher certificate after two years, then took a third year and got his EA certificate (elementary advanced). He got his first teaching job in Chetland in the Dawson Creek school district (Peace River area), where he taught elementary school for two years, after which he again returned to Vancouver.

Basil got married in August of 1967. His wife Etsuko (Kokubo) is also Japanese Canadian and has roots in Shiga Prefecture, near Hikone City. Coincidentally, her family and Basil's family had both been on the same ship (*General Meigs*) going to Japan, but did not know each other at that time. She was still a baby when her family had gone to Japan, and had stayed in Japan longer than Basil, eventually returning to Canada with her whole family in 1952.

²³ See Tatchel, 29-34. This was also said to the writer by Ross Tamagi, a member of Holy Cross Church who grew up near Kelowna.

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Basil first met Etsuko at church one summer while boarding in East Vancouver and taking a summer course. He had gotten together with his father's old friend Shingo Murakami, who invited him to a church service and then to his garden party which was usually held after the church services. Shingo mentioned to Basil that he was going to introduce him to a lady who would also be at the party. When Basil arrived, he noticed a young lady arranging flowers, immediately felt attracted to her, and they were soon dating, so no introduction was needed. Basil has a very vivid memory of surviving a scary car accident shortly after their engagement. At the time he was teaching in Creston, a town in eastern BC. He had made arrangements to meet up with Etsuko in Penticton, which was a good midway meeting point located in central BC. Unfortunately, while driving to Penticton to meet her, he lost control of the car and it plunged about 100 meters into a ravine, rolling over several times. Basil was not wearing a seatbelt but somehow was able to hold onto the steering wheel and stay inside the car until it stopped rolling. Amazingly, he had only "cuts and bruises" and, while waiting in the hospital to be treated he was able to phone Etsuko's family in Vancouver to inform her of the situation and cancel the rendezvous. He notes that his survival of this accident caused him to "believe strongly in the existence of guardian angels."

After they got married, Basil and his wife stayed in Vancouver, and he went to work at Eburne Sawmill at the foot of Marine Drive. This sawmill paid much better than the BC interior sawmills. Meanwhile he was phoning around various school districts in BC looking for teaching work. One of the school districts he had applied to (Ashcroft district in south Caribou) called him, and they moved to nearby Cache Creek. From the very start, Basil found himself working as a relief teacher for the principal of Ashcroft Elementary School in the mornings and also as a relief teacher for the principal of the Cache Creek Elementary School in the afternoons. Soon there was a full time opening in Ashcroft, then an opening in Spences Bridge, where they stayed until their two children started school. He resigned from that position and moved back to Vancouver due to concern about the education of their two children, a girl and a boy. As he puts it, "We didn't want our kids to start school in a two-room rural school." Unfortunately, he found that once they were back in Vancouver it was hard to get back into a fulltime teaching career again, so he worked as a substitute teacher for several years.

Basil enjoyed playing sports such as baseball and soccer with his students. His own background as a minority and his past hardships contributed positively to his teaching career. As many of his students were indigenous peoples, he was able to use his difficult experiences as a Japanese Canadian to encourage these students to rise above their circumstances by working harder and not giving in to discouragement.

One day he learned a fish cannery company (Canada Packers at Steveston) was looking for someone who could speak Japanese to work in the salmon roe operation. Japan was their main export market. Basil successfully applied for this position and continued for a long time until Canada Packers closed, at which time he transferred to a cannery operated by Canadian Fish at the foot of Main Street in Vancouver. He continued there for about 20 years. He retired when he was 67, two years later than normal retirement age as the company requested him to stay on.

Basil and the Holy Cross Anglican Church

As noted previously, Basil's parents had both been active members of the Holy Cross Anglican mission, and as a small child he had attended Sunday school and kindergarten there before the internment. Upon returning to Canada from Japan, he attended the Anglican Church in Vernon

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with his aunt and grandmother. When they moved to North Vancouver²⁴ in 1954 they began attending a nearby Anglican Church, Saint John the Evangelist.

In contrast to those Japanese Canadian Anglicans who were excluded from worshipping at Anglican Churches after returning to the west coast after the war,²⁵ Basil does not recall feeling any discrimination there, and has good memories of being involved in the various activities of the church youth group. Specifically, he recalls going berry picking with them in order to raise money to buy a heifer for an Anglican missionary in Japan who was trying to establish a dairy farm there. This involvement continued until he left Vancouver to work in the sawmill in Devine for five years.

At some point Basil began to gravitate back towards the church of his earliest childhood, Holy Cross Mission. Even while working as a teacher in eastern BC, he would occasionally spend a weekend in Vancouver and attend Holy Cross at its post-war location.²⁶ He was married there in 1967, and later had his two children baptized there. When he and his family moved back to Vancouver permanently (around 1985), he was able to attend more regularly, except for the summer holidays when he would go salmon fishing with his father-in-law who owned a trawler in Steveston. After the church moved to its present building in 1989, he steadily became more involved in administration of the building and property.

Due to the uprooting, internment, dispersal, dispossession of church property, and various other trials that Holy Cross has gone through in more recent years, Basil is the only remaining member who was involved in Holy Cross (albeit as a small child) before the war. He is known by other members as a constant “pillar” of the church, playing a key role as it has struggled to survive the more recent upheavals mentioned in the first chapter.

In the 1980s a memorial garden containing a columbarium was built next to the church, and Basil was placed in charge of it in about 1990. Since then he has made its care his special responsibility, coming early every Sunday morning and opening it before the other congregants arrive. He still to be deeply involved in administration of the church and the memorial garden.

In 2010 the Diocese of New Westminster presented Basil with the ODNW (Order of the Diocese of New Westminster), the purpose of which is to “honor and give special recognition to members of the Diocese who have given outstanding service over a significant period of time in their volunteer ministry.” In announcing the award, the Diocese home page contains the following statement: “Basil has been a faithful member and leader in the parish for many years. When the parish went through a very difficult time, Basil was one of the few who chose to

²⁴ North Vancouver is continues relatively distant from the Powell Street area and is also separated from central Vancouver by a strait. This would explain why Basil and his aunt and grandmother chose to attend a nearby Anglican Church rather rejoin the Holy Cross Mission which at this time had just been reestablished by Rev. Gale

²⁵ For the story of the Murakami family being told to stop attending the Anglican church her family had helped build on Saltspring Island, see Patricia E. Roy, *An Ambiguous Relationship: Anglicans and the Japanese in British Columbia, 1902-1949*. BC Studies No. 192: Nikkei History: Winter 2016 (p. 124) and Rose Murakami, *Ganbaru: The Murakami Family of Salt Spring Island* (Salt Spring Island: Japanese Garden Society 2005), p.33.

²⁶ The original Holy Cross Mission and other Japanese Canadian Anglican properties in Vancouver had been sold off during the war without the consent of the Japanese Canadian members who had funded and built them. The proceeds were placed in the fund that paid the bishop’s salary. See Tatchel, Gregory R. *Relinquished: The Seat of Deitie Supream Dispossess*. M.Div. Thesis, Vancouver School of Theology, 2009.

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remain with the parish. He accepted the appointment by the Bishop to the position of Bishop's Warden of the parish, a position he still holds today."²⁷

Reuniting with Mother and Sisters

When Basil returned to Canada in 1949 at the age of twelve, he left the rest of his family behind in Japan. At that time his younger sisters were just four and five years old. He occasionally corresponded with his mother, who also corresponded with her sisters and mother with whom Basil was living in Canada. He did not have direct correspondence with his father, but used to visit with Shingo Murakami, his father's old friend, who occasionally informed him how his father was doing. He also recalls receiving some news of his father from the daughter of Mr. Campbell, his father's previous boss at Campbell Photography Studio.

At some time after Basil came to Canada, his parents divorced. Because this information was kept from him by his mother, aunts and grandmother, he did not learn about it until several years after the fact. He is not sure whether the divorce was primarily due to the stress of what they had been through in Canada (the uprooting, internment, and deportation), their long separation while his mother was away working in Osaka, her conflicts with her mother-in-law, or some other reasons. In any case, both of Basil's parents became romantically involved with other partners and consequently Basil has a half-brother on his mother's side and a half-sister on his father's side.

After coming back to Canada at age 12, Basil never saw his father again. He became ill with cancer and passed away in 1983. When Basil learned that his father was seriously ill, he wrote him a long letter, expressing among other things his regret for not having been in direct contact with him since leaving Japan and mentioning that he had been receiving news about him from Mr. Murakami and the daughter of Mr. Campbell. The letter was read to his father in the hospital by Basil's mother and sisters who then conveyed back to Basil that tears welled up in his father's eyes and he seemed heartbroken. Later his sisters sent him his father's diary and photograph collection.

Basil's mother visited Canada twice and stayed with Basil's family in Vancouver, once in the mid-seventies and again around 1985. During her visits, she expressed a desire to stay permanently in Canada and live with his family. However, both her sisters strongly advised Basil against it. As she was frequently talking about her grandchildren she had left behind in Japan, and due to her headstrong personality and the fact that she had been the family member who strongly wished to go to Japan after the war, they were concerned that there would be various problems if she stayed in Canada permanently.

Both of Basil's sisters still reside in Japan.²⁸ Megumi married into a family known for making futons and now lives in Hirakata, a small city near Osaka. The husband of Emiko worked designing baseball caps and they live in Sakai City which is also near Osaka. Both sisters' husbands are now retired. Basil did not have much contact with them right after he came back to Canada, but through his correspondence at that time with his mother was kept informed of what was happening and how the family members were doing in Japan. Both sisters visited Canada in

²⁷ See *The ODNW 2010 Recipients* (<https://www.vancouver.anglican.ca/news/the-odnw-2010-recipients#:~:text=for%20the%20Lord.-,Mr.,James%2C%20Vancouver>)

²⁸ The story of the Izumi family in Japan, especially after Basil left them to return to Canada, is told in detail in from the perspective of Basil's sisters in the following chapter about the exiles who stayed in Japan.

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1993 and Basil rented a van and took them around to the various camps in which they had been incarcerated as children.

Basil himself was never enthusiastic about going back to Japan even for a visit and thinks that this may have been partly due to some form of resentment against Japan for how it started and conducted the war, as well as the fact that Japan has not yet wholeheartedly apologized to the world. However, he felt his attitude change somewhat when his daughter and a cousin visited Japan in 1992. In 1994 Basil visited Japan himself with his son and stayed with his sisters, who showed them around various places including Shimasato, his father's home *village*. He felt glad afterwards that he had made this trip despite his earlier misgivings.

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Kazuko Makihara

Birth and Childhood until the War

Kazuko (Katy) Makihara (nee Fukuhara) was born on September 26, 1933 in her parents' home near Vancouver Cannery on Sea Island. She had an older sister, Hisaye, a younger sister, Judy, and a younger brother, Akio. Kazuko's parents were from Onomichi, Hiroshima. Her father had first come to Canada when he was adopted by a childless aunt and uncle who were fishermen there. Like his adoptive father, he worked as a fisherman.

At some point he went back to Japan to find a wife and returned with his bride. They lived on Sea Island. Kazuko's father had his own boat which he had been given by his adoptive father. The fishing business went well for him, and he intended to stay permanently in Canada. Economically they were well established because Kazuko's grandparents had been in Canada for a relatively long time and were successful at fishing. Kazuko remembers her father as very industrious but quiet. He was quite a heavy drinker, and her mother used to brew a lot of rice liquor for him at home. In contrast to her father, Kazuko's mother was more friendly and outgoing but spoke her opinions frankly, which occasionally led to quarreling with family members.

Kazuko attended a Canadian public kindergarten on Sea Island. She enjoyed school life, and her ambition was to be a kindergarten teacher as she liked helping people. Unlike many other kids of her age group, Kazuko did not attend a Japanese language school, and only learned Japanese because her parents spoke it at home. Her parents were too busy to teach her how to read and write in Japanese, so she only learned how to speak it. Her first language was Japanese as her family and all her good friends were Japanese, but she also spoke English well because she had to speak it in the public school.

Uprooting, Dispossession, and Incarceration

Kazuko recalls that, at the time of the uprooting, her family were given only twenty-four hours to leave their home and her mother told her to quickly pack her own clothes. The police were at the door waiting for them to leave, so there was no time to waste. It happened so quickly they had no chance to ask friends to take care of their property or any of the things they left behind, so they lost everything. She says, "All our property and goods were confiscated: house, boat, everything. The RCMP were there, so although father was shocked at what was happening to them, there was nothing he could do."

Kazuko's father was one of about 700 Japanese Canadian men incarcerated in POW camps in eastern Canada. She never learned why as he never talked about it. She still remembers watching him being taken away by the RCMP. They would not see him again until about four years later when they boarded the General Meigs to go to Japan.

At first, Kazuko, her mother, and her siblings were confined in a livestock building at the Pacific National Exhibition (PNE) grounds in Vancouver. After enduring three awful months

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there, they were sent by train to the Bay Farm internment camp. Kazuko was quite frail as a child and became ill on the train from Vancouver to Slocan City. When they finally arrived at Bay Farm, they first lived in an old apartment while the houses were being constructed. Eventually they moved to a house on Sixth Avenue which consisted of only two bedrooms and a kitchen. The houses were built in rows, and each house had an outside toilet.

There was a rule that, if you had at least seven family members, you were allowed to have a whole house to yourselves, whereas if you had less, you had to share a house with another family. Kazuko's family at the time consisted of the mother and four children, so, in order to qualify for their own house, they "borrowed" the names of two children from a larger family, the Kamitakaharas. Actually, the "borrowed children" continued to live with their own family, so it was nothing more than a convenient arrangement on paper that enabled Kazuko's family to have their own little house..

There was no running water inside the buildings in the camp. The water tap, like the toilet, was outside. During the cold winter season they would put a bucket of water on the stove at night to keep it from freezing. They used some of this water to make breakfast in the morning. The rest they used as a toilet during the night, and then took it outside for disposal in the morning. Kazuko remembers there was lots of snow, but they were just kids so didn't mind as much as the adults. However, it was a much colder climate than what they were used to in Vancouver.

At the beginning it was hard to eat properly although they could buy some basic foods at the government-run grocery store. The internees had to share their various skills and improvise in order to live. For example, carpenters would lend their skills to families who needed to repair or renovate their houses. "We had to make everything ourselves," says Kazuko. During the first summer they started raising their own vegetables. Later the internees were able to set up a machine for making tofu, and also start a bakery. Eventually they even built their own public bath. Kazuko is still amazed at what they became able to do. Many housewives took sewing classes, among whom was Kazuko's mother.

Exile and Life in Post-War Japan

Kazuko was thirteen years old when her family was exiled to Japan. Her parents made the difficult choice of exile to Japan because their kids were still small and her father felt a strong responsibility to take care of his adoptive mother who was still alive and living in Onomichi. His adoptive parents had previously moved from Canada back to Onomichi before the war, had bought a house and ran a small restaurant there. His adoptive father had died during the war, and his adoptive mother was managing the restaurant by herself. Kazuko's father also thought there was no use in staying in Canada with small kids. She says, "He had lost everything in Canada, so what could he do there?"

The family went to Japan on the General Meigs. Kazuko doesn't remember much about the journey. They landed at Yokosuka and were held in the Uraga repatriation center, which, she remembers, was fenced around so they couldn't get out. She can't remember exactly what food

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they received there, but does recall that they were not fed properly, and had to boil and eat dandelion greens as a vegetable.

After several days in the repatriation center, they went to Onomichi by train. The conditions on the train were terrible. Kazuko recalls that it was extremely crowded with soldiers and expats who were also returning from the colonies to Japan. There were no open seats, and the soldiers would not give up their seats for the civilian passengers. Soldiers just jumped on the train and showed no regard for the children like Kazuko. It was difficult to even move. Kazuko jokes that her future husband could have been one of those rude soldiers as he was nine years older than her and was returning from China about this same time.

Kazuko recalls the strong anger she and her siblings were feeling about being deported to Japan just like foreigners even though they had been born in Canada. She says, “We were all very upset at Canada, and we kept saying that we were Canadian, but that didn’t matter to the government officials because our parents were not Canadian-born.” During the journey, Kazuko’s brother kept crying all the time and refusing the food, and saying he wanted to return to Canada. This continued for some time even after they arrived in Onomichi.

Because the second generation Japanese Canadian exiles could not speak or even clearly understand the local dialect of Onomichi, they found themselves being excluded and being called enemies by many of the local people. Perhaps because they had been better nourished during the war than the local people who were practically starving, they were even told that, since their faces didn’t look Japanese, they could not possibly be real Japanese.

Kazuko’s younger brother started school in grade one, and her younger sister in grade two. Kazuko was supposed to go to high school, but couldn’t understand what the teachers were saying. She was moved from high school back to grade 5, but still could not understand. There was also a severe shortage of textbooks. She quit school after about a year and a half. Her older sister went to work for the American occupation forces at the base in Kure, and she recommended that Kazuko do the same.

About that time they learned that a family in Montreal, Canada, wanted to adopt both Kazuko and her older sister. Her parents approved of the older sister going to Montreal, but wanted Kazuko to stay and help them in Japan. Consequently, the older sister went to Montreal after only a short time in Japan, while Kazuko continued to live in Onomichi with her parents. The older sister eventually broke off contact with the family and they never met or heard from her again.

Soon Kazuko briefly did go to work for the American occupation forces. Perhaps because she was only 15 years old, her mother didn’t like it, so she quit and returned to Onomichi after about a year. She didn’t know what to do next. Fortunately, her younger cousins all wanted to learn English from her, so she started to go regularly by bus to their home to teach them. They paid her for it, and also provided her dinner on the days she taught. She continued teaching them English for about three hours per day, two or three days per week, for three or four years, until she got married at age 19. This teaching work helped her maintain her own English skill. Kazuko was

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later told by her uncle that her good teaching enabled one of her younger cousins get a good job in Tokyo due to his above average English ability.

Kazuko's parents were also eventually able to find work after they went back to Japan. Since her mother had taken sewing lessons while in the internment camp and had learned to sew western clothes, she was able to work at home as a seamstress, making western style clothes which were becoming popular in Japan at that time. She was very outgoing and liked to both knit and sew clothes for those around her. Kazuko's father worked delivering ice cube boxes to various restaurants. Kazuko thinks that he never wanted to return to Canada because of his limited English, and also because he had been dispossessed of all his property (including his fishing boat) in Canada—so he had nothing in Canada to go back to.

Sadly, they later divorced. Before the uprooting and incarceration in the internment camp, they had been a prosperous family and a social and economic hub for other families in the community. Kazuko believes the long separation and trauma her parents endured during the incarceration of Japanese Canadians while her father was being held in Angler POW camp was a major reason for the eventual breakdown of their marriage. She notes that after the incarceration and return to Japan, their relationship was never the same, and they no longer got along. Her father eventually remarried with a lady from Onomichi and spent the rest of his life there. After the divorce, Kazuko and her siblings, except for her older sister, all gravitated to their mother and even changed their family name from Fukuhara to their mother's maiden name, Momotani.

At age 19 Kazuko married Takeshi Makihara, a former soldier who was nine years older than her. He had worked as a blueprint designer for the Japanese navy and was based in Taiwan during the war. After coming back to Onomichi, he began working for a private sector company and apparently saw Kazuko several times as he passed her house on his way to and from work. Eventually they became acquainted and decided to marry. She jokes, "He was a typical *ishii-atama* (stubborn hard-headed) young Japanese man. I later told him, 'If I were in my 20s and smarter, I would never have married you.'" They had their first child, a boy, in 1952.

They moved to Kobe in 1954 because Takeshi's friend and brother were already living there and had invited them to join them since there were more jobs in Kobe at that time. Takeshi worked for a pearl company, and Kazuko worked in a big luggage store in Kobe's famous Motomachi shopping street. A lot of Americans used to visit Kobe in those days and Kazuko's English skill really helped increase the store's business. She continued this job until she returned to Canada in 1958.

Return to Canada and Building a New Life in Vancouver

Both Kazuko and Takeshi continued working in Kobe and financially supporting the education of Kazuko's younger brother and sister till they finished high school. After graduating, Kazuko's younger brother and sister returned to Canada around 1955. First the younger brother worked for a lumber company and then for Nelson Chocolate in Vancouver and the sister did housework.

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Eventually, Takeshi lost his job in Kobe, and in 1958, Kazuko's younger brother and sister invited Kazuko and Takeshi to join them in Canada. Takeshi wanted to move to Canada at that time, but due to immigration law Kazuko had to move there first and work fulltime for a year in order to qualify to sponsor him as an immigrant.

Almost all of Kazuko's female Japanese Canadian friends in Vancouver were employed as house-workers because it was very difficult for them to find other kinds of employment. She also did housework at first, but wanted a better job, so used her rare days off to search for work at the various department stores. The effort paid off and within a couple months of her arrival she was able to get a job at the Hudson's Bay Company department store, which was a great surprise to both her and her friends who couldn't believe it was possible for a Japanese Canadian to get such a job.

She started as a part time seasonal worker for the Christmas shopping season, but her manager was impressed by her work and soon hired her fulltime. He told her she was so efficient she could do the work of two people. She never experienced being laid off and continued working for Hudson's Bay at various locations around Vancouver for thirty-four years. Her first job was invoicing new merchandise that had just come in, but soon she was doing machine work making price tags, tickets, etc. At that time she still felt that her English was not good enough so she really studied hard. In addition, her work gave her the opportunity to practice speaking English all day. Next, she worked at pricing items for the drugs section. She had to go to work very early in the morning to price the medicines and drug items before the store opened. She recalls, "It was very hard work, but I did it. I'm a person who hates to lose."

She successfully sponsored Takeshi as an immigrant in 1959, a year after her own arrival. She wanted to also sponsor her mother, but due to immigration laws she was unable to do so until three years later when her mother turned 55. Her mother did not want to be in Japan by herself, so they left Kazuko's first son, who was six years old, with her. When he was nine years old, he arrived in Canada together with his grandmother and the family was reunited.

Kazuko gave birth to a daughter in Canada in 1962, ten years after the birth of her son. She recalls feeling very sick every day but didn't know she was pregnant until her doctor told her. She continued to feel sick almost all the time and had to go to the hospital emergency ward often. Her doctor warned her that if she continued to work so hard she might suffer a miscarriage, and she began to occasionally miss work due to illness. At one point, the assistant manager of her department threatened to fire her if she was absent one more time. Perhaps because she felt confident that she was well liked by the senior manager, she stood up to the assistant manager and told him that he wasn't her real boss, and that she would talk directly to the senior manager. When she went to the senior manager, he told her that if she was sick it was fine to take time off and come back whenever she wanted. Fortunately, after that she no longer needed to take any more days off, so it never became a problem again.

Next, she was transferred to the Hudson's Bay branch at Lake City in Burnaby (suburb of Vancouver). As there was no bus route there at that time and she was the only one who could

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drive, she used to give other employees a ride to work. She worked at Lake City for quite a long time. Then the Bay built several other branches, including one near her home, and she worked there until they closed that branch and opened a new one at the Metrotown Shopping Center in Burnaby. Soon after that she became very ill and was diagnosed with genetic diabetes and polymyalgia, so retired at the age of 58. Due to her illness, she started to exercise seriously, eventually became healthy and strong, and went on to lead a very active life in retirement.

Life and Retirement in Canada

As a young man in Onomichi, Kazuko's husband Takeshi had worked as a writer for a religious sect called Nanmyo Horen Gekkyou. This experience helped him hone his Japanese writing skill. Soon after moving to Canada his writing talent was discovered by his friend Gordon Kadota, the founder of the *Geppo* (a monthly bilingual magazine of the Vancouver Japanese Canadian community called *The Bulletin* in English). For many years Takeshi wrote the Japanese section of the *Geppo* every month as volunteer, and was very busy with this three or four late nights each month.

Then a gardening job opened at the Japanese Consul General. At first, it was for only seasonal and for three days per week, but eventually he got hired fulltime. When his writing ability was discovered, he became the main speech writer for the Consul General, who also utilized his artistic talents and got him to make PR posters for various events. He really enjoyed this job and through it made many friends in Vancouver. He also put his numerous skills to work at home, doing all the house renovations and creating a beautiful garden in the yard. He continued working for the Japanese Consul until age 65, retiring in 1990.

By then their five-bedroom house was too big for them as their children had grown up and Kazuko's mother had passed away, so they sold it and moved to a townhouse. Takeshi spent much of his time in retirement playing golf. Kazuko remembers him as a person with a good sense of humor who would think carefully before speaking, was considerate of others, and did his best to serve them. In 1996 he was awarded the Order of the Rising Sun (旭日章) by the Japanese government for his years of service in the Japanese Consulate. He passed away in 2014.

At about the time of Kazuko's retirement, her mother, for whom she had been caring, passed away from breast cancer. As mentioned above, Kazuko herself became very ill from diabetes and polymyalgia, but gradually exercised her way back to good health. Takeshi was "golf-crazy", and he made her learn golf. She says, "I cried but I learned how, and later came to enjoy it." Her first private golf teacher said she would never be a golfer, but her second teacher was good and helped her improve her golf skills a lot.

Her son lives nearby with his wife in the Vancouver suburb of Richmond where is president of a consulting company. Her daughter graduated from the University of British Columbia in Vancouver and now lives in Japan where she is in charge of human resources at a major international theme park.

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After retirement Kazuko continued to attend exercise classes near her home twice a week “with young people, not seniors” and also do line dancing at the Bonsor Recreation Center in Burnaby once a week. She also helped with Bingo for two hours on Saturday mornings at a nearby retirement home and enjoyed taking evening walks with friends.

Following her daughter’s advice that she get out and do some volunteer work in order to stay active after Takeshi’s passing, she first volunteered at Tonarigumi (a Japanese Canadian volunteer organization Vancouver) for over a year until her volunteer work there conflicted with her line dance schedule. Then she met the leader of the Iki Iki program at the Nikkei National Museum & Cultural Centre who asked her to volunteer there all day once a week. After suffering a heart attack in 2018, she had to reduce her activities though she continued to exercise regularly. Presently Kazuko is living in the Nikkei Place Seniors complex located next to the Nikkei National Museum and Cultural Center in Burnaby.

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Hirai Family

This chapter narrates the exile and return story of the Hyoshiro and Fujiye (Fujino) Hirai family, relying mainly on the recollections of the younger of the two sons, Miki Hirai, while also including some recollections gained from a brief interview with the older son, Shig (Shigeru) Hirai and Shig's wife, Akemi (Eto) Hirai.²⁹

Fujiye's father, Sanya Fujino, moved to Canada in 1894 from Oyabu, a small village now part of Hikone city, Shiga prefecture. He found work at the Brunette Sawmill in the Sapperton area of New Westminster, BC. and was put in charge of the Japanese laborers. He also owned a boarding house which accommodated about 20 single laborers, and the family looked after the Japanese men who worked at the sawmill. Fujiye was the second oldest child in the family, with two brothers and three younger sisters. She did not have the opportunity to go to school as she had to stay home doing laundry, cooking, cleaning, and other household tasks in order to help take care of the Japanese men living in their boarding house. However, at age 15 she got her barbering license.

Hyoshiro's father, Sekizo Hirai, moved to Canada in 1906 from Tsuchida, a small village located a few kilometers southeast of Hikone, leaving his wife and children in Japan. He found work on a farm and by 1920 had saved enough money to buy a quarter section of land near Mission, British Columbia. He had four sons. Hyoshiro was the second oldest, born in Tsuchida in 1907. In 1922, Hyoshiro went to Canada to join his father and worked mainly in the sawmills.

Hyoshiro met Fujiye Fujino through the traditional Japanese custom of arranged marriage. After their marriage in 1936, Fujiye continued to work as a barber in Vancouver. Their first son, Shig, was born with the assistance of a midwife in a home near Powell Street on September 9, 1937.

Start of the War, Uprooting, and Internment

When the war started, Fujiye Hirai was still working in a barber shop on Main Street. At that time, things were rapidly becoming worse for the Japanese immigrant community in Vancouver. Her younger son Miki explains:

The war came, and she noticed a lot of changes, she told me, because at the barbershop they kept calling her "Jap." She didn't quite understand what it meant, because even the other Orientals were calling her "Jap," and they were spitting on the windows as they

²⁹ Most of the content of this series is based on personal communication with Miki Hirai, his brother Shig Hirai and Shig's wife Akemi Hirai consisting of three audio-recorded interviews (August 22, 2022 and August 13, 2023 with Miki Hirai; August 23, 2023 with Shig and Akemi Hirai). These interviews will not be cited further. Sources other than these will be cited.

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walked by, and suddenly hardly any customers came in. Nobody dared to walk in — they were scared to walk in.³⁰

Hyoshiro's father Sekizo returned to Japan at some point before the war, leaving Hyoshiro in Canada. Under normal circumstances, Hyoshiro would have been heir to his father's land in Canada. However, this expectation would be overturned by the start of the war. Soon after the start of the war, the Hirai and Fujino families, like other Japanese Canadians, were soon uprooted from their homes, dispossessed of all their property, and sent to internment camps. Miki Hirai explains that his grandfather Sekizo's land "had been all paid up when they took it. Within about ten days they turned around and sold it to somebody else... for around two thirds of the (original) price."³¹

The Hirai family was incarcerated in the Lemon Creek internment camp. Hyoshiro was sent there ahead of his family and helped in the construction of the small houses where the Japanese Canadian families would be forced to live during the war. When his family joined him, they shared a small house with a cousin's family. Their second son, Miki, was born in the hospital in nearby Slocan city on May 22, 1944.

Despite the deep trauma of the uprooting and loss that the adults were experiencing, they made the best they could of their terrible situation and endeavored to shield their children from their pain and give them a normal childhood. Hence, most of the children had mainly happy memories of the internment camps. Shig recalls that, regardless of the difficulties the adults were experiencing, for him as a child "it was the best time of my life."

While Miki was too young at the time remember the internment camp, he does recall his mother talking about her life in Lemon Creek. Ironically, even as an adult, despite the heartbreaking loss of her family's properties and livelihoods, and despite the extremely cold weather and lower standard of living at Lemon Creek, in some ways life there turned out to be better for her than the difficult situation she had left behind in Vancouver. Like her oldest son Shig, she remembered this period as the best time of her life. Miki explains:

Surprisingly enough, according to my mother, she said that was the best time of her life that far...that was the first time she didn't have to work... And there she learned to sew for the first time... so she enjoyed so many things, and she was finally learning something... and she used to cut lots of men's hair there, and everyone like that, so she was appreciated.³²

When faced with the dilemma of whether to choose exile to Japan or dispersion to "east of the rockies," Hyoshiro Hirai chose the former because his father Sekizo, who had previously moved back to Japan and was still there, asked him to do so. Miki explains:

³⁰ Nikkei National Museum and Cultural Centre (2023, September 23) Okaeri-Miki Hirai [YouTube] (3:40~) <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=LlMJJaVOjZ2Y>

³¹ Nikkei National Museum and Cultural Centre (2023, September 23) Okaeri-Miki Hirai [YouTube]. (6:00~) <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=LlMJJaVOjZ2Y>

³² Nikkei National Museum and Cultural Centre (2023, September 23) Okaeri-Miki Hirai [YouTube]. (9:20~) <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=LlMJJaVOjZ2Y>

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What I heard from my parents was that his father told him to come back to Japan. My father was the second son... but the first son had perished in the war. The third son had died from illness. The fourth son was on a Japanese submarine during the war. According to what I heard, the submarine had a mechanical problem and couldn't surface. Eventually they were able to surface, but the war had just ended, and he got caught by an American boat. He became a POW and got sent back to Japan.

Life in Postwar Japan: Hardships and Neighborly Support

Difficult Relations with Relatives

On October 2, 1946, the Hirai family boarded the Marine Falcon, one of three ships chartered by the Canadian government to transport Japanese Canadians to Japan. Miki was two years old and Shig was nine. Shig recalls being seasick every single day of the voyage. He also remembers the terrible food they were given after landing at the repatriation center in Uraga. Of the infamous rancid soup there he quips, "If you say it was soup, then I guess it was soup!" After about two weeks in the repatriation center, they made the arduous train journey to Tsuchida, their father's ancestral village in Shiga Prefecture. Miki says, "That's where the sad story for our family begins."

Although Hyoshiro's father had written a letter asking him to come back to Japan, on his arrival he was shocked to discover that his father's attitude had completely changed and he was no longer welcome. His father even asked him why he came back. Miki says, "By then it was too late—he could not return to Canada." Shig explains that the prevailing attitude of the locals was, "There is no house for you, and nothing to eat, so why did you come over here?"

From then things only became worse. Hyoshiro's father decided that, instead of Hyoshiro, his youngest son, who had just come back alive from the war where he had fought for Japan, would take over the family inheritance, despite Hyoshiro being the eldest surviving son. Miki thinks that his father, on the other hand, was looked down on for having returned from Canada which was an enemy country during the war. As a result, everything the family owned went to the younger brother. Hyoshiro did not receive any land or financial support from his father, despite the fact he had been sending money back from Canada. Economically speaking, he was completely on his own. He even had to buy a rice field from his father in order to provide for the family. Miki explains:

My father had to put up all his savings to pay for a rice field so that our family could have rice although his father had over ten rice fields of his own...My father also had a small vegetable field by the house and he looked after that, and my mother helped — whatever she could do, to make a living.

Due to lack of lodging, the family had to live in a tiny shack near the main house. Hyoshiro didn't say much to his sons about this period, but Miki heard a few stories about it from Fujiye. Relations continued to be very strained with Hyoshiro's parents and relatives. Sometimes the relatives even went so far as to put a board across the outside of the door of the storehouse where

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they were living so that they could not get out. Miki recalls, “My father was so upset, fighting with his dad all the time.”

Fujiye also didn’t talk in much detail about what it was like for her, or about what kind of relationship she had with her Japanese mother-in-law. But she did explain to Miki later that this period was the worst time of her life. She had been born and raised in Canada and had never experienced life in Japan. She wondered aloud, “Why did we ever come to Japan? For what?” Miki explains:

That was a big pressure on my dad, because he was the one who had made the decision to go to Japan. My mother told me it was so bad because she was Canadian-born...She (had) never experienced life in Japan, and especially after the war it was so severe. Everybody could hardly eat... Anyway, life was not good. Shig points out that they were extremely fortunate that their mother was a licensed barber. “Everyone needs a barber — that’s what she said. She put up a sign and right away people came.”

One resident of Tsuchida with fond memories of the Hirai family recalls frequently seeing her set up a chair in front of the Hirai house and give haircuts to the locals and says that she became popular in the village. The family continued living in Tsuchida for about one and a half years. However, the relations with Hyoshiro’s family became so strained that he finally decided to relocate the family to a neighboring village called Taga.

The Family’s Life in Taga

After moving to Taga they rented space in a house where Fujiye opened a barbershop. As she did not have enough money, she took out a loan guaranteed by her older brother in Canada. The barbershop was in the front part of the house, and the family lived in a small tatami room at the back, about four by five square meters. Hyoshiro built a tiny kitchen and equipped it with a small oil stove.

They had no running water so had to use the wells of their next-door neighbors. They also had no bath but were kindly invited by four different neighbors to use theirs. As there was no toilet they likewise had to use their neighbors’ outhouses. They did have electricity (a necessity for a barbershop). Their neighbors were very supportive and friendly. Miki recalls, “They all helped each other so much. I didn’t think anything of it. I thought that was normal!”

In addition to setting up her own barbershop, Fujiye taught the owners of the building, Mr. and Mrs. Miyano, how to do barbering and they both became professional barbers.³³ While

³³ Even after the Hirai family had left for Canada, this couple carried on the barbershop business for many years. The building containing the shop was left standing until just a few years ago. When Miki visited the shop then closed and soon to be torn down, he was surprised to see a large old Asahi Beer Company mirror that his parents had bought many years ago was still hanging there. “It must have been there for half a century or more.” Years later, whenever he visited Japan, Miki would stop by the Miyano home to visit. On one such occasion, Mr. Miyano told him that he wished he could thank Miki’s mother, who had already passed away, because if she had not taught them how to barber, they wouldn’t have been able to have that business all their life.

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Fujiye ran the barber shop, Hyoshiro continued farming. So, between her barbering and his farming, and with the good will and support of their neighbors, they were able to sustain their family. Miki notes, “Compared to others, we were doing better.”

Childhood Experiences in Taga, Japan

Miki had no problem adjusting to Japan as only two-years-old when he arrived. In fact, when he became older he felt like he had been born in Japan as he had no memories of Canada, and Japanese became his first language. He got along well with friends and played baseball using a bat made from bamboo. Every morning they got up around 6:00 a.m. so they could play baseball for an hour before school. Miki played third base and was a good batter and home run hitter. He remembers what a great day it was when his dad bought him a baseball glove and a wooden bat which he then shared with his friends. “Life was good. I did very well academically and played baseball as clean-up batter and third baseman. So, I had a wonderful time in Japan.”

Miki has almost no recollection of being seriously discriminated against during his childhood in Japan. The only incident he can remember was having his cap taken by some other kids and being called “Foreigner!” Perhaps due to his young age he did not find this appellation as deeply insulting as the older children did.

However, Shig, who was nine years old when he arrived in Japan, recalls having a much more difficult time adjusting. Unlike his younger brother, he had fond memories of Canada and his friends there and how much he had enjoyed life as a small child in the internment camp. Although his parents spoke Japanese at home and he could sort of get by, he had not learned to read or write Japanese before arriving in Japan, so he had to start elementary school in Japan in grade two at the age of nine. He recalls often being called various names including “Foreigner!” and getting into fights with the other kids but adds that he was a tough kid and didn’t lose. Somehow, despite the frequent fights, he was eventually able to make some good friends. Being a native English speaker was sometimes an asset, but sometimes not. For instance, he later told Miki that when they had English speech competitions in school, he was barred from participating because he was considered to have an unfair advantage.

He also remembers often feeling hungry. Compared to what he ate in Canada, the food he could eat in Japan at that time did not taste good, so he always wanted to return to Canada. Years later he told his wife Akemi that this frequent hunger and looking at the delicious bento of a classmate whose parents owned a restaurant gave him a dream to open a restaurant someday so he could make good food. This dream would be realized years later after he returned to Canada.

Shig also recalls most of the young adults (and some teenagers who were just a few years older than him) quickly getting good jobs at the American military bases, which enabled them to do much better economically than the Japanese people around them. He also wanted to go to work and clearly recalls his father telling him he couldn’t as he was still too young. So, he had to content himself with helping his father in the field.

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Although Miki's recollections of that period are happier, he does remember some unpleasant experiences that he and all his Japanese classmates had to endure. For example, elementary school kids were required to drink makkuri (a herbal medicine that kills worms in the stomach) at school. The teacher would come with the makkuri during lunch hour and make the kids drink it. Miki remembers being required to drink this medicine several times. It tasted awful and he couldn't endure it. "I drank it the first time, but the second time I couldn't. So I paid my friend five yen or something to drink it for me. I really hated that stuff!" The school also used to spray white DDT powder on the girls' hair to kill lice. All the boys were required to get a bozu haircut (shaved head) at school from Dr. Kamike, the school doctor. Miki, however, was spared from Dr. Kamike's haircuts thanks to his mother being the local barber. Miki chuckles, "So, I was the only guy with long hair! I could get my hair cut anytime I wanted. Kamike sensei lived five doors from me and used to get his hair cut by my mother. So, he never cut my hair, but he cut all the other boy students' hair."

Unlike some of his classmates who ate mugi (grain) or brown rice, Miki was able to eat white rice for his school lunches.

I guess, because we had a rice field, we always had white rice to eat...On especially lucky days I also had a fried Japanese style egg and sometimes salted salmon...and my dad used to grow all the vegetables. That's why my favorite foods even now are rakkyo, umeboshi, takuwan, and cabbage, all of which can be bought in Vancouver now. I still eat lots of those.

The elementary school in Taga had a field and the students learned how to grow rice and vegetables. The school also kept chickens, rabbits, a goat, and pigeons. Each grade would take turns looking after the various animals. There was a mountain just behind the school, so during the noon hour the kids would go up the mountainside and play. They learned about what plants grow on the mountain and what could or could not be eaten, and they used to pick berries and other things they could eat.

In the postwar years, there was a dearth of sports equipment in the Japanese schools. Most of the equipment they did have was directly donated by parents and other individuals. Also, the kids would go and catch inago (locusts) in the rice fields to raise money for sports equipment. Miki recalls,

Each grade had a project, and each one of us had to catch so many inago and bring them to school and (the teachers) cooked them. I remember the inago getting very red...then they put them on a mat and dried them. Then some food company would come and buy them. Also, there was a special herb called yakiso that grew by the riverside. Each grade was assigned during the summer holiday to collect a certain amount of it. Then we would bring them to school. I used to go and pick it all the time. The school would sell the herb to a pharmaceutical company...and then we could get a new baseball.

Because the students had to raise money like this to buy sports equipment, they appreciated it more. They also had to clean the school and were taught to mend their own school uniforms.

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About that time the new phenomenon of television was gradually starting to spread in Japan, and the kids in Taga would go to the local electrical goods shop where the owner would let them watch. Miki remembers this shop becoming a social gathering spot where all the kids would watch TV together.

Even now Miki is still in contact with many of his childhood classmates and friends in Japan. “Most of them are still alive and I meet them at class reunions... Whenever we had a class reunion, about 40 of them would come.” As of now he has online contact with 19 of them. He also used to visit his elementary school teacher every time he went to Japan, but the teacher passed away in 2021.

Return to Canada

At some point in the mid-1950s, Hyoshiro and Fujiye Hirai decided to move their family back to Canada. Miki now characterizes his life after returning to Canada as “a story of frustration, challenge and finding success in my own way. It has been a long time, starting in 1956, and is still going on.” He describes why his family returned to Canada as follows: On his mother Fujiye’s side, two of her brothers and one sister were living in Taber (in southern Alberta) while just one sister was living in Oyabu, their hometown in Shiga prefecture. Hyoshiro and Fujiye had good relations with her side of the family, and Miki speculates that they wanted to be together with them. Perhaps they also felt their family would have a better economic future in Canada. Miki notes, “In Japan, our family just survived and we had nothing to show for a total of about eleven years.”

Shig returned to Canada first in 1954 at the age of 16, sponsored by his maternal uncle. Because he was nine when he had left Canada for Japan, English was not a problem for him. At first, he lived on a sugar beet farm near Taber (in southern Alberta) with his uncle who had sponsored him. As his uncle was a bachelor, Shig had to look after the cooking using a wood-burning stove. The menu was mostly limited to canned foods and bread.

He strongly wished to go to high school in Canada, but his uncle told him this was impossible as they needed to save money in order to sponsor the rest of his family to Canada. Hence, instead of studying, he found himself laboring long hours during the summer on the sugar beet farm, often from about six o’clock in the morning till about ten in the evening, and in the winter he worked at a sawmill at Williams Lake, BC. He was never able to realize his wish to go to high school in Canada.

According to Shig’s wife Akemi, due to his good speaking skill in Japanese and his enjoyment at communicating with older people, he became quite popular among elderly Japanese Canadians. She recalls:

I heard that there were old people who could talk in Japanese and a few of them called Shig “Japan Boy!!” and wanted to have conversations with him and ask him how Japan was...they had him do extra work and told him to stay for dinner and talk more...they

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were happy to have him come...Maybe that's why Shig became a talker...he enjoyed talking with many older people!

In late February of 1956, Miki and his mother, sponsored by their uncle and Shig, returned to Canada from Japan. Miki was still eleven years old and in grade five at Taga Elementary School. A week before his departure, he asked his baseball friends in Taga to write something for him, so they each wrote a farewell note in an autograph booklet. He has kept it ever since and showed it to them many years later when he visited Japan, much to their surprise. They told him that he is the only one of them who still has anything like that from their childhood.

They sailed to Canada on the Hikama Maru, arriving in March. Miki was seasick during most of the ten-day voyage. They stopped at Hawaii first, and then Seattle, and finally Vancouver. While walking in a Seattle fish market, Miki was surprised at the size of some crabs he saw — much larger than the crabs he had seen in Japan. A lady who had been a passenger on the same boat noticed his amazement and bought one for him to eat.

Miki vividly remembers seeing the Hotel Vancouver and the Marine Building when they landed. Mrs. Kada, a friend of his mother, met them and they stayed with the Kada family during their short stay in Vancouver. Miki used to watch Western movies in Japan and really wanted a toy pistol, which Mrs. Kada bought him, much to his excitement. During his stay in Vancouver he also experienced his first taste of Coke. At first it seemed a little bitter, but now is his favorite drink. He also recalls meeting other family friends. He was very surprised to see houses with central heating, gas stoves, refrigerators, and hot water coming out of a tap. These modern conveniences were unimaginable in postwar Japan.³⁴

Life in Alberta

After a week in Vancouver, Fujiye and Miki moved to a large sugar beet farm near Taber, Alberta, near where her sisters who had stayed in Canada after the war were living. Miki explains, "My first experience of Canadian life was at Taber." The farm was owned by a Mormon family. As part of their contract, they were provided with a small one-floor bungalow. The nearest town, Taber, was twenty-five minutes away by car. Both the geographical surroundings and the way of life there were a big surprise to Miki. "In Taber, the first thing we saw was the massive land, as far as you could see, 360 degrees, no matter where you looked." He was amazed to be able to see the sun rise from the eastern horizon and set on the western horizon. Miki recalls:

So, we got to the house. It was a small bungalow, one floor, with two or three bedrooms, and a kitchen in the middle, and an outhouse about a hundred meters away. There was no electricity and no water. Even in Japan after the war we'd had electricity. There we'd had a radio, but here we had nothing. There was just a kerosene lamp in the house.

³⁴ Nikkei National Museum and Cultural Centre (2023, September 23) Okaeri-Miki Hirai [YouTube]. (21:00~) <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=LlMJaVOjZ2Y>

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It reminded Miki of the cowboy movies he used to watch in Japan.

Although treated well, the Hirai family was very isolated. The boss's house was about five hundred meters away, and the nearest neighbor lived five miles away. The post office was about twenty miles away. They didn't have a car so couldn't go anywhere and had to wait for a bus to go to town. When they wanted to go shopping, they had to ask a neighbor for a ride to town. "We had no telephone, and just felt cut off from everything. It was so quiet, and you could hear the coyotes at night."

Struggle to Adjust

In stark contrast to Shig, who had previously lived in Canada till age nine and spoke English as his first language, Miki could hardly speak any English at all. He had learned romaji (Roman letters) in Japan, but little more. However, he was naturally good at math and had also studied soroban in Japan, so math class was easy for him. He had done very well in school in Japan, but this would not be the case in Canada. Although he had completed grade five in Japan, because of his lack of English he was placed in grade one at Taber. "I was the biggest guy in the classroom because all the other kids were five or six years younger. I was almost twelve then."

Due to the language barrier, he was terrified to go to school, and recalls being especially afraid of what would happen if he missed the school bus back to home as there was no way to contact his family. He couldn't speak English if he needed to ask for help. However, his mother made him go to school anyway, and he remembers waiting for the school bus while holding his blue lunch box. He felt frustrated and bored with grade one level schoolwork, so he often just sat there. Fortunately, his classmates were kind and tried to help him with English, so he got along with them well. He also recalls a kind teacher giving him extra help.

The farm had a big underground cement holding pool for water, which became their source of drinking water. A big truck would come and dump the water in it, and that was the water they used for living. After coming back to the farm from school each day, Miki's job was to fill big jars with water from the holding pool and carry it to his family and others working in the fields. He also occasionally helped out with the smaller vegetable garden work.

The family's lack of a car made it impossible to go to town and join in team sports such as baseball or even socialize much with other kids. The only people he could talk with were his mother, brother, and uncle. As he puts it, "I was just cut off for a year and a half or so."

The sugar beet work was extremely hard on his mother, Fujiye. Miki recalls that the sugar beets were often bigger than Japanese radishes (daikon). They had to pick them up and chop off the leafy part by hand. Then they gathered them up and took them to a sugar beet factory in Taber. It was a huge factory, and the sugar beets were piled up high beside it "like mountains."

Return to Vancouver

In 1957, after a year and a half in Taber, Fujiye, Shig, and Miki moved back to Vancouver, and Hyoshiro came from Japan and joined them. After suffering a serious foot injury, Shig had

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stopped working at the sawmill and was now employed in a furniture factory in Vancouver, a job he continued until the factory burned down. He was also doing Japanese gardening. Fujiye soon found housekeeping work and a job in a chicken processing factory. Eventually she began barbering again.

Their friends the Kada family again let them live in their home. They had a small space in the basement with a little kitchen, living room, and one bedroom. Shig and Miki slept in the attic. They lived there for several years and grew up together with the two youngest Kada brothers. Miki used to go with one of the Kada brothers to Hastings Elementary School. He started in grade two but soon skipped to grade four, so was catching up. However, because he had difficulty understanding English well, he was barely passing. He was afraid to show his report card to mother and recalls just signing her name on it and returning it to his teacher. English was his worst subject, and this handicapped his ability to learn the other subjects as well. He had not learned to read enough Kanji characters to use a Japanese-English dictionary, and his parents also could not help him much due to their limited English.

Fortunately, in grade eleven he had a very good teacher who worked with him after school and helped him improve his English. As a result, his grades improved to a B average. He liked science and math but English was still very difficult. He persisted on through grade thirteen at King Edward High School but heard that English was the hardest required university subject so decided not to go on to university.

Some time after returning to Vancouver, Fujiye started to work in a barbershop owned by some Chinese people. About a year or two later she decided to open her own shop (Fuji Barbers) on Main Street, where the police station is now located. She urged her son Shig to get his barbering license in order to have a practical trade to rely on, so he went to Moller School of Barbering and started working with her. After Miki's decision not to go on to university, she likewise convinced him to learn barbering, so he also went to barbering school and joined Fujiye and Shig in her barbershop. Later, the city demolished the building to make space for a new police station, so they moved the shop to a location on Dunlevy Street across from Powell Street.³⁵ The new shop did well, and Miki recalls he and Shig learning a lot from their conversations with their various customers. Shig became especially popular among the Vancouver police and they would line up for his crew cuts but unfortunately he had to stop barbering due to a hair allergy.

On August 25, 1962, Shig married Akemi Eto, the sister of a good friend. Her dedicated support would become a major factor behind his future business success. Shig and Akemi would later go on to open a very successful Japanese restaurant called *Maneki* on Hastings Street and then a Japanese grocery store which grew into the well-known Fujiya grocery chain with four branches in Vancouver and one in Victoria.³⁶

³⁵ The building in which the shop was located is still standing.

³⁶ See the following chapter on the Eto family for more details about the Maneki restaurant and the Fujiya grocery chain stories.

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After returning from Japan and rejoining his family in Vancouver, Hyoshiro did various things to support the household and Fujiye's barbershop business, becoming the "main cook" and cleaner at home. Shig remembers often being sent by his father to buy groceries. After Shig and Akemi married, Hyoshiro and Fujiye moved in with them. Akemi recalls, "Father did all the gardening around the house. The peony flowers and climbing roses around the fence were beautiful." He also enjoyed watching horseracing and going bowling every week and was a member of the Japanese Kika bowling team.³⁷

Eventually Miki went on to start his own barbershop. On September 6, 1969, he married Miyako Kawazoe, who had been born and raised in Osaka and had immigrated to Canada alone as a young single woman in September, 1968. The first time Miyako and Miki met each other was at a Christmas Eve party. Some of her friends in Vancouver at that time were barbers and hairdressers who had immigrated earlier. Miki was established as a barber then and would explain to newly arrived barbers how to get a license in Canada, so had gotten to know quite a lot of them. Some of these barbers invited him to a Christmas party where he met Miyako. They happened to meet again two or three days later when she was shopping for Japanese food with some friends and their romance began. Eventually he moved on to various start-up ventures and had a career in fish wholesaling, international marketing, and consulting. He established a company called Sunny Marketing.

Life after Retirement

From 2019 Shig and Akemi gradually started to retire from their grocery chain business. Their daughter's husband joined Fujiya after graduating from university. At first he was doing various jobs such as cutting up the fish but gradually became more involved in the management and eventually took charge of the company. Due to Shig's health problems, he and Akemi have now retired completely from running Fujiya, leaving their son-in-law in charge.

Miki's retirement was a gradual process as he ended his various consulting roles over a period of several years. In some cases, the companies he was representing were bought out by larger companies. His retirement from business finally became complete in 2022, at the age of seventy-eight. As he retired from his various business roles, he became more active in the Japanese Canadian community in Vancouver. Around 2015 he started becoming increasingly involved with the Shiga Prefectural Association (kenjinkai), partly through the influence of his brother Shig who was very active in the association and the Japanese Canadian community in Vancouver. Shig was also a major sponsor of various cultural events such as those held at the annual Japanese Canadian festival at Powell Street and a wellknown leader of the community.

Looking back over his own life history and that of his family, Miki reflects:

³⁷ Hyoshiro Hirai Passed away on November 5, 1981 at the age of 74. Fujiye Hirai passed away on March 10, 2005 at the age of 94.

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Our family did not have anything monetarily wise. But I think we had lots of love! That's for sure! I value people most of all. My brother Shig does too. That is the key to our success, to his success. That is the way we were raised. My mother was like that. She never fought with her brothers or sister in her lifetime. She can remember no fighting. I talk to my uncle now. He says the same thing—"I never fight"... And my father taught me the same thing. My mother—she never got mad. That's what my Dad said. So, I guess that is the way I should act.

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Eto Family

Family Roots, Life in Canada Before Exile

Sunao Eto, the Eto family's father, was born on March 15, 1886, in Iwasaka, a rural farm village Kumamoto Prefecture, Japan. He was the second son of four brothers. Their father had left them in poverty having drunk away all their property, so it fell upon Sunao, being the second son in the family, to go overseas and earn some money in order to redeem their lost property.

He first went to Hawaii around the age of 17 (1903) and, after a short stint there, emigrated to Canada. He found employment at Union Steamships where he worked hard for several years and was able to save enough money to send substantial amounts to his elder brother in Japan. In this way, not only did he rescue his family from extreme poverty, but he was also able to purchase some paddy fields in his home village.

In 1920 at age 34, Sunao left for Japan to find a wife and, on the advice of the local priest in his home town Iwasaka, married Yasue Mitsunaga who had also been born there in 1899. After their honeymoon in Kobe they settled in Vancouver, first living on Princess Avenue and later Alexander Street. Their first child, Tadasu, was born on September 3, 1922, followed by Ayako (Mary) on October 21, 1925, Kinuko (Betty) on February 19, 1929, Miyako (Margaret) on February 2, 1932, Sadao (John) on February 11, 1934, and Akemi on February 28, 1938.

Around 1935, during the Great Depression, there was a seaman's strike and Sunao lost his job with Union Steamships. He was unemployed for several years but enjoyed reading and spent much of his time with books. Meanwhile, Yasue managed to find various part time jobs such as shrimping and working in canneries. In 1940 they moved to a house on Alexander Street where Yasue was able to supplement her income by making industrial gloves at home. She did well at it and hired several other women who likewise worked from their homes as sewers. Around 1940, Sunao found a job working at a paper mill in Port Alice, B.C., and took eldest son Tadasu with him.

While living in Vancouver, the Eto family attended church services at the Holy Cross Anglican Church and the children attended kindergartens and various schools as well as the Vancouver Japanese Language School. Margaret fondly remembers her teacher at Holy Cross kindergarten, Margaret Foster: "She was my favorite teacher! That's why I named myself Margaret after her!... I looked up to her."

The Eto family was just beginning to experience the financial rewards of their hard work when the uprooting occurred. In the spring of 1942, Sunao was sent to a road construction camp in the Interior of B.C. and later to the internment camp at Rosebery (beside Slocan Lake). A six-p.m. curfew was placed on all Japanese Canadians in Vancouver. One evening, eldest son Tadasu, who was 18 at the time, broke the curfew, disguised as a Chinese. He was caught and sent to Camp Petawawa, a POW camp in Angler, Ontario. This harsh experience would harden his resentment against Canada.

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In September of 1942 Yasue and her children travelled by train and joined Sunao who was already at the internment camp being built in Rosebery, a small mining ghost town on the edge of Slocan Lake. This would be their home for the next three years. On October 2, 1944, Yasue gave birth to her youngest daughter, Naomi. Akemi went through the United Church kindergarten in Rosebery, and Margaret attended Sunday school and church at the United Church. Margaret and John also enrolled elementary school. Mary and Betty joined a sewing school run by a lady named Mrs. Fujiwara where they learned to make draft patterns and do various kinds of finishing such as smocking. As a result of their sewing and tailoring abilities, the Eto girls were always dressed to perfection.

Margaret recalls that, although the uprooting must have been very traumatic for her parents, for the kids it was a much more positive experience, “We weren’t aware of all they were suffering. My older sisters may have had some bad experiences, but we weren’t aware of all that. It was like ‘going to camp’ for us.” Akemi also has pleasant memories of her early childhood in the camp playing games, skating in the winter, and swimming in Slocan Lake in the summer. In June 1945, they moved to the internment camp at Bayfarm.

Exile To Japan

Decision to go to Japan

Near the end of the war, the Canadian government gave the Japanese Canadians the unpleasant choice between dispersing east of British Columbia or being permanently “repatriated” to Japan. Sunao had no hesitancy in his decision as he had been planning to go back to Japan even before the war. He had been sending funds to Japan and had his older brother there purchase paddy fields for him. He also had ample savings (enough to build three houses, he would say), so was unworried and even optimistic about their future in Japan.

Eldest son Tadasu, embittered towards Canada by his experience of being incarcerated in the POW camp, was also strongly determined to go to Japan. Yasue, on the other hand, while also indignant about the treatment the family had received in Canada, was hesitant to leave. She had been warned about the harsh conditions in postwar Japan by friends who urged her to move with them to Toronto instead, but in the end decided to comply with the wishes of her husband and eldest son (whom she had not seen for four years and was missing deeply) in order to keep the family together.

Ship voyage back to Japan, Uruga Repatriation Center

On June 16, 1946, after a year of living in the Bay Farm internment camp where they had moved to wait for their “repatriation” to Japan, the Eto family boarded the General MC Meigs at Vancouver Harbor and began the voyage to Japan. At the time, Mary was 20, Betty 17, Margaret 14, John 12, Akemi 7, and Naomi just 19 months old. They had been eager to meet up on the ship with their eldest son and brother, Tadasu, whom they had not seen for the last four years, as he had been incarcerated in the POW camp since he was 19 years of age. Margaret explains, “For

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Yasue, being reunited with her eldest son was no doubt an unforgettable moment, but she later told us that Naosuke had seemed indifferent to her and she was not able to get much out of him.

Margaret vaguely recalls being very seasick during the whole trip. She says:

I personally have very little recollection of the voyage as I was sea-sick the minute we boarded the ship. I did not get up until I heard someone shout “There’s Mount Fuji!” I looked up at the distant horizon but we could not see Mount Fuji until someone said “Look up, w-a-a-y up!” and high above the horizon, we were able to get the imposing sight and majesty of the Mount Fuji we had seen so often in pictures.

Akemi, on the other hand, was hardly sick at all though she recalls the rough seas and sleeping in bunk beds. She has particularly vivid memories of how the passengers were behaving just after they arrived and disembarked at Yokosuka.

I was close to my mom because I was only seven years old. When we were getting off the boat, there were so many people running around, and they were taking the sink plug chains off the sinks and stealing them. Some of the people were taking pillowcases and hiding sugar in them...I was seeing so many things that were happening, everybody was going crazy...Before getting off the boat, I almost got lost. Everybody was rushing to the top deck—I didn’t know what was going on.

After getting off the boat, she noticed some Japanese people standing behind a fence nearby begging for food. She explains, “Some people were waving for handouts. At that time, I didn’t know what they were doing. I thought they were just waving to welcome us. Some of the passengers who had disembarked were throwing food to them and they were grabbing it.”

After landing at Yokosuka they were quickly transferred to the Uraga Repatriation center where they were given various inoculations. The quality of the food was very poor. Margaret remembers being given extremely hard biscuits which she and Sadao spat out. “All I remember is the hard biscuits we got in Uraga...They were so tasteless... and just hard!”

Train Trip to Kumamoto

Soon they were put on a train to Kumamoto. Margaret explains, “The long train trip to Kumamoto was filled with apprehension and dread as we did not know what to expect. When we saw the destitution, despair, and frailty of the people, I’m sure our parents were regretting returning to Japan, thinking ‘What have we got ourselves into?’” Elsewhere she elaborates in more detail:

At Hiroshima, hordes of wraith-like people tried to board the train—scarred, hairless, skeleton-like figures which was a disquieting moment for us. At other stations, beggars would swarm the train looking for a handout. As the train travelled along the bleak countryside, we noticed clothes hanging on trees and realized people were living in the

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caves nearby. This was post-war Japan and we were seeing the grim reality and despair in the lives of the people. (*Nikkei Images* p. 15)³⁸

Akemi remembers the train going through numerous tunnels and black sooty smoke entering the passenger cars. “There were lots of tunnels. You couldn’t even open the window because in those days lots of smoke came into the train with those coal-burning engines and all the faces would get black.”

She also recalls that it was on the train that she first met her eldest brother Tadasu. She had seen him on the boat and her mother had called out to him but he was busy helping the crew so briefly looked at them but didn’t reply. “In the train, that was the first time I met my big brother. When I woke up, someone was holding me, and I felt so strange because my mother was sitting there, but I was sitting on somebody else’s lap, and that was my big brother who I hadn’t met for 4 years!”

After finally disembarking at Ozu Station at Kumamoto city, the family had to walk to their village, Iwasaka, about four miles away. Margaret explains,

The long trek to Iwasaka from Kumamoto city was a harrowing experience as we had to walk in the hot sun dragging our baggage. We children were in awe at the people we encountered on the way as they appeared to be like savages to us by the way they were dressed (or undressed as the case may be).¹ Halfway there, a gracious grey-haired lady ran up to our mother and identified herself as our mother’s aunt whom our mother hadn’t seen since childhood. She offered us some watermelon and a shady rest which invigorated us for the rest of the walk.

Much to their surprise, when they finally arrived at the home of Sunao’s elder brother³⁹ in Iwasaka, they were given an unusually cold reception. Margaret recalls, “When we arrived at the home of father’s brother, we sensed the hostility as his first words were ‘Why did you come back?’ instead of a warm greeting. It did not help that we children rushed onto the *tatami* with our shoes on, eager to relax” (*Nikkei Images* p. 16). When the elder brother threw Sunao’s bank book on the *tatami* mat, Sunao was devastated to notice that the balance would barely buy a sack of rice at black market prices.

Life in Postwar Japanese Village

Due to the postwar influx into Japan of repatriates from various former colonies and other countries, there was an extreme lack of food and accommodation in the villages. Hence, the Eto family of nine had to crowd into a *zashiki* (tatami mat room) in the home of Sunao’s elder brother for the first several months. Margaret recalls:

³⁸ Elsewhere Margaret writes, “The family of nine started the trek in the hot sun, not aware of the strange looks we were getting. Instead, we children were shocked to see men clad only in loin cloths and old ladies carrying babies on their backs while wearing only a *koshimaki*. We thought we were back in primitive times in the wild jungles of Borneo.” (*Nikkei Images*, p 16)

³⁹ Although their mother was still living, their father had already passed away, leaving the elder brother in charge of the family property.

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Once we had reached our uncle's house and met with a cold reception, we settled into the *zashiki* (tatami room) which was made available to us. Every day we had all our meals on a straw mat in the yard with the matriarch (grandmother) doling out the miso soup to all of us. The men would be served first and we women were lucky to have whatever was left in the miso soup.

After several months of negotiation, Sunao was able to get back from his brother some of the rice fields he had originally paid for with his savings while working in Canada. Meanwhile, the family had moved to the brother's tobacco drying house, a cramped, dimly lit one-room building (about 12 tatami) to which a lean-to shack was added to be used as a kitchen.

Sunao and Yasue worked hard raising rice and vegetables to provide sustenance for the family, but food continued to be scarce. The two eldest siblings, Tadasu and Betty, moved to Kumamoto city where they found employment, Tadasu as an interpreter/translator for American Occupation Forces, and Betty as an interpreter and desk clerk for a hotel catering to Americans. They were able to send some much-needed money back to the remaining seven members of family. However, people in the village were hesitant to sell food to Yasue for money, so she struggled to purchase enough food for the family. Of Yasue's persistent efforts to take care of her family, Margaret recalls:

Throughout all of this, our mother did not waver in her determination to serve her husband and the youngest, Naomi, nothing but white rice while the rest of the family ate barley, buckwheat, millet, sweet potato, etc., and in retrospect, these were healthy substitutes. In spite of the rigorous conditions, the family did not catch any colds or serious illnesses (*Nikkei Images*, p. 16).

During this time, daughter Mary had begun to put to good economic use the sewing skills she had learned in the internment camp by converting old Japanese military coats and kimonos to western style clothing, which had become much in demand. Once word of her sewing skills got around, this became a profitable business. Margaret points out that Yasue had wisely ordered a lot of fabric from Simpsons Sears before going back to Japan "so we had all this fabric that my sisters could sew western clothes, and a lot of people brought in their *yukata* to be made into western clothes. Men would also bring their military coats to be converted into western style overcoats. Mother had also shipped (to Japan) her Singer sewing machine." Furthermore, Yasue had cleverly decided, instead of being paid with money, to have these customers to pay in food staples, thus resolving much of the family's food purchasing problem.⁴⁰ Later, Sunao was able to buy back more of his fields and provide more food for the family, and Mary and Margaret also found employment with the Occupation Forces in Kumamoto. During this time, the remaining family members moved out of the tobacco drying house into another tatami room for a couple more years while Yasue and Sunao continued to save money to buy a house and buy back land. Margaret recalls,

⁴⁰ This appears to be another example of the practice of bartering nonperishable items such as clothing for food as money was almost worthless due to the extremely high inflation.

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When the tobacco house became unavailable, we had to find another accommodation, but rental homes were almost impossible to find in the village. This resulted in renting another *zashiki* room for a couple years until our house was built. Yasue and I would alternately get up at four a.m. to start the fire to cook the rice in the makeshift kitchen for Sadao's bento as he had to leave for school in time to catch the earliest train for Kumamoto city.

Finally, after some difficult negotiations with relatives, they bought a lot from Sunao's elder brother in return for a rice field and built a house. Margaret explains:

There were ongoing talks to negotiate the return of the rice paddies to our father, and our mother enlisted the help of her father to resolve this, our mother being at the center of these talks. Our mother was the chief negotiator in most of these matters and she was responsible for getting the house built (with financial help from the income earned by Tadasu, Mary, and Betty) with her usual flourish, complete with ceremonies when the foundation was laid and the roof was raised.

Sisters' Recollections of Life in Japan

Margaret's Recollections

Despite the tensions with relatives, there were some aspects of the Eto family's life in Iwasaka and Kumamoto city that were, relatively speaking, better than what was reported by many exiles in postwar Japan. For one, the children, even the older ones, did not experience a serious language barrier and they recall actually finding the local Kumamoto dialect amusing and fun to speak.

Margaret explains:

As for the language barrier, it was minimal since we attended the Vancouver Japanese Language School in pre-war times and we spoke Japanese at home.⁴¹ Sadao had finished grade two and I had finished grade four at Vancouver Japanese Language School, so when our parents enrolled us in the local school, they opted to enroll us (in the grades) where we had left off in 1942. However, the principal (who happened to be our father's cousin), arranged to pass us into grades four and six respectively, after six months. (*Nikkei Images*, p. 16)

The eldest son, Tadasu, was quite fluent at Japanese as he had studied Japanese diligently during his incarceration in the POW camp with the help of his former schoolteacher who was also incarcerated there with him. (*Nikkei Images*, p.16). This enabled him to almost immediately find good employment as an interpreter with the Occupation Forces.

Margaret also points out that, overall, compared to the reported experiences of other exiles, the Eto family experienced relatively less discrimination from adult relatives and village members. She acknowledges the heavy economic burden and stress it must have been for the

⁴¹ Since both parents were from the same village, the children would also have had some exposure to the local dialect at home when the family was still in Canada.

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relatives and the village, which was already crowded at the time with younger generations returning to their parents' homes. She notes that, as time passed and both the local economy and the economic situation of the Eto family improved, their relations with their relatives became less strained. She also thinks that the long history of both sides of the family being respected members of the village community was another reason they did not experience the level of discrimination that many other exiles did.

She does recall some bullying from a few of the younger people, partly due to the nice clothes that she and her siblings used to wear. For example, she was sometimes called “Pan-pan” (derogatory term for prostitutes who catered to members of the Occupation Forces) because she wore brighter colors than others, who were wearing school uniforms, and permed her hair. Naomi explains, “My sisters dressed really nicely—they were beautiful sisters. So, the other students would say ‘*Pan-pan kaere!* (Go back to your country, prostitute!)’ Akemi chuckles, “We didn’t even know what a prostitute was, so we never knew what that meant!” Margaret also remembers her brother John being bullied because of the way he dressed.

When my brother John enrolled in the private school (an all-boys school called *Chinzei Koukou*), before he could order his uniform he wore a western style suit—our mother had always dressed us so nicely—and he wore that to school at first, and of course they kind of ridiculed him. It was known as a very tough school. He was a shy quiet boy, but he learned to be tough, taking up judo and earning a black belt at an early age.

Margaret also has vivid memories of the physical rigors of village life, especially those due to the lack of plumbing and running water:

Until they put in pipelines years later, we had to go down to the river to get the bathing water. There was a well for drinking water, but for bathing water we had to go all the way down to the river to get it, and I still remember lugging two buckets several times up and down the hill. That was a tough part! That was at least two blocks, and uphill. We had to use a pole with a bucket on each end. My back got strong, so there was some good that came out of it!”

After living in the village of Iwasaka for about four years, Margaret followed her elder siblings and moved to the Kumamoto city, got a job with the occupation forces, and lived with her sisters Mary and Betty. Margaret recalls, “Mary was a great cook and, having cooked for the family during the four years of incarceration and with limited resources, she knew how to make even bologna sound appetizing!” She adds, “I have only memories of eating good food! I was 19. We lived in a dormitory at the base so could use a kitchen to cook.”

Margaret enjoyed the amenities there and came to like life in the city. Akemi adds, “Margaret was lucky (to move to the city) because although we were living in a new house in Iwasaka, it had just a radio, no TV, and no telephone. There was just one place in the village where people had to go if they wanted to use the telephone.”

Akemi's Recollections

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Though only seven years old when the family arrived in Japan, Akemi has many vivid memories of her life as a child in Iwasaka, both negative and positive. For example, she recalls that many kids, including herself, often suffered from *odeki*, a kind of boil, so would have to gather a special kind of medicinal herb and put it into their bathwater to cure the boils. She also recalls having to get various kinds of inoculations “all the time” and having to line up with her grade one classmates and have a white DDT powder sprayed on their hair to kill lice, even when they did not have lice. The sisters wonder in retrospect how much of the DDT they inhaled although they do not recall any noticeable ill effects.

While she enjoyed school and made many friends, Akemi recalls a few times when she experienced bullying and discrimination from a few of her schoolmates. She explains:

We had to struggle when we were taken back to a place where we didn’t know how to adjust to people. Some Japanese treated us like we were still an enemy. I was only seven years of age, but some kids shouted at me, “*Amerika ni kaere!* (Go back to America)” ...It wasn’t everybody, just one or two students....My 4-years-old brother (John) fought almost every day!!....Of course everyone was still in pain after the war.”

On the other hand, Akemi also has many pleasant memories of her childhood in Iwasaka, for example, enjoying various traditional Japanese customs with her family, such as *Otsukimi* (moon-viewing).

When the full moon came out, my mom made the *fukashi-manju* (a kind of traditional Japanese sweet). I used to help her put the sweet potato inside *ankou* (red bean paste), and then we would go out on the *engawa* (veranda) and put it there. And there was also *Suzuki* (a kind of willow) which was put in a vase. Then some of the neighbors would come and watch the moon and the stars, and I thought that was really nice...Our mother did something like that every month...She celebrated all the special days such as *Hina Matsuri* (Doll Festival) in March, and Boys Day in May. We would make *chimake*. Dad would go to the mountains to get bamboo leaves, then steam them, then put the *mochi* inside and steam them again. Mom always used to do those kinds of things.

The sisters also recall with amusement how the villagers came to call Sunao and Yasue by the names they heard them being called by their children, “Mamma” and “Pappa.” Margaret comments, “When people referred to our parents as ‘Mamma’ and ‘Pappa,’ it was comical to our ears as this is a term that is used for one’s own parents—perhaps these people thought it was our parents’ real names.” However, the amusement also seems to have worked in both directions with the locals getting some laughs from the sisters’ Japanese Canadian linguistic idiosyncrasies. Margaret recalls one such situation: “When I was taking lessons from a local instructor in kimono-making, I used to have my classmates “in stitches” with my combined jargon of Canadian Japanese and local Kumamoto dialect. The only thing I can remember from those sessions were the stiff knees that resulted from the sittings.”

Another source of both good and bad memories for Akemi was her school life. Her best memories were of her elementary school days in Iwasaka. She recalls, “Our teachers were so

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nice. They were young and they treated us like younger sisters. I never missed a day going to school. That was the most enjoyable time, for three years!”

However, school life took a turn for the worse when Akemi transferred from public school to a mission junior high school in Kumamoto city. She had been looking forward to attending the local public junior high school (*Ozu Chugakko*), but the wife of her recently married eldest brother, Tadasu, got her to take a test to go to the private school (*Kyushu Joshi Gakuin*) and she passed. She explains:

I did not know I was going to go there. It was not my choice, and I had to go into the dormitory because there was no bus from our place, and I had to walk quite away to take the bus. To get to school it took about two hours, so they put me in the dormitory. That was the first time I had to be away from my family. They let me go home twice a month. It was so strict, and the dormitory had a strict time schedule. It was a beautiful school, but I was not comfortable going to a place where I didn't even know anybody. I was the only one to go to a private school as all the other students opted to go to a local school. The classes were enjoyable but the dormitory life was so strict and we had to adhere to so many rules, I was worried I was being groomed to become a nun. The memorable part for me was at Christmas when we would go caroling. Also, I looked forward to the bi-monthly weekends when I could go home or meet up with my older sisters who would often take me to lunch and movies.

Akemi also has some fond memories of her junior high school days, especially when she used to participate in school plays. One that won their school an award was an English-speaking play in which Akemi played Portia in “Merchant of Venice.”

Naomi's Recollections

While her older siblings remember their youngest sister as a baby doll, Naomi saw herself growing into a tomboyish girl with her dog always at her side. She fondly remembers roaming the countryside and munching on wildflowers. She remembers her mother as a generous person who always had time and food to offer to strangers, going so far as to have food prepared for a mother who, with a little girl in tow, used to come down from the hills every week. Naomi also recalls that, following the major flood in the summer of 1951, they opened their home to neighbors who had lost their house during the flood. When her mother saw men working on the roads following the flood, she invited them to sit on the veranda and fed them hot sweet potatoes while Akemi and Naomi served them cold tea or water.

Return to Canada

The return of the various members (except Tadasu) of the Eto family to Canada seems to have been the result of a series of circumstances over a period of years rather than a consciously made decision to return. As in the cases of most other exile families who returned to Canada, it was a

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process that spanned several years with different family members returning at different times and then working hard and saving money to sponsor others who would follow.

Eventually, every member of the Eto family would return to Canada except eldest son Tadasu, (who was now going by the names Naosuke or Tony). He had found employment at Northwest Airlines and married the daughter of a prominent hotel owner. They had a daughter, Kimi, and were living comfortably in Yokohama. He rarely spoke to his family of his incarceration in the POW camp during the internment period, but they could sense that he was still deeply embittered by the experience. After a long career in the airlines industry and retirement in Japan, he passed away in 2010 at 87 years of age.

The first member of the family to return to Canada was second son John (Sadao) in 1953. He had recently graduated from a boy's private high school known for its toughness and had also attained a black belt in Judo. Mr. Nakano, an old family friend in Canada who, like Tony, had been incarcerated in the POW camp at Petawawa, offered to sponsor John's return to Canada. John's parents accepted the offer and he left for New Denver, British Columbia, where Mr. Nakano was residing.

John spent a few years in New Denver where he attended high school and during which time he had the experience of fighting wildfires. He moved to Vancouver in 1955 to join Betty and Mary who had just moved there from Japan (see below). He worked for an import-export firm with sister Mary and later went on to establish his own company. On the side he also taught Judo to members of the local police force. He married Keiko Inouye with whom he had two sons, David and Paul. Keiko and John would later divorce and he would marry Yvette, a happy marriage that lasted until 2011 when John passed away after being in a nursing home for several years. Yvette followed him in 2021.

The second family member to move back to Canada was Betty (Kinuko) in 1954. She had married Masaharu Kawano, a Japanese national, in a church wedding in Kumamoto. The year after her return, Betty was able to sponsor Masaharu. The following year, they moved to Toronto where he found employment as a structural steel engineer and Betty attended an art school. Later they moved to Los Angeles, where she ran a successful craft store. Due to Betty experiencing health problems, they eventually moved back to Vancouver. Betty suffered a brain hemorrhage in 2015 and died at age 86, after being in a coma for several days. Her husband followed her seven months later.

Mary (Ayako) was the next sibling to return to Canada, arriving in 1955. She was employed at an import-export firm for several years with her brother John. Mary married Mike Tanaka in May of 1958 and they had three children, Wayne, Glenn and Karen. They were a typically happy and successful suburban family as Mike was a hardworking family man and Mary a capable mother and homemaker.

After having a fall and becoming unable to walk, she lived at a nursing home where Mike visited her daily until he passed away in 2016. Mary survived the Covid pandemic, thanks to the

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special care by her children and staff at the nursing home, but later died of natural causes at the age of 97 in July 2023. She was 97 years old.

Margaret (Miyako) joined her other siblings in Canada in September of 1956 and found employment within weeks of her arrival. She would continue to work at the same company for 34 years going from secretary to bookkeeper, purchasing agent, and finally operations manager. She recalls that, due to her holding various responsibilities in the company during her career, she was never bored. She lived with her mother Yasue who was the main cook. Margaret was also active in the English-speaking congregation of the Vancouver Japanese United Church and her Sundays and some weeknights were taken up with church activities until 1992 when she moved to Port Moody, to live with Naomi and her family. She explains,

When I was a child in Vancouver, I used to go to the Holy Cross (Anglican) Church.

During the war I started going to the United Church because the Anglican church didn't have any Sunday school in the Rosebery internment camp. In Japan I didn't go to church, but once I came back to Canada, I started going to the United Church again. I was very active in it until the last few years.

Her niece, Yumi was also an integral part of her life and as Margaret's health began to decline, Yumi and Naomi provided her with "all the comforts I had envisioned and more."

Despite their hardships experienced soon after moving to Japan, living conditions gradually improved for Sunao and Yasue. Sunao was enjoying life and his friends in the Japanese countryside and was content to tend to his fields, so he was not keen on uprooting yet again and returning to Canada. However, after Mary had gotten married, Margaret was finding herself "at odds with coping with both work and domestic duties," so she and John decided to apply to sponsor their parents and their two younger sisters, Akemi and Naomi, to Canada.

Sunao very reluctantly agreed to leave Japan. Margaret recalls the application proceeding so quickly that they were not able to make the financial preparations to support their parents in time for their arrival. They did manage to arrange the purchase of a small house with a large backyard which they considered to be a necessity as they wanted something to keep their father occupied since he had been so hesitant to give up his comfortable lifestyle in Japan and return to Canada.

Meanwhile, back in Iwasaka, the Sunao and Yasue had to sell their house and properties in order to have sufficient funds to buy a house in Vancouver. It was a hectic time for them but relatives and neighbors helped them out by purchasing their house, rice fields, and furnishings, thus enabling them financially to start a new life again in Canada. The whole family was joyfully reunited in Vancouver on November 2, 1958, and began to gradually settle in and buy furnishings and other necessities.

The house the older children had purchased for their parents in Vancouver had a large backyard with space for vegetables and other plants, and Sunao found contentment in watering the garden every day. He also made new friends in the Japanese Canadian community and would occasionally walk down to Powell Street. However, with age his health began to fail and he

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suffered a stroke. Yasue nursed him at home for several years, but he was eventually hospitalized and passed away on September 9, 1965, at 79 years of age.

After the passing of Sunao, Yasue continued to live with daughter Margaret and do most of the cooking as Margaret was busy with work and church activities. Yasue also took up painting and became quite good at it. Another interest was crocheting which her daughter-in-law Yvette taught her, and Margaret recalls her completing at least one Afghan per month. In addition, she enjoyed playing *Gaji* (a Japanese card game using *Hanafuda* cards) with daughter Margaret and a friend, and this became a weekly ritual. She continued to be active despite struggling with cancer, but finally passed away on December 5, 1979. Of her, Margaret says, “She left a legacy of courage and resourcefulness which will surely inspire all who knew her for generations to come.”

Akemi recalls being quite surprised when she found out she would be going back to Canada as it happened so suddenly. At the time of her return to Canada in 1958, she had recently graduated from Kyushu Jogakuin High School. Once they were settled in Vancouver, Akemi soon found part time work for an insurance company but realized she would have to learn some basic office skills such as typing in order to find good fulltime employment. She attended Duffus School of Business in the evenings and later got a full-time job at an import-export company where she was able to utilize her Japanese as well as her newly acquired typing skills.

She met her future husband, Shig Hirai, through her brother John. Their friendship soon progressed to courtship and marriage in 1961. They had two children, Mari and Ken, but sadly lost Ken at the early age of 21 following an auto accident. Early in their marriage, they acquired a Japanese restaurant, *Maneki*, which Shig and Akemi successfully ran for several years before starting the Japanese grocery store chain, *Fujiya*, which now has several subsidiaries in Vancouver and Victoria.

During the early years of their business, Akemi had to work evenings at the restaurant while raising a family and remembers it being a very stressful and busy time. Shig reluctantly retired in 2019 when he started to have difficulty walking. Akemi looked after him at for several years until he was admitted to a rest home. The Fujiya enterprise is now being capably run by their son-in-law, Jeff Matsuda (Mari’s husband) and their children, Megan and Ryan.

Naomi was only 14 years old when she returned to Canada. After graduating from high school, she attended Moler School of Hairdressing, and then continued on to successfully graduate from Blanche MacDonald School of Modeling, after which she worked for several years as a hairdresser and model. She married Shoji Nakamura, who was a building engineer, and they had a daughter, Yumi, who became a noted fashion designer, and is now “the cornerstone” of Naomi’s life. Naomi and Shoji eventually divorced. After sister Akemi and her husband Shig opened *Maneki* restaurant, she helped out on weekends as a server. Later, she met and married Yutaka Yamamoto, who was working as the chief chef at *Maneki*. Yutaka had recently immigrated to Canada at age 22 under the sponsorship of Shig. He had applied for the

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job at *Maneki* while still in Japan through the chef school in Osaka where he was already employed as an instructor.

After working at *Maneki* and *Fujiya* (on Powell Street) he opened his own restaurant and could be credited with making sushi a household word in Vancouver when he started offering “All You Can Eat” sushi. He had several restaurant locations in succession and at *Haru* Japanese Restaurant (in downtown Vancouver) was able to serve visiting dignitaries and celebrities. Naomi and Yutaka’s son, Andrew, followed in his father’s footsteps and is involved in the culinary arts.

Sisters’ Memories of Readjustment to Canada

Having spent 10 years in postwar Japan and adjusting to life and the culture there, returning to Canada involved yet another uprooting and to some degree a process of culture shock and readjustment for the family. For the two youngest sisters, Akemi and Naomi, there was additionally a linguistic hurdle to overcome. Even for the older siblings, who had been using English in their work with the occupation forces, the cultural adjustment to life in Canada was not always easy though there were also pleasant experiences.

Margaret

Margaret reflects on her own process of re-adjustment to life in Canada as follows:

After returning to Canada as an adult, after 10 years of living in Japan, I already knew there would be obvious changes to be expected, especially in lifestyle, but I did have some apprehensions about how I would be accepted both by my Japanese Canadian peers and in the working world. Because I found a job soon after my return, I did not have an opportunity to adjust gradually to my surroundings.

One thing that impressed her early was the politeness shown by men towards women:

I found out that women are treated differently here. Men were so polite it took me awhile to get used to it. For instance, I would stand in line for the bus, and when the bus arrived, the men would wait for me to board it first. Doors would be held open for me. These were little things that were quite foreign to me.

About her work environment she adds:

The staff of the first and only office that I worked in in Canada was made up mainly of staid, very British and Scottish stiff upper lip types, so the atmosphere was very proper and unlike the American GI style that I had grown accustomed to while working in Japan. The few ladies that I had to work with were also genteel and kind, which helped me get accustomed to my new surroundings. I’m sure they did not know what to expect of me since there were no other Asians employed there. In fact, back in those days, it was unheard of to have Asians and other people of color working in offices.

Margaret’s reintegration into the Japanese Canadian community and in particular the United Church also seems to have gone quite smoothly. She explains, “As for being accepted by my

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peers (other *nisei*, that is, second generation Japanese Canadians), it was as if I had never left. The first day I attended the Nisei church (Japanese Canadian United Church), the reception was cool (as I had hoped) so I was able to gradually ease in and stayed as an active member for many years until the congregation had to close.”

Before long, she became very involved in the church. When the deaconess found out that Margaret could do shorthand, she quickly recruited her to be church secretary, a role she continued to serve in for many years. She also ended up taking on additional administrative and leadership roles and participated in various ways in the worship services such as doing the scripture readings and so on. Church activities came to occupy many of her weekday evenings in addition to the Sunday worship services.

Akemi

Akemi vividly remembers her arrival in Vancouver and initial impressions of the city, her shyness, and her first experiences meeting and speaking English with white people:

Right after we got off the ship, Mary and Margaret were there to meet and take us to their place, so I wasn't alone. Vancouver's view was just wonderful—some snow on top of the houses looked like a picture in a book. At first we stayed in a rented place for about two weeks and then moved to a house. At that time they ordered a small cabinet for us to put some of our clothing in. Two huge tall men came to deliver it and that was my first time to meet *hakujin* (white people). I didn't know what to say, so I just said “Thank you very much!” in a small voice. Then one of them replied “Thank you!!” I thought, “Oh my! How kind!!” Then he gave me a piece of paper. I didn't know what it was so showed it to my brother John when he came home. He looked at it and said, “Hey, Akemi, this is a love letter! His phone number is written on it!” I had only said, “Thank you very much!” That's all! Anyway, that was the first time I saw a huge *hakujin* person and talked to him in English!

Apparently she was still quite shy and introverted when she got her first job but recalls being treated very kindly:

Even when I worked at the insurance company, they all treated me like a tiny girl, and a quiet one, so I just enjoyed my job without trouble. I worked there until I married and had my first baby (a girl). The boss wanted me to come back to work, but I wanted to stay with my baby girl and care for her. I used to take her to a clinic and I had to study English so was always carrying my Japanese dictionary with me in order to understand the new words and their meanings.

Akemi does not remember experiencing racial bullying or discrimination when she first arrived in Vancouver. However, she does recall her older sisters Mary and Betty seemingly being discriminated against once when they were trying to find an apartment to rent:

They wanted to rent a room in the West End. They were perfect at speaking English on the phone and were told that a room was available and to come over and look at it, but when

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they went to look at the room, they were told it was already rented out. So, there was still some discrimination.

Akemi's brother John had a good friend named Shig Hirai, and he introduced her to him. Shig used to often come to the Eto house. Akemi, being a very cautious person, first regarded Shig as a just a valued friend as she really wanted to have friends.

I felt comfortable with Shig because my parents knew his parents. I was such a careful person actually, so didn't want to go out with many guys. But I felt comfortable talking with him—he was very good at talking and talked about his old times, and I thought, “Oh my goodness, he has a lot in common with me!” He was still working in a barbershop at that time...I was very happy to meet Shig. He was liked by everybody.

Soon their relationship would blossom into romance and marriage. By the time she and Shig started *Maneki* restaurant, she felt more comfortable using English although Shig did most of the talking with customers, and a lot of Japanese was spoken by the staff and the Japanese customers:

When we opened *Maneki* Restaurant, I didn't have to talk much English with the customers, as Shig was the one who talked to everyone. By that time I was able to speak English more easily, and more than half of the customers spoke in Japanese. The restaurant employed many local girls—mostly Kika-nisei's (second-generation Japanese Canadians who had moved to Japan and come back to Canada) as waitresses and kitchen workers also. So, mostly Japanese was spoken. There weren't very many places for Kika to work, so many of them wanted to work for us and that's how we started to learn more about families and enjoyed one another—it was like a family reunion sometimes. I still remember that the price of a huge plate of curry rice was only \$1.75 (some of the customers said they couldn't finish it!). Udon with shrimp tempura was about the same price. Dinner was a full course meal starting from *otsumami* (appetizers), and by the time they finished eating the customers were rolling over on their *zabutons* and exclaiming what a great meal they had eaten. So, we were doing fine and Shig's childhood dream to start a restaurant had come true!

Akemi does remember one unforgettable experience of racism that occurred later when she and Shig had just established the first *Fujiya* Japanese grocery store on Powell Street in 1977.

I was doing cashier and a lady with a cane walked past with a man who looked like her son. The man was about to open the door, but then the lady saw the sign on the door and realized that it was a Japanese food store, so she banged it with the cane and said “This is a Jap store,” and then she grabbed her son and walked away...she must have had a reason for that—perhaps she had lost her husband or a son in the Second World War so couldn't help it!

Naomi

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As the youngest sibling (14), Naomi, who had spent almost her entire childhood in Japan, had the hardest obstacles to overcome when the family returned to Canada. She had no knowledge of the English language or Canadian culture and had to face her teenage years in a completely new and unfamiliar environment. Fortunately, she was naturally good at talking and communicating with others, which really helped her learn English quickly, and she was able to adapt quite well compared to other returnees in her age group, even finding a job as a live-in babysitter for a very socially prominent family during her first summer in Canada. The lady of the household was very gracious and entrusted Naomi with the job of looking after their three children. During this time, she found herself reading bedtime stories to the family's seven-year-old, which vastly improved her own English. This experience was an impetus for her to continue her schooling.

Yet, she does remember experiencing some difficulties, including occasional racial discrimination. She recalls, "I think I was kind of bullied, because my teacher was not very kind, but I made lots of friends. On the first day, some students said, 'Jap go home!' I think I dealt with it pretty well—I'm pretty tough. Later I went to hair dressing school and became a hairdresser." She was slim and tall and enrolled in a modelling school. 18 years of age at the time, she was the only Asian girl in the modelling school, which turned out to be an asset for her, and she successfully did modelling and hairdressing for several years until she got married.

Currently Akemi continues to live in her home in Burnaby where she enjoys working in her garden and regularly visits Shig in the care home, and Margaret continues to live with Naomi and her family in Port Moody. Naomi and husband Yutaka still make occasional visits to Japan.

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Roy Uyeda

Life in Canada and Japan Before the War

Roy Uyeda was born in a small fishing hamlet called Celtic Cannery⁴² on November 10, 1933, to Tokinosuke and Shige (Kadota) Uyeda. Roy was the youngest child and had three brothers and five sisters. His father was from a small village called Takatsuka in Fukuoka prefecture in Kyushu where he had apprenticed in farming for five years from the age of 12.

Tokinosuke moved to Canada in 1894 at the age of 17. He initially found employment in the forestry industry and subsequently moved to Wyoming in the US to work in the mines, and then to Grande Prairie (Alberta) where he worked on ranches. Next, he moved to Skeena (British Columbia) where he started his career as a fisherman. While there he married Shige Kadota through the then common “Picture Bride” arranged marriage system. Together they ran a Japanese restaurant while he continued fishing. After a few years, they moved with their children down the coast to Gambier Island in Howe Sound near Vancouver where he ran a logging camp.

Sometime during the early 1920s he moved with his growing family to Celtic Cannery⁴³ where he again worked as a fisherman and eventually accumulated sufficient money to purchase a boat. Although the cannery had closed, the village continued to exist as a fishing hamlet inhabited by about 25 close-knit Japanese families and just a handful of single non-Japanese residents, so Japanese was the main language and the village was in effect a microcosm of Japanese culture.

Roy’s eldest brother Jim also became a very daring and successful fisherman and just before the war invested much of his profits in new fishing equipment. Roy’s second eldest brother Tom by contrast was studious and dutiful so was much loved by his family, especially the father. He briefly opened an electrical sales and repair shop in Vancouver but the venture failed, largely due to anti-Asian discrimination which was rampant in Vancouver at that time. Consequently, at his father’s earnest urging, he went to Japan in 1940 where he was immediately hired by Yasukawa Electrical Manufacturing Company.

In April of 1940, Roy and Marion enrolled in grades one and three respectively in the Shiida Elementary School in their father’s home village of Takatsuka in Fukushima, Kyushu prefecture. At that time, Japanese society had become “completely militarized,” and Roy reminisces about how strongly this impacted his school life:

One day the principal announced that, from that day forth, all male students were “the soldiers of the imperial nation of Japan” and every male student was to salute instead of bowing, so we saluted everywhere and we were proud. We were just bedraggled kids saluting, so I think if somebody had taken a newsreel it would have been quite comical. [For example,] if we were walking along the street in a group of four or five kids, the first pupil that spotted an important person must give the

⁴² For information on the history of Celtic Cannery and its Japanese Canadian residents, see <https://placethatmatter.ca/location/celtic-cannery/>. Now it is called Celtic Shipyards (<https://heritagevancouver.org/top10-watch-list/2017/4-celtic-shipyards/>)

⁴³ For a summary of the history of Celtic Cannery, see <https://www.landscapesofinjustice.com/news/celtic-cannery/>

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command to salute and, until that dignitary passed, we must keep saluting until the same student would say that it was alright to finish the salute. So that's how militarism really got hold of the whole country. And, for the boys in grade seven and up, there used to be a professional army officer assigned to our school and there were a lot of older rifles from the Russo-Japanese war—the corridors were just lined with rifles. So, all the grade seven and eight kids would be obliged to go through a military drill with a professional army officer giving out the commands. So that's how militarism really pervaded the whole country. But at least there was social order—everybody behaved very correctly. Politeness was taken for granted and when we got on the train, everybody was very polite (Okaeri video 61:01~).

In early 1940, after only six months in Japan, Roy's father returned alone to Canada where his favorite son Tom, as mentioned above, was preparing to move to Japan to escape racial barriers to his career in Canada and pursue his vocation as an electrical engineer. They would have only a short time together as Tom soon boarded the same boat to Japan that had just brought his father back to Canada.

Roy's mother passed away in Japan at the end of January 1941, so Roy and his sister were brought back to Canada by their eldest brother Jim. Roy recalls noticing a group of Jewish people on the ship who he later learned were escaping to Canada from Lithuania with visas issued by Chiune Sugihara, the Japanese diplomat who became famous for saving thousands of Jewish lives by issuing the visas in defiance of his own government's order not to do so.

Pre-War Life and Wartime Internment

In September 1941, Roy and his sister Marion enrolled in Kerrisdale Elementary School in Vancouver. Because he could only speak a few simple words in English and did not even know how to write the alphabet, he was moved back to grade one. This, combined with the drastic difference in educational culture from the very regimented and militarized elementary school he had just come from in Japan, turned out to be the first major culture shock of his childhood. Another aspect of his culture shock was the more carefree social atmosphere and interactions he experienced in his Canadian elementary school. However, he persevered and seemed to be coping fairly well until everything was changed by the bombing of Pearl Harbor which occurred less than a month after his eighth birthday.

On the [following] Monday morning when I came to school...I passed a small group of boys talking together, and as I passed there one of them said, "Here's a Jap!" and ever since then every day after school there would be some kids hiding behind the bushes. They would shower me with rocks. So, every day I had to come up with a strategy to elude these kids...It was not a pleasant thing at all. (Okaeri video 8:30~).

Even Roy's Chinese classmates started to avoid him and his sister and, in some cases, joined in the racial bigotry against them, referring to them as "Japs," a term that Roy says "stings" him to this day. He recalls, "At lunch, no one sat with me. I was so sad, so sad." (Tatsuo Kage interview, 1991). Roy also recalls a particularly shocking experience of racial prejudice at the hands of an elementary school teacher who called him "a Jap kid" and grilled him "like a

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criminal” for unwittingly taking home and repairing a broken wagon that had been donated as material for the war effort. (Okaeri video 1:08:40)

Like other Japanese Canadians, at the beginning of the war Roy’s family had all their property, including the fishing boats and equipment owned by his father and eldest brother, confiscated and sold off at a fraction of their actual value by the Canadian government. Roy’s father was so indignant at the government’s sell-off of his property and goods without his consent and its paltry offer of remuneration that he refused to accept any of it. They were sent to Hastings Park for a few weeks and then to Slocan City internment camp in June where they were initially housed in army tents until construction of the living quarters could be completed. Just before winter started, they were moved to flimsily constructed wooden shacks.

Roy came to really enjoy his life in the camp, partly due to the pristine natural environment and partly due to no longer having to deal with the racial prejudice he had been enduring in Vancouver.

As kids we missed toys...but, other than that, I liked nature. I liked the mountains, bushes, and birds. So, I had a grand time, always romping in the hills...watching bears and deer all over...wild hares, rabbits. (Rebeca Salas interview)

He also recalls that, due to the rationing of sugar, the kids received a very limited amount of candy and other sweets and instead ate a lot of dried apples, prunes, and other varieties of fruit which, in retrospect, were much healthier.

Roy also has fond memories and a very high regard for the high-quality education he received in the camp elementary school thanks to the dedication and professionalism of his teachers (Tatsuo Kage, interview).

During the war most Japanese Canadians completely lost contact with their relatives in Japan. However, around 1943 Roy’s family received an ominous letter from relatives in Japan through the International Red Cross saying that the employment of the second son Tom had been disrupted by his conscription into the Japanese military in late 1941 and his army unit had been dispatched to Burma (now Myanmar).

Exile to Japan, Arduous Journey to Father’s Home Village

Roy’s father was among those Japanese Canadians who made the decision to be sent to Japan, largely because of the complete betrayal he felt from the way the Canadian government had violated his rights as a Canadian citizen and had dispossessed him of all the property he had spent so many years laboring to build up. (Tatsuo Kage, *Uprooted Again*, p.86). Roy elaborates:

He was a naturalized Canadian, but [the certificate of citizenship] was just a piece of scrap paper. It said that as a Canadian he was entitled to various rights, but in reality that meant nothing. He was already 69 so he had nothing to look forward to. When one is in a situation like that, he thinks of his homeland, so he decided that, even if he went to eastern Canada, the place would be a totally strange land, and he couldn’t speak English very well, so the only recourse was to go back to his homeland. So, the two youngest sisters, myself,

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and my dad—just four of us went. The older of my two youngest sisters wrote to my eldest brother who was living in Montreal and asked him what she should do. He replied that she was old enough to decide for herself, so she decided to go to Japan. My (other) sister, who was just two and a half years older than me, and I were too young to decide, so the four of us went. The other members of our family stayed in Canada.

Although only twelve years old and hence too young to resist his father's decision to return to Japan taking Roy and his sisters, Roy had very complicated feelings about the decision. On the one hand, in contrast to most Japanese Canadian children, he had at least briefly lived in Japan and attended elementary school there about five years before. Hence, he spoke Japanese as his first language and was no stranger to Japanese life and culture.⁴⁴ Yet, the circumstances behind moving to Japan this time were very different from those of his previous trip. He explains:

I always heard on the news that Japan had lost a big war and that the U.S. bombed it heavily. After all, there was the atomic bombing. So, I was worried, even as a child, about what would happen if I went to a place where such a thing had happened. I didn't fully understand what was happening, but [I now knew] I was going to be kicked out of Canada...Before the war, when I went to Japan, I was free to go there and free to come back. This time, even though I was going to the same place as that time, I felt a sense of heaviness or uneasiness because it was different from that time. It was a complicated feeling in my childish mind. We were the enemy, and Japan lost.... They told us that we were going to be sent outside (British Columbia) anyway, and that we had to make a choice, either to move east of the Rockies or go to Japan. We had two choices, but (both) were not good ones. It was an ultimatum, so I had mixed feelings and a lot of anxiety.

Most of the Japanese Canadians who went to Japan had either become naturalized Canadian citizens like Roy's father or were Canadian-born like Roy and his siblings. Although some of the children, like Roy, had spent some time in Japan before the war, often for educational purposes, most had never even visited Japan and it was a foreign country to them. Regarding this paradox and his relatively fortunate status Roy explains, "We were called 'repatriates' which means that you go back to your former place of birth, but more than 65 per cent of the kids didn't speak Japanese and they had never been to Japan, whereas I had two years of schooling there, so for me, I wasn't going to a strange country." (Okaeri video, 18:00~)

Roy, his father, and his two older sisters departed Vancouver on the General MC Meigs on June 16, 1946 as the first group of exiles to go to Japan. It had previously been a troop transport ship, so the sleeping quarters were extremely crowded. Roy recalls meeting Spanish-speaking Nikkei on the boat who were from Peru but had been interned in the US during the war⁴⁵ (Kage, *Uprooted Again*, 87). Roy elaborates:

⁴⁴ Likewise he had become comfortable with English due being exposed to it at school five days a week from autumn 1941 until his departure to Japan in June 1946.

⁴⁵ Kage: In the 1930s the Peruvian government had stripped second-generation Japanese Peruvians of their citizenship and sent 1800 of them to American internment camps, then refused to accept them back after the war, so the US sent 750 of them to Japan (Kage, *Uprooted Again*, p. 87).

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Together with us Japanese Canadians onboard the General MC Meigs was a bunch of well-tanned boys about my age, some a bit younger, some a bit older, running around, but they weren't talking in English to each other. I didn't know what to make of them at first, although I guessed they were Japanese like us or they wouldn't be on the same boat headed for Japan. Later I found out that they were Japanese from Peru and they had been detained in the US for some time. I later learned too that they had been treated badly twice – once by the Peruvian country and then by the US, those poor people!

During the two-week voyage, many of the passengers, including Roy, became very seasick.

We were housed near the rear end of the boat, so I could feel the rear of the boat going up and down and I was sick many days...Lemons were treasured on the boat. Everything would make us sick except lemons, so we sucked on a lot of lemons during the trip. We were too sick to eat normal food so the lemons were very refreshing.

Yet, for those not too seasick to eat, the food was plentiful. Roy explains, "Inside the ship, the food was very rich because it was an American ship...we could eat as much as we wanted: chicken, beef, anything. There was plenty of everything. The richness of America was [visible] everywhere you could go on the ship." (Tatsuo Kage interview)

Roy also remembers their arrival in Japan and his first view of the devastation of the war:

As the ship approached the Tokyo Bay region one day around noon, we could see the land of Japan from about thirty or forty miles out. Gradually it got closer and closer, and we reached the Yokohama port area in the late afternoon or early evening. My dad was very happy and felt a peace of mind that he was coming back to his home... By the time we docked at Yokohama it was already nighttime. As our boat came into the port area, we saw the first signs of the destruction caused by American bombing. It was the first time we realized how intense the bombing had been.

The next day, the passengers were transferred to the Uraga repatriation center in Kurihama where they stayed for about two weeks and received various inoculations and so on as arrangements were made for their return to their home villages.

We were housed in one of the big three-story barracks—it had been a training ground for the Japanese Imperial Navy and had been turned into a processing center for people coming back to Japan from all over. And we saw lots of troops returning from the theater of war. They would be brought back to Kurihama where they would be processed and then put on trains to wherever they lived, and we were treated in the same fashion. While we were there, we were fed leftovers from the Japanese armed forces.

Ironically, the surrounding wreckage of war became a kind of playground for the children as Roy explains:

In the Kurihama former naval training base's adjacent huge yards there were signs of fierce battles that Japan had fought. One yard had piles of train wreckage—mountains of rusting train steel. Adjacent to that yard was another big area where there were a lot of destroyed

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anti-aircraft guns placed on swiveling mounts, all with their muzzles cut in half with acetylene torches to make them useless anymore. They were designed so the seats and guns could swivel and elevate. We would get up on them and play. As we sat on the seats and hand-operated them to point the guns in any angle in any direction, we could imagine and picture the opposing side's aircraft maneuvering to come in and attack. On one end of the field there was also a single-seat Japanese fighter plane still in pretty good shape. I recall seeing that the instrument panel was completely in Japanese—that really struck me. Close to that was a big seaplane. We also used to get on it.”

Roy was also surprised to notice an important historical monument nearby:

We wandered all over the huge Kurihama former Imperial naval training base and explored its immediate surrounding areas and one day, very close to the seashore's foaming edge, we came upon a massive monument with inscriptions in Japanese and English and it was for commemorating the site of none other than the epoch-making landing of Commodore Mathew B. Perry, USN, in 1853 with his four gigantic “kurobune” – “black boats” as they were known... The Japanese people had never before set eyes on such monstrous contraptions which repeatedly fired their powerful guns which intimidated to the bones the Tokugawa shogunate to open up the country to foreign countries from the slumber of a self-imposed closed country policy of nearly 300 years. I had learned this part of Japanese history of Commodore Perry's landing in Slocan in my grade 5 history lesson.

After about two weeks at the repatriation center in Kurihama, they boarded a train bound for their father's home village (Takatsuka) in Fukuoka prefecture. Roy vividly describes the chaotic conditions on the train:

We were placed on special coaches on the train so we had quite a lot of seats at the beginning. There were volunteer university students with armbands to help people coming back to Japan. They took care of us, got on the train, and used megaphones to warn everybody to watch out for pickpockets and other thugs as Japan was destitute and there were people who would steal anything they could. But at a certain point they had to get off and go back, so we were left on our own. I don't remember what we ate. It took about two days. The train stopped at every station from Kurihama to Shimonoseki, which is at the south end of Honshu island, and then we got on another local train [in Kyushu]. It was hot and there was not much food to speak of. There was much distress and chaos. Every time the train came to a stop, there were hordes of people with backpacks. It was hot so the windows were open. Nobody bothered going through the proper entrances—they would come to the window, throw their backpacks in through the window—they literally crawled over our knees to get inside. They would get into fistfights, and everything was chaotic. We had to put up with this stuff every time the train came to a station. They were mostly people in their 30s and 40s. Japan was normally a well-mannered country, but these people had no manners—it was everybody for himself and survival of the fittest, and the strongest won. It made me sick to my stomach. I think the majority of these people trying to get on

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the train at each station were people going from the cities to the countryside to barter for food. So, they would pack their backpacks as full as they could. Money didn't mean much then, so they bartered."

Although still a child, the chaos and fighting Roy witnessed on the train was completely contrary to the orderliness and politeness he had experienced in pre-war Japan, and it left him shocked and disillusioned. He explains:

This made my childish mind shut down. I wondered what was going on. When I say prewar Japan, I think it was when I was in the second grade. Imperialism had finally come to power. I entered a Japanese school and learned Japanese etiquette, such as bowing. Boys were required to [salute] like soldiers, so they had to stand up straight like soldiers, like troops. So we were all made to salute—raise our hands, and salute. But, I can at least say that there was a great deal of order. They respected the elderly. (However,) after the war, there were special trains for the repatriates, but as soon as the train left Kurihama, everything became chaotic. There was fighting for seats and such, and I must say, I had a very dark feeling in my heart as a child. I didn't know what was going to happen now that I had come to this kind of place.

The views of destruction seen from the train further shocked Roy:

Along the way we would see the bombed-out shells of factories, with a big electrical motor left in the corner and nothing else, just the steel girders of the factory skeleton. We saw lots of this devastation—it was very unpleasant. When we got to Hiroshima, everybody's mouth was gaping—nobody said anything, because everything was completely flat except for a few rough lean-to shelters. The station was just rough timbers nailed together. (Okaeri video 22:00~)

However, throughout this long arduous train journey, their spirits were being sustained by a "strong and cherished" hope:

On the trip to Kyushu there was one bright thing that we were looking forward to, especially my dad: That was his second son (Tom), his favorite son on whom he doted, who was dutiful and quiet and studious and all that, so my dad looked forward to seeing him, and we did too, but my dad first and most of all looked forward to reuniting with him. (Okaeri video 23:00~)

However, this hope was cruelly dashed upon their arrival at their father's home village:

The evening that we reached our father's village, we were given lodging by a kind person and the first thing that my sisters and I asked his family was, "Where is our brother?" We asked the oldest daughter and she was just stuck for words and said, "Mother, what should I do?" So, we knew that our brother hadn't returned from the front lines, and she didn't have to say anything more. He was killed in action, or maybe he died from starvation or maybe he died from illness or something like that... We were just crushed, but life had to go on. (Okaeri video 23:00)

Roy additionally reflects:

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The greatest and most terrible thing that happened to me and my family from the war was the loss of our beloved brother Tom. Especially our father's sense of loss was extremely keen. To our father he had been the most ideal son he could ever want—always dutiful, quiet, conscientious, studious, friendly, kind, and yet a firm individual. My father's only hope in returning to his homeland after losing everything in Canada was to reunite with his favorite son whom he was sure would be back from the war front or would surely yet come back. He had always worked so hard to save for his studies while always being mindful too of the wellbeing of our family. When Tom was accepted by Yasukawa Electrical Works and his future looked most promising, this was a true joy for our father to see his most cherished son attain such a wonderful result after so long of having exerted efforts. But now all that was dashed to smithereens.

This devastating shock was further exacerbated by an extraordinary irony:

The night we received lodging in Takatsuka at the home of Mr. Toshio Ozaki, our former boarder in Slocan, and learned of our dear brother's death on the battlefield of Burma, we also learned of something else that was really amazing. Mr. Ozaki's younger brother Jiro, who had been in the Japanese army for eight years, also happened to be assigned to Burma. Mr. Ozaki's mother related to us that, one evening just after bedtime, she heard some rustling and thought that it could be a thief trying to break in to steal something, since Japan right after the war was direly destitute and pilferage was widespread throughout the country. But no, it was not a thief trying to break in but was Jiro who had returned home alive from the battlefield in Burma. According to him, he was on a reconnaissance mission when his unit encountered British forces. There was a firefight between the two forces and he received a bullet in his lower abdomen, was taken prisoner, treated, nursed back to health, and eventually returned to Japan alive after the fighting stopped. What a story, what good fate for Jiro, who was utmost fortunate, in contrast to our Tom who was utterly ill-fated.

Life in Post-War Japan

The day after their arrival in their father's ancestral village Takatsuka, Roy, his father, and two sisters moved to their uncle's house. Eventually they received more permanent lodging in an abandoned clinic owned by a relative. Roy explains, "A relative had a medical clinic right in the center of the village, but it had been closed several years before the war when a hospital was built. So, it was available as a place for us to live after the war, and we received consent from the cousin who owned it to stay there."

Several weeks later, they were surprised by the arrival some other family members who they had thought would stay in Canada. Roy explains:

My eldest brother Jim and third brother Bob stayed in Canada [but] my eldest sister Mary and her family as well as my second sister Kay and her family came to Japan in mid-August 1946 unexpectedly, onboard the General M C Meigs on her second Pacific

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crossing. My father and the two youngest sisters with whom I went to Japan in June thought that the two older sisters would stay in Canada.

Compared to the cold-hearted reception experienced by many Japanese Canadian exiles in their ancestral villages, Roy feels that what his family members experienced was relatively better:

For us it wasn't that bad. I had spent two years there before the war (1939-41), and my mother had passed away in that village, so we were not strangers there. I don't remember being unwelcome, although they didn't really welcome us with open arms. A lot of soldiers also came back to the village the same time we did. Many families lost their loved ones but many came back...our village was not terribly crowded as far as I remember."

It also helped that his father still retained the skills he had learned as a young farming apprentice before leaving Japan for Canada. The people of his village were impressed by his ability to help them with their farm work when he returned to Japan after the war.

Roy's older sisters' English ability enabled them to quickly find employment with the 24th Infantry Division of the American Occupation Forces stationed in the nearby city of Kokura. In addition to receiving free lodging, they were paid well enough to be able to send some much-needed financial support to Roy and his father who continued living in Takatsuka.

Despite the relatively positive reception of Roy's family, they were not exempt from the severe lack of food, and Roy remembers constantly feeling hungry and never being able to eat enough to feel satisfied:

We used to barter after we got back to Fukuoka. We used whatever things we could to trade to get food. Rice was very hard to get, even in the countryside, so my dad used to go around buying "third-crop squash." The first crop is the best, the second crop is somewhat lower grade, and the third crop is very low grade. It was disfigured and very tasteless, but it was the cheapest too. We would boil it, sprinkle some salt on it, and eat it. At least it was food. I often felt we were eating food that was worse than what we used to feed the chickens in the Slocan internment camp in Canada. That food shortage continued for about three years, and then it gradually got better. Rice sales were strictly controlled by the government so there was a lot of black-market selling. When I ate a meal, I had to think about the others and make sure I did not completely fill my stomach. In Japan a lot of people used a weed called Obako, which became black when baked. Nutritionally it was probably pretty good—not very attractive, but a lot of people made bread out of it. At the dinner table, we [stopped eating before our stomachs felt] full. After a while my dad's trousers became very baggy because he lost so much weight. We did not have a rice field or garden, so we had to buy or barter for everything.

Regarding the common practice of bartering goods for food, Roy adds:

Right after end of war, bartering clothing for food was prevalent throughout Japan and the expression "takenoko seikatsu" (literally "bamboo-shoot way of life") was equally prevalent, meaning that one sheds layers of clothing to exchange for food, like the young

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bamboo shoot sheds its outer layers of skin one after another. Then after a while, someone said, “No, that’s not quite right, it should be more like, ‘tamanegi seikatsu’, (“onion way of life”) because each time you shed a piece of clothing off your back to barter for food, you also shed tears—like when you peel an onion, tears well up in your eyes!

Many exiled children report having felt extremely conspicuous upon their arrival in Japan, partly due the kinds of clothing they were wearing. Roy was no exception. He says, “In the beginning we wore the clothing we took with us so we stood out right away in school. The Japanese students wore uniforms, but we wore ordinary clothing and that made us stand out. Also, the Japanese kids had really short haircuts, but ours were longer.” Nevertheless, he does not think that he suffered an unusual amount of bullying.

I ran into a few people who called me names. The people there all considered us to be Americans, so we were called ‘Amerika-jin.’ They couldn’t differentiate us from Americans. Everyone from North America was called ‘Amerika-jin’⁴⁶ [but] there were very few instances where I was treated as unwelcome. I was treated as a kind of novelty as I could speak English. There were a few instances where people were unkind, but that was rare. People who returned from the colonies had a Japanese education, whereas people like me coming from North America were quite different. On the whole, I was fortunate.

That September, Roy was enrolled in the local school. He was now 12 years old. Although he had forgotten much of his Japanese while living in Canada for the previous five years, thanks to having previously lived in Japan for two years he could still speak somewhat better than most other exile children who really struggled with the language and hence had to start from grade one regardless of their age. Hence, he was only moved two years behind his agetates from grade seven to grade five and was able to adjust with relatively less difficulty than most Canadian child exiles his age. He also received some individual help from a kind teacher. Yet it was still a struggle for him, especially reading and writing Japanese:

I entered school from grade five. The teachers were quite conservative generally, and they revered the emperor. But my teacher was quite broad minded and interested in places like Canada. In the beginning, he individually helped me learn to use the abacus and to write Chinese characters...I was treated pretty much like everybody else. I got along with my classmates.

Elsewhere he says,

At that time the class was studying Japanese classics and they used very sophisticated archaic language and I didn't know what they were talking about. I was just lost. But one thing that saved me was that the teacher was an excellent storyteller and he would tell us in ordinary everyday language about how the hero of each section of the book was a real

⁴⁶ Roy adds, “All returnees from North America were referred to as “Amerika-gaeri”--returnees from America. They couldn’t differentiate the Canadians from the Americans. I think many, many Japanese really didn’t even know that such a nation as Canada existed.” (Personal correspondence, February 12, 2025)

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person who existed in history, and he would tell us about the all kinds of stories and most of them were about samurai warriors and I just loved listening to samurai stories. So, he would tell us in a very interesting way, so that saved the day [for me]. I went on from elementary to middle school and on to high school and graduated from high school in 1954 Spring (Okaeri video 25:30~).

During his eight years of elementary and high school education in his father's hometown, Roy lost much of his English conversation ability. He explains:

For reading, I always had enough materials since my sisters brought home various kinds from the US army camp where they worked. As for writing, I every so often wrote letters to Canada. And for listening, there was a US Armed Forces radio network which had a few stations broadcasting throughout the day in English and also a British Forces station which I listened to sometimes. But for speaking, I very seldom had any occasion to do so, other than with my sisters who occasionally came home from their stay in their dormitory. So, when I graduated from the Japanese high school in Spring of 1954, I often spoke English from my own devices and not so much in the natural way of expression as I had forgotten much of the idiomatic ways of saying things. Somehow however, I managed to retain the natural North American pronunciation and accent of English.

However, his first job after graduating from high school would give him the opportunity he needed to revive and improve his English-speaking ability. After finishing high school in 1954, he considered enlisting in the Canadian Armed Forces, but as the Korean War had ended the previous year, it was impossible to do so (Kage, *Uprooted Again*, p. 87). So, he instead found employment as a civilian staff with the American forces at the nearby Tsuiki Air force base. It had been used by the Americans during the Korean War but was returned to Japan in 1951 and was now being used as a training base for the Japanese Self Defense Air Force.

Roy's job on the base was to monitor the on-the-job training program for non-pilot Japanese personnel such as mechanics, firemen, supply men, and all other ground support staff and help ensure the training proceeded smoothly. Doing so was a real challenge that involved a lot of intercultural interaction, interpreting, and constant moving between various locations on the base. This became an education itself, both in terms of language skill and intercultural understanding. Although it was a hard job, it paid well, and Roy continued there for three years, during which time he was able to save quite a lot of money.

In 1957 the base was completely turned over to the Japanese Self Defense Forces and Roy's job became obsolete. He was offered a better job elsewhere by the American Forces, but by then was strongly feeling the urge to return to Canada, so although deeply appreciative of the kind offer, he gratefully declined. Japan was also feeling "too crowded" for him.

Return to Canada and Readjustment to Canadian Life

The Canadian government decided in 1949 to allow Japanese Canadians exiled to Japan to restore their Canadian citizenship which had been taken from them when they agreed to be sent

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to Japan. Eexiles scattered throughout Japan were advised to go to Tokyo, visit the Canadian embassy, and reapply for Canadian citizenship. Roy did so and received his citizenship certificate in April, 1953.

He often talked with those around him about the possibility of going back to Canada, but his superior officer at the Tsuiki Air Base encouraged him to move to the US instead, saying he could get a good job in the car sales business there. The officer even went to the US embassy on Roy's behalf to enquire about the procedures for Roy to immigrate to the US, thinking it would be easy due to Roy's restored Canadian citizenship. However, the embassy explained that, despite Roy's Canadian citizenship, the US law still categorized immigration applicants not by citizenship but by race, and only a very small quota of Japanese were being accepted into the US each year. In hindsight, Roy believes this outcome, though discriminatory, turned out to be a good thing because Canada is now safer than the US.

In 1958, at the age of 24, though apprehensive about again suffering racial discrimination, Roy returned to Canada. Of his motivation to return, he says, "I will call it roots, just like a salmon going upriver to where it was born. My family were fishermen, so it was something like that." (Okaeri video, 39:00~). Another motivation was that he still had siblings living in Canada.

Despite having been born in Canada and having spent most of his early childhood there, Roy recalls experiencing various difficulties related to culture shock and racial discrimination upon his return.

I was in Japan for 12 years after the war, and the Japanese culture had seeped into me more than I realized. I was bi-cultural, but I was more Japanese than Canadian. Some people told me I was more Japanese than someone born and raised in Japan. When I came back to Canada, emotionally it took me a long time to re-acclimatize to the local atmosphere, and there was still quite a lot of anti-Japanese feeling.

He spent the first year in Vancouver but really struggled to find suitable employment and thinks he probably would have ended up homeless on the street had he not received free room and board from a young lawyer's family in exchange for doing various chores around their house and yard, a system that was quite common for young Japanese returnees then. Eventually, after several weeks of persistent job hunting, he was able to find employment in Vancouver, but it turned out to be rather short-lived.

I found work with Brook Bond Canada, a maker of coffee and tea imported from India, especially Darjeeling tea. They would blend the tea in Canada. I got a job there as a shipper. I had gone to many places but there was no work, but one day I just decided to step into their office, and there happened to be a job as a shipper. But I made the bad mistake of resisting my immediate boss passively, and one day he informed me that they had no more work for me and were laying me off. I had started in July and was laid off in November. So, I went all around Vancouver again job hunting but couldn't even find a dishwasher's job. Because I had worked for four months, I was entitled to some

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unemployment benefits. At the time I was still doing chores for a lawyer's family and received room and board in exchange, so at least I had a place to stay.

Roy speculates that racism might also have been one of the factors in his firing and subsequent inability to find a new job. He says,

I often heard the word 'Japs' both on the streets and at work. Hearing that word really stung me. Had I not been a Japanese, I might not have been fired right away and could have been given another chance, but they never warned me or gave a reason. In 1959 I went around Vancouver in one last attempt to find work but to no avail.

While in Vancouver, Roy was able to get some training in data processing and using data processing machines at an IBM center. This apparently lasted for about five months, during which time he accumulated considerable knowledge about the data processing field, and it would hold him in good stead for his future job-hunting endeavors.

At the urging of one of his older brothers who were living in Montreal, Roy decided to move there and live with him. This move in the Spring of 1959 led to an immediate improvement in his situation.

I had two older brothers living in Montreal, and I was young and wanted to see the world more and gain more experience, so I decided to move to Montreal. Everything there was French which was very different and very refreshing, but best of all I didn't feel any discrimination in contrast to Vancouver.

His recently acquired knowledge of data processing turned out to be a real asset as within two weeks of his arrival he had received three job offers so could choose the one he liked the most. His first job was at the Canadian head office of a French company in Montreal. After working there for about 17 months, he moved in late 1960 to Northern Telecom where he worked for 16 years. While working there, he also attended university night classes where he mainly studied commerce. His efforts to combine work with serious study resulted in sleep deprivation and fatigue as he was taking too many difficult courses, so he had to suspend his studies, and it took him about three years to recover his "courage and stamina." Then he began taking night courses again, this time in geography and history, hoping to become a teacher. This second academic venture while working fulltime was also a tough experience with several setbacks and it took him nine years to graduate. Unfortunately, by that time, the job market for teachers had deteriorated, so he gave up his dream to become a teacher (Okaeri video 48:00~).

Because Roy lived in the English section of Montreal, he never became proficient in the French language but he did enjoy experiencing French Canadian culture, even doing a short "homestay" on a French-Canadian dairy farm. He explains:

When I was in Japan, I was impressed by some American servicemen who, despite not speaking a word of Japanese, used to adventurously go around the Japanese countryside. I thought about that and decided I wanted to do something similar. So, one summer, through a friend, I got to spend a week on a French-Canadian dairy farm in the outskirts of Quebec City. Nobody spoke English there. This was in 1960. I didn't learn enough French to speak

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but I became somewhat able to feel comfortable in a completely French speaking environment, and I wasn't completely lost. If I had stayed longer, I might have learned to speak French.

This adventure caught the attention of a local French newspaper which published an article about it.

While in Montreal, Roy became a Christian and initially attended a Presbyterian church where he was introduced by a friend to Mizue Yuriko Yamada who had come to Canada a few years before as an independent immigrant. Her first job was working for a clothing company in Toronto before moving to Montreal. She had been raised Catholic in Japan but started attending the protestant church after coming to Canada. They married in 1974. While in Montreal, Mizue became actively involved in an NPO assisting elderly immigrants, and Roy often helped her.

Although Roy enjoyed life in Montreal and his friendships with French-Canadians, compared to Vancouver the winter climate was often severe and really affected his health. In the early 1970s, the Quebec political climate also began to change and the separatist party rose to power in 1976. This caused him deep concern about what might transpire, so he decided to move back to Vancouver although apprehensive about the possibility of yet again facing racial discrimination and joblessness there (Okaeri video 52:30).

The first several years of my life in Quebec were fine. Winters were very harsh, but [it was a] good life there. I had a good time, good French-Canadian friends, but the separatists began gaining momentum and in 1976 they won majority in the government, and separation from Canada became a real possibility. And then I started thinking...there was going to be lots of upheaval and disruption there. In 1942 I was only a child, but I experienced a lot of upheaval and a lot of hardship. So, I didn't want to go through another [experience] like that. So, I started thinking twice about continuing to live in Quebec (Rebeca Salas interview).

In 1977 he moved back to Vancouver with Mizue. He found that the racial discrimination situation in Vancouver was vastly improved but still existed, and some companies and banks were still excluding people of Asian descent from good jobs. Again he struggled to find good work in Vancouver and at first did part time jobs. In 1978, while working part time, he also volunteered with MOSAIC, an NPO that assisted new immigrants. While there he mainly did interpreting. In June he attended a conference of volunteers where he met some key persons in the Japanese Canadian community who would influence his future. In September, the well-known Japanese volunteer organization Tonari Gumi⁴⁷ advertised for people to help with Japanese Canadian seniors. Roy had gotten some experience helping his wife assist seniors in Montreal who couldn't speak English, so he applied and was accepted to work at Tonari Gumi in October 1978. Tonari Gumi was always on a shoestring budget so sometimes he didn't get paid and worked as a virtual volunteer.

⁴⁷ Link to homepage of Tonari Gumi: <https://www.tonarigumi.ca>

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His official employment with Tonari Gumi finished at the end of 1988, but in spring 1989 he continued there as a regular volunteer teaching English to senior citizens every week. This went on for 24 years until the end of 2013, soon after he turned 80. Simultaneously, from spring of 1989, he had become a free-lance interpreter/translator. In the early 80s, while working as a staff at Tonari Gumi, he had taken evening courses in court interpreting which he now did frequently as a free-lancer. He retired from this work around 2009. However, he still does some volunteering at the Nikkei Cultural Centre in Burnaby whenever he is asked to if he feels he has time and it is something he can handle.

After moving to Vancouver, Roy and his wife also continued to be active in church life. They tried several churches before settling on Faith Baptist Church in southeast Vancouver where they attended 13 years. Then they switched to the Japanese Gospel Church which has since relocated from inner city Vancouver to New Westminster. Presently they are attending New Westminster Evangelical Free Church where the minister, a former missionary to Japan, can speak fluent Japanese. It holds both Japanese and English worship services.

Roy's Reflections on Culture Shock, Discrimination, Cultural Identity and Bilingualism

With his detailed recollections of his various experiences of uprooting, racial bigotry, exile to Japan, and repatriation to Canada, Roy often reflects on the significance of those experiences both for himself and for society at large.

Experiences of Racism

Roy's mindset is still strongly affected by his own experiences of the racial persecution he experienced, especially as an elementary school child in Vancouver. He frequently comments that hearing the pejorative term "Jap," first used against him by his classmates as a small child and again after his return to Vancouver as a young man, still "stings" him. He believes the little kids in his elementary school who tormented him verbally and "showered" him with stones on his way home from school during the early days of the war did so largely because they had been influenced by the racist rhetoric of their parents. He warns adults that talking negatively about other races will result in their children quickly absorbing their racism:

I want them to realize that the adults have a very heavy responsibility to never talk bad or belittle other races because that will automatically make their children become racial bigots ...The kids who discriminated against me—they were too young to be discriminatory. They should have been "colorblind" but because the adults talked [negatively] about us, they automatically inhaled that and became racial bigots. I'm sure that's how it was when I was attending grade school (Okaeri video 67:00~).

Roy also ponders the irrationality of the racial discrimination against Japanese Canadians generally by the government of a supposedly democratic country such as Canada:

Later on, when I became more mature, I got to thinking...how could a democratic country like Canada have treated us like that? It's almost like, you know, a country like Hitler's Germany or even Japan's militarism or even Stalin's Soviet Union. They're not democratic,

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they're totalitarian, they're, you know, they're harsher regimes. So, you might expect that kind of thing to happen, but in a country where they open up the country with one hand on the bible and one hand on the shovel...that kind of country would do that? I couldn't make sense of it. But, at least in 1988, the Mulroney government finally recognized it. So... I came to believe that Canada's still a good country (Rebeca Salas interview)

He further notes the extreme irony of Canada accepting the Lithuanian Jewish refugees (whom he had met as a small child on the ship back to Canada) before the war although it would later be deporting its own Japanese Canadian citizens at the end of the war.

When the Japanese Canadians began the redress movement in the 1980s in an effort to get Canada to recognize and redress the grave wrong that it meted out to its own citizens from 1942 to 1949, I awoke to the saving of the Jewish people. It was mighty commendable for Canada to have helped these people in far Europe, but I noticed the biiiiiggggg double standard here. What they did [for the Lithuanian Jewish refugees] was very, very nice, but on the other hand, they confiscated and sold off for a pittance all the properties of Japanese Canadians who were their own people and forced the main portion of them to move out of BC. For those who didn't or couldn't do so, they forced them to volunteer to go to Japan while forfeiting their Canadian citizenship regardless of birth or naturalization.

Gratitude for Loyalty of White Friends

Yet, while deploring the racism perpetrated by white Canadians against Japanese Canadians, Roy also reflects with gratitude about some white Canadians who remained steadfast friends of his family at a time when it was very unpopular to even associate with the Japanese Canadians:

When things go bad, you find who your real friends are. And we did find some, a couple of Canadian people, and I think by them befriending us they were put in a pretty uncomfortable position themselves. But... they stuck it out with us. They were friends and they proved themselves. True friends, those people...One man, he had a small cartage company called Columbia Cartage and he kept associating with us until the last minute. I remember him shaking hands with my father before we shipped off to Slocan (internment camp) He was a true friend until the last minute. There was another veteran from the First World War and he kept corresponding with us in Slocan. When we were being shipped to Japan, he came to see us off at the CPR rail yard. Yeah. That was very hard...he was a friend until the last....They were loyal to us, even through the war time. My second brother had a friend in Celtic, a white person. We used to call him, in Japanese, "Shush" or something....He even joined my brother's Japanese class. And so, you know, he would participate in the Japanese Christmas concert. It was very comical. In the war time, he even came to visit my brother in Slocan. He was in the army.... Yeah, these kinds of people...so broad-minded, so friendly, and so warm. In those days ...these people were great, great people (Rebeca Salas interview).

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On Being Bicultural and Bilingual

Like many of the Japanese Canadian exiles, Roy has a very ambiguous sense of his cultural identity. In a 1991 interview with Tatsuo Kage, joked with Tatsuo Kage that, although being a second generation Japanese Canadian, he probably seems to be more like a first-generation Japanese immigrant (Issei). He expressed this blurred sense of cultural identity in more detail in an interview with Rebeca Salas:

Although I'm biculturally a complete mixture, strictly speaking I'm more Japanese-y type. Has nothing to do with which is better or which is worse. I'm just saying, speaking objectively. My wife would say that too, and other people would. I'm bilingual, so if I'm with Japanese from Japan I speak like them. And if I'm speaking with Canadians, I speak like them... The Japanese [on the ship back to Canada] thought I was a pure Japanese-born, Japanese-bred individual. So, when they saw me talking English with some other white passenger, they said "How come? How come you're speaking English?" They thought it just didn't fit me. I said, "I'm Canadian-born." People thought I was a real Japanese. And my wife tells me that I'm a real Japanese-type individual... Sometimes, [I feel] both, but I've lived in Canada much longer than Japan. So, I think I'm more Canadian... Some people don't know how to judge me. "Is he Canadian or is he Japanese?" People don't know....

In the same interview, he elaborated on what he considers some positive and enriching results of his life experiences that made him bicultural and bilingual:

Right now, I'm glad that I came through some hard times and I could appreciate things more... Changing from Canada to Japan and Japan to Canada... the culture's so different and it's disruptive. Especially as a child, it's kind of hard. But, I'm glad I went through that because I can appreciate things Canadian more, I can appreciate things Japanese more... It's a worthwhile process to go through. It enriches my life a lot more... It's sometimes been awkward... (but) I think in both languages and I get better appreciation. I'm Christian, so I use [both the English and Japanese] Bible and I get a better view, a better appreciation of things, you know? In that respect, I'm glad. In a way, I'm glad I went through a lot of uncomfortable times in the past. In Japanese, there's a saying that roughly translates, "One should go and initiatively grab situations and undergo hardship," and you would come out a better person... I'm not that brave to go forward and grab such situations, but circumstances... made me go through those things (Rebeca Salas interview)

Regarding the big differences between the Japanese and English languages he explains:

Japanese and English are so different, you know? Enunciation is different, grammar is so different, the sentence structure is different. Simply speaking, English and our language are reverse. In English you say, "I go to school." In Japanese you say, "I to school go." That's how the Japanese sentence structure is made. So, when you translate or interpret [a Japanese sentence], you have to listen to the very last verb to see if "he went" or if "he didn't go" (Rebeca Salas interview)

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Roy further describes how he coped with this difference in language structure, tone, and level of directness when working as a court interpreter:

When I used to go to the trial courts to interpret, I had to wait until the last word [of the sentence] to see if “he went there or did not go”.... Traditionally, Japanese culture is that we don't come out straightforwardly. We go in a roundabout way to say something to soften the blow. So, to a Japanese [person in court the lawyer] would ask, “Did you go there that morning?” And this person would answer, “Well, that day was very cloudy and sunny, and I didn't feel too great and I was wondering if I should take an umbrella or something,” and all blah, blah, blah. So, the court interpreter has to interpret just as is. And the [lawyer] questioning says, “I don't care how you thought...did you go or did you not go?!” The questioner wants to know if he or she went or did not go. But, the Japanese has to go all over all kinds of things and go in a roundabout way. That's our culture. So, an interpreter must be a cultural interpreter, too. We were taught that. Not just language, be a cultural interpreter (Rebeca Salas interview).

Chapter 3: Recollections of Exiles interviewed by Kirk—Those Who Stayed Permanently in Japan

Suejiro and Mitsue Ibuki

One Japanese Canadian who opted for exile to Japan with his young family instead of dispersal to eastern Canada was Suejiro Ibuki. As he is no longer alive, this history of his life relies heavily on the recollections of his son Mikio (who is featured in the next chapter) as well as photographs, personal letters, and various official documents related to Suejiro's life. Fortunately, he left a significant amount of such materials which have been faithfully preserved by Mikio. For the basic outline of his life history, two of the most useful documents were his handwritten English resume of the jobs he had held both in Canada and during the period after his return to Japan and a brief article based on an interview with him by Art Miki that was published in the *Nikkei Voice* (November, 1989).

Suejiro was born on April 28, 1908 in Mitsuya, a small farming village on Lake Biwa near Hikone city⁴⁸ in Shiga Prefecture, the fourth son among four brothers and four sisters. He left Mitsuya for Canada in September of 1923, at the age of 15. In addition to his sense of adventure, one reason for his leaving Japan was that he did not pass the entrance examination of Omi Hachiman Commercial High School, which limited his future career options within Japan. He chose Canada as his destination because he had an older sister already living in Vancouver with her husband. Furthermore, his older brother Totaro already had plans to go to Canada, so Suejiro decided to accompany him.

Life in Vancouver

After arriving in Vancouver, he resided in the Powell Street area, which was where many of the new Japanese migrants to Vancouver settled. Although he was 15 years old and had already finished elementary school in Japan, he entered the nearby Strathcona Public Elementary School at the grade 1 level as was common for new immigrant young people who could not speak English well. He quickly jumped several grades during the following months. He transferred to Seymour Public School in September, 1924, and finished primary school in June, 1925, and then began high school. Soon he began working as a night clerk at the Owl Drug Store at 197 East Hastings Street, continuing until June of 1928. In 1927 he entered Vancouver City Night School of Commerce and graduated in 1928, after which he began working as a shipping clerk and later as a travelling salesman at E.A. Morris Ltd., located at 435 East Hastings Street. He continued this job until the uprooting of Japanese Canadians from the west coast in 1942.

In addition to his work, it seems Suejiro had an active intellectual and social lifestyle. He

⁴⁸ Now Mitsuya is part of Hikone city.

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enjoyed writing and was a member of a small literary coterie composed of several male friends. He even tried his hand at writing some short novels, some with a distinctly erotic flair, and had several articles and short stories published in the Vancouver Japanese newspapers. He was also an avid photographer and took numerous photos and videos of life in Vancouver which were kept and stored by Mikio. It appears from some photos that he was quite an avid golfer in his free time. Judging from his photos and his correspondence with various people, he seems to have had a lot of friends in the Japanese community and to have been very popular among the young ladies. Years later, this was confirmed to his son Mikio by various people who had known Suejiro during that time. Mikio once met a lady who had been one of his father's girlfriends and got the impression that she still loved him.

In November of 1934 Suejiro returned to Japan for three months, during which time he met his wife-to-be, Mitsue Otake, through the introduction by an older brother living in Tokyo. She had been born on February 8, 1918, and raised in Tokyo (Senjyu-cho, Minami-Adachi-Gun) where her father worked as an artisan (tortoise shell art, and later carving images on fountain pens). At the time, she was employed by Marubeni Company. They married at the Meiji Jingu (shrine), and Suejiro then went back to Canada alone. About one year later (February, 1936), at the age of 16, Mitsue sailed alone to Canada and joined him.

At first, the new couple lived at 431 East Georgia Street until 1936, and then at 501 Hastings Street until their uprooting in 1942. They had a happy marriage and their life in pre-war Vancouver also seems to have been comfortable. Although Mitsue's English ability was limited, they enjoyed an active social life within the Japanese community as can be seen in several photos and videos of them picnicking and socializing with friends. On January 1, 1940, they were blessed with their first child, Mikio. As far as Mikio knows, they intended to stay in Canada permanently. Suejiro's parents had already passed away before he left Japan, and his correspondence with his relatives in Shiga Prefecture was not very frequent. However, until the war began, he and Mitsue sent many letters to her family in Tokyo, often including photos of their baby Mikio.

After the Japanese attacks on Pearl Harbor and the British colonies Malaya, Singapore, and Hong Kong in December of 1941, the Ibuki family, like the other Japanese immigrants and descendents living on the west coast, were dispossessed of all their property and goods and forcibly uprooted from their homes by the Canadian government. Subsequently they were incarcerated in the Slocan City internment camp from July 1942 to September 1946. Suejiro was initially sent to a road construction camp as were many of the able-bodied Nikkei men but, because Mitsue was pregnant with their second child, he was soon allowed to leave and join his family in the internment camp. He did various kinds of work in the camp, including cleaning chimneys. He was also active as a member of the camp residents' self-governing committee and at one time served as the committee leader.

Their second and third children were born at Slocan City during the internment. The second child, a girl was born on July 9, 1942. She was the first baby born to Japanese internees of the

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camp, so everyone celebrated. She was named Gloria by the attending nurse, but Kazuko (和子, literally “child of peace”) by her parents, which expressed their wartime wish for a return to peace. Their second son, Toshiaki, was born on November 3, 1944.⁴⁹

Exile to Japan

Suejiro and Mitsue were among the Nikkei who agreed to be exiled to Japan rather than move to eastern Canada. Mikio believes the most compelling reason for this was their extreme anxiety regarding the wellbeing of Mitsue’s parents in Tokyo. As mentioned earlier, there was no contact between the Nikkei Canadians and their loved ones in Japan during the war, and the resulting desperation to reestablish contact and confirm the survival and welfare of loved ones became one of the strongest motivations to accept the choice of exile. Mikio says his father also had another strong motive to return to Japan—the wish to use his experience in Canada to help rebuild a better and more internationalized Japan following its destruction in the senseless war.

In October of 1946, Suejiro and his family boarded the *Marine Falcon*, one of the three ships chartered by the Canadian government to transport Japanese Canadians to Japan. According to the Repatriate Card issued to the family upon arrival in Japan, the ship left Vancouver on October 2 and arrived in Kurihama on October 15. Suejiro was the group leader of the Japanese Canadian passengers.

The adult exiles had received 200 dollars and each child 50 dollars from the Canadian government as part of the agreement to go to Japan. However, it rapidly lost most of its value and it could only be accessed in small quantities. Therefore Suejiro took with him many large boxes and trunks filled with various kinds of goods including rice, canned goods, medicines, sweets, etc.), both to help sustain his own family and to share in his ancestral village. Obviously he had heeded the strong advice, based the dire conditions experienced by exiles who had arrived earlier, to take as many such goods to Japan as possible.

The *Marine Falcon* was originally scheduled to arrive at Yokosuka, but as that port was already full, it was diverted to Kurihama. Soon after arriving in Japan, the Ibuki family learned the heartbreaking news from Mitsue’s father that her mother had passed away during the war. The family spent the first few days in Japan at the repatriation center at Uraga and then stayed a few more days at the home of Suejiro’s elder brother in Mikata, Tokyo, after which they went by train to Mitsuya, Suejiro’s home village in Shiga.⁵⁰

After an arduous journey by train, they finally arrived in Mitsuya. Like many who returned to their home villages in Japan after the war, they faced serious difficulties upon their arrival. The most immediate problem was that there was no room for them in the family house so instead they had to move into a nearby storage shed where they lived for a year and a half. They had no electricity, so for lighting they depended on a kerosene lamp. Like many other exiles, they experienced friction with their relatives, partly due to the severe shortage of food. Everyone was

⁴⁹ For more details about their internment at Slocan city, see the subsequent chapter about Mikio Ibuki.

⁵⁰ This train journey is described in more detail in the next chapter about Mikio Ibuki.

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lacking food and other basic necessities, and although Suejiro had brought many goods from Canada to share in the village, they were quickly used up and resentment resulted. Fortunately, in April, 1948, they were able to move away from Mitsuya to Otsu City for Suejiro's employment.

Suejiro's first job after returning to Japan was as an assistant managing director with Hokoku Sangyo Ltd., a textile company in Nagahama City managed by his nephew. After one year there, in 1947 he was able to get employed as a Labor Liaison and Advisor by the Labor Section of the US Armed Forces at Otsu City. This position involved him in the hiring of Japanese workers for the base, which employed a total of 6000 Japanese civilian workers, and it enabled him to help many of his relatives and friends get employment there. He studied hard about various aspects of his job, but he was handicapped by his lack of a college or university education, and this limited his advancement. This hardship later led him to make sure his children got a good university education. He was transferred to Nara in 1957 where he continued working until the US Armed Forces closed its camp there in 1958.

The following three years were quite difficult for him economically, but he did engage in various kinds of jobs to support his family including sewing machine sales and established a small English school which continued for three years. He also started to teach English conversation lessons as a volunteer to many people of all ages at Otsu City Hall, which continued for 35 years. These jobs helped provide money for his children's education. He later told Mikio that, from the time he returned to Japan, he strongly felt that teaching English was the best way he could help Japan become an international country and contribute to mutual understanding and world peace.

His economic situation significantly improved in 1961 when he was employed by Jinbo Pearl Ltd., to which he had been introduced by his elder brother's daughter who was married to the company's founder. During the following years the Japanese economy continued to grow and his career in the pearl industry went well. He soon began to work at a subsidiary pearl exporting company, Jinbo Pearl Exporting Ltd., located in Kobe. His son Mikio joined him in this company in 1962. Six months later, Suejiro moved to the company's pearl farm in Shiga and continued to work there for six more years. Then, at age 60, he started his own company in Otsu City, Jinbo Shinju Shokai Ltd., which retailed fresh water pearls from Lake Biwa. Many of the pearls were supplied by his son Mikio who continued to work in the pearl export company. Mikio recalls that this was a very enjoyable period of Suejiro's life. Incidentally, his company is still active and is managed by his younger son, Toshiaki and his daughter (Name?).

Suejiro apparently regretted his decision to return to Japan, and he often apologized to his children, saying that it was a mistake. Through his life he continued to stay in contact with his friends in the Nikkei community in Canada. In addition to personal correspondence and sending Japanese magazines to various friends in Canada, he occasionally contributed to Japanese publications in Canada.

Interestingly, although he encouraged his children to move back to Canada, he himself never returned to Canada, even for a visit. His son Mikio is not sure why, but speculates it might have

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been because he did not wish to be reminded of what he had suffered there. Perhaps another reason was that he had a successful career in the pearl business in Japan. However, in a brief profile based on an interview with Art Miki,⁵¹ he commented that he hoped one of his children would move to Canada so that he himself would be able to go and visit, so it is clear that he at least thought about it. His wife Mitsue did visit Canada once with their daughter for two weeks in the autumn of 1994 at the invitation of her niece's daughter who was living in Toronto. In addition to Toronto, she went to Vancouver and visited one of the apartment buildings where they had lived before the internment. It still looked the same as when they had left it at the time of their uprooting, and she was moved to tears.

In 1990 he was awarded the Honobono Taisho prize in recognition of his educational contribution to the city through his 35 years of teaching English classes at Otsu City Hall. On February 17, 1995, Suejiro passed away at the age of 87. His wife Mitsue followed him eight years later on November 5, 2002, at the age of 83.

The following chapter focuses on the life history of their son Mikio.

⁵¹ Published in the *Nikkei Voice* (November, 1989)

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Mikio Ibuki

Mikio Ibuki is an interesting example of a Japanese Canadian exile who initially was making plans to return to Canada but due to circumstances ended up staying permanently in Japan. He was born in Vancouver on January 1, 1940 as the first child of Suejiro and Mitsue Ibuki (see previous chapter). He has a younger sister, Kazuko (born July 9, 1942 in Slocan City), and a younger brother Toshiaki (born November 3, 1944 in Slocan City). He himself was only two years and six months old when his family was uprooted by the Canadian government, so he has almost no recollections of his life in Vancouver except for a very faint memory of watching a moving train and his mother worrying about him getting too close to it.

Life at Slocan City Internment Camp

After the forced uprooting from their home in Vancouver, Mikio's family was incarcerated at Slocan City internment camp from July 1942 to September 1946. His father Suejiro was briefly sent to a road construction camp but was soon allowed to join his wife Mitsue and son Mikio at Slocan due to her pregnancy with their second child. While Mikio only vaguely remembers watching the scenery from the train carrying him and his mother from Vancouver to Slocan City, he has many vivid memories of his childhood experiences in the camp during the almost four subsequent years. He says that, although his parents must have been suffering emotionally from their uprooting and the confiscation of their property, they did not pass on their anguish to their children, so most of his memories of this period are pleasant, heartwarming, and in some cases, amusing.

Many of his happiest recollections relate to attending the camp kindergarten run by teachers from the Anglican Church and have been kept alive by various mementos he still has from those days, including photos of his kindergarten class and various events such as graduation ceremonies, Christmas pageants and other class activities. Amazingly, he also still has some of the pictures he drew and handicrafts he made, as well as Bible story pamphlets and pictures received from his kindergarten teachers. He nostalgically remembers being taught common children's songs such as "Row, Row, Row Your Boat" and "Jesus Loves Me This I Know." He recalls his teachers treating him very kindly and this left him with a very positive and warm impression of non-Japanese Canadians and Christianity which continued long after he left the camp.

He spent much of his time playing outside and made many friends with other children. Manabu Murakami and his younger brother Tsumoro, who lived in the same building (#12) were among his close friends. He recalls various activities with them such as making a fire on the river bank and roasting wieners. They also got into mischief together. Once they entered an empty house and searched for anything worth taking. Another time they boarded an empty train that was stopped at Slocan City, peeled the rubber lining from a window and used it to make a

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slingshot with which they shot a sparrow. Mikio took the sparrow to his mother as a present, was severely scolded by her, and then buried it.

Various sports activities were also a big part of his life in the camp. Once he injured his arm while wrestling with his friends and cried loudly while being taken to the hospital, thinking the arm was broken. Fortunately, it turned out to be a minor sprain and healed quickly. Although he himself did not own ice skates and does not recall playing or even watching ice hockey, he does remember borrowing skates from an older friend. He has a picture of himself smiling happily as he sits on the edge of an outdoor ice rink, holding a hockey stick and wearing skates that are clearly several sizes too big for him. He also has memories of sleigh riding and watching baseball games although he did not play much baseball himself. After the war, the Murakami brothers moved with their family to eastern Canada. Mikio really wanted to meet them again but unfortunately completely lost contact with them.

He also has numerous memories of the beauty of nature around the camp such as small colorful flowers, ferns, and pussy willow bushes growing luxuriantly in a swampy area near the lake. He recalls catching minnows with a net, taking them home in a bucket, and leaving the bucket near the doorway. The fish soon died and started to smell bad. After a severe scolding from his mother, he carried the bucket of dead fish outside and buried them. He also remembers trying to catch reddish-colored fish¹ with his hands in the river near the camp's movie theater.

Other memories from the internment include his younger siblings' births, specifically watching the special celebrations following the birth of his sister, Kazuko, the first baby born to Japanese Canadians in the Slocan City camp, and looking out the hospital window when his brother was born. He also has pleasant memories of occasionally being allowed to accompany his father to some of his various jobs in the camp.

Exile to Japan

At the age of six Mikio was exiled with his family to Japan. The first leg of this journey was going by train back to Vancouver to board the ship. He recalls seeing at the time many large wooden boxes and trunks packed by his father with food and other goods to be distributed in his home village.

During the journey, he noticed a white lady handing out balloons to some white children on the ship's deck. When Mikio approached her for a balloon, she coldly refused and said that the balloons were "not for Japanese children." This is his only memory of overt racial discrimination, but it was an experience he never forgot. Other memories of the journey relate to his mother, who was severely seasick for several days. He also recalls their first glimpse of the contours of the Japanese islands in the distance, the appearance of numerous small fishing boats, and his mother shedding tears as they neared port. As they disembarked, the passengers noticed a brass band performing a welcoming ceremony and at first thought it was welcoming them, only to learn later that the welcome was for Elizabeth Vining who had come to Japan from the US to serve as the private tutor of the crown prince.

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After disembarking, the Ibuki family spent several days at the Uruga repatriation center. There was still destruction from the war everywhere. Mikio remembers seeing and playing on the nearby remains of destroyed military vehicles and large artillery. His sister became ill and was given *okayu* (soft-boiled rice) to eat. Mikio also really wanted some *okayu* but was refused because there was too little and it was reserved for sick persons. He can't remember what food they did receive there, but does recall that it tasted so bad he couldn't eat it. Fortunately, his father had brought from Canada a lot of foods and sweets to give away, so for some time Mikio's diet consisted largely of chocolates provided by his father.

One pleasant memory of the repatriation camp was being allowed to ride together with his father on an American military jeep and seeing various places including the ruins of Nakajima Airport and the port at Yokosuka. Apparently this opportunity arose because his father was the group leader of the Japanese Canadian passengers on the ship and was summoned to the military headquarters to be debriefed.

A very moving memory concerns the emotional reunion of his mother with her father. A small festival and outdoor market were being held at a nearby shrine. Mikio recalls going there with his mother and buying a small piece of persimmon from one of the outdoor vending shops, then walking down a narrow gravel street with her and suddenly meeting up with her father. This meeting was a surprise as they had completely lost contact with her family during the war. Apparently her father had by chance read in the newspaper about the ship arriving from Canada and had seen the name of Mikio's father as the leader of the group of Japanese Canadian passengers, so he immediately came to find them. Mikio's mother and her father embraced each other and cried loudly. Perhaps one reason for their open crying was the fact that her mother had passed away during the war and this was her father's first chance to communicate this heartbreaking news to his daughter.

The family stayed for about a week at the home of Mikio's maternal uncle in Mitaka City, Tokyo before setting out on the arduous train trip to Mitsuya, the home town of Mikio's father in Shiga prefecture. The journey by train was excruciating as the passengers were squeezed close together with some lying on the floor, making it very difficult to move. It was so crowded that the Ibuki family were unable to get off the train when it stopped at Kawase, the station closest to their home, so they had to stay on until it reached the main station at Kyoto. Even at Kyoto it was impossible to exit through the doors, so they had to somehow find their way out through the windows. Then they boarded another train and backtracked to Kawase where a relative with a trailer cart⁵² was waiting to meet them.

Mikio recalls various tensions and frictions which arose between his parents and his relatives due to the extreme living conditions in the village after the war. As there was no space for them in the family house, they lived for a year and a half in a storage shed. Mikio refers to this time as

⁵² This kind of trailer cart, called a rear car (リヤカー) in Japanese, was commonly used to carry various kinds of loads before automobiles became common in Japan. It was usually pulled either by a bicycle or by a person on foot.

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their “kerosene lamp life” due to the lack of electricity and their resulting dependence on the kerosene lamp for light.

He also has vivid memories of the tensions with relatives that were exacerbated by the severe food shortages. Once he picked a persimmon from a relative’s tree and started to eat it. Unfortunately, it tasted unexpectedly bitter so after one bite he threw it onto the ground. The relative, extremely angry that Mikio had wasted this precious food, severely scolded not only Mikio, but also his mother Mitsue, who apologized profusely. Mikio recalls that his mother, who was only 28 years old at the time, was always apologizing to relatives during this period. It must have been especially difficult for Mitsue, who had been born and raised in Tokyo and hence was a newcomer to her husband’s ancestral village, to adapt, especially in such extreme circumstances. Mikio also recalls noticing some serious tensions between his father and his elder brother and wife, although he does not remember the details.

Mikio soon entered elementary school (Take Primary School) in Mitsuya. While in Canada, his parents had endeavored to teach him Japanese using various methods such as singing Japanese children’s songs with him. Despite their efforts, at that time he had not been very motivated to learn. Hence, when he arrived in Japan, he knew only a few Japanese words. In addition, and was unfamiliar with the local customs, so for some time felt quite disoriented.

Fortunately, his elementary school teacher, Miss Tanaka, took a special interest in helping him and gave him special individual tutoring after regular class hours. He does not remember her explicitly teaching him Japanese but does recall her spending extra time with him and listening to what he had to say. He told her about Canada and sang English children’s songs to her. This personal emotional support from Miss Tanaka alleviated his confusion and anxiety, and before long he began to enjoy school life.

Soon he was acting in school activities and recalls participating in a school festival where he played a role as a dancer in *The Monkey’s Cage* (お猿のカゴ屋)、and also the role of the monkey in *The Battle between the Monkey and the Crab* (サルカニ合戦). From this time on, his Japanese ability improved rapidly albeit while he gradually forgot his English. Another school memory is using old printed textbooks, some parts of which were covered with thin paper or blackened over with charcoal because they were about the emperor or contained content deemed to be nationalist propaganda.

Mikio does not recall being overtly bullied by his classmates over his language or cultural shortcomings but was teased and called a girl because he was wearing a red sweater. He was also laughed at because his lunch bento consisted mainly of sweet potatoes (his preference), while those of the other children were mainly rice. Overall, he does not remember feeling particularly troubled during his adjustment to Japanese life and thinks that he adapted and learned the language fairly quickly, thanks largely to the support of Miss Tanaka and also because he was just under seven years old when he arrived in Japan.

In 1948, Mikio’s family moved to Otsu city for his father’s work where he completed elementary school at Nagara Primary School in 1952. He then graduated from Ojiyama Junior

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High School and Zeze Senior High School. He belonged to the baseball teams at both schools, and remembers wearing number 11 at Zeze where he “was a benchwarmer.” That year Zeze was very strong and advanced to the Koshien Spring Tournament.

At the age of 17, Mikio converted to Christianity. At the time he was experiencing various anxieties about his situation as a high school student and his future life course. One day he saw a leaflet advertising an evangelistic meeting at the Otsu United Church, so he attended and listened to the sermon. He soon became a Christian and was baptized. He now believes this conversion experience was partly “the result of the seed planted” by the teachers during his time at the Anglican kindergarten in the Slocan City internment camp. Ever since his conversion he has been actively involved in the Japanese United Church. He also met his wife Kana Ikeda, an organist, at the Otsu United Church and they married on May 1, 1966. They later moved to Okamoto in east Kobe where they are still active members of the Okamoto United Church. Perhaps it is no coincidence that Mikio, who has such pleasant memories of the Anglican kindergarten in Slocan City internment camp, now regularly volunteers in the church’s kindergarten.

Mikio did well academically in high school and was accepted into the Economics Department of Doshisha University, a prestigious university with Christian roots located in Kyoto. He credits his mother with playing a very significant role in his successful elementary and high school education. He recalls her attending his university entrance ceremony and his feeling at that time that this was the best present he could give her. He made several close friends among his classmates, and regrets losing contact with two of them, Kota Otsuka and Ikuo Ebata who went back to Canada after graduating from Doshisha University.

Initial Plan to Return to Canada and Eventual Permanent Stay in Japan

Mikio’s father Suejiro expressed regret for his decision to return to Japan and often apologized to his children, saying that it was a mistake. Furthermore, he frequently urged Mikio to move back to Canada and make a new life there, saying, “Mikio, Japan is not the country that you are meant to live in. Japan is too cramped for you, and your personality is much more suited to living overseas. I really want you to make your life in Canada!” Mikio has never forgotten these words of his father and believes he was wishing for his own lost Canadian dream to be fulfilled by Mikio.

Consequently, while still a university student, Mikio made plans to move to Canada after graduating. However, as the time of his graduation (March, 1962) approached, he received a letter from one of his father’s most trusted friends in Canada, Mrs. Miyake, explaining that the Canadian economy was doing poorly and that it would be better for him to wait a couple more years before making the move, and that he should find employment in Japan in the meantime. This situation was also confirmed through a visit to the Canadian embassy in Tokyo, so Mikio followed her advice and temporarily postponed his return to Canada.

In addition to studying English at university, he had many opportunities to speak English

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with the foreign missionaries in his church and became quite fluent. In order to save more money for his future move to Canada, he looked for some part time employment in Japan. On one occasion he worked together with his father as a simultaneous interpreter at an international trade fair for small and medium sized businesses held in Osaka. One of the displays at the fair was by a pearl company located at Lake Biwa called Jinbo Pearl Company. It happened to be managed by the husband of a cousin, and Mikio's father had already started working there. At the fair, the majority of Mikio's work involved negotiating with foreign buyers. Although he was extremely busy, he found this work very interesting.

In 1957, the son of the owner established a new export company in Kobe called Jinbo Pearls Exporting Co. Ltd. which dealt with processing and exporting Biwa freshwater pearls. Mikio's father transferred to this new company and Mikio was also offered a position which he eagerly accepted and he started working there after graduating from Doshisha University. This was the beginning of his career with the company which would continue for 30 years. At first, his work consisted mainly of sending letters to various pearl import companies around the world in order to start business relationships with them. However, he eventually became vice president and was involved in all aspects of the company management including buying and selling. The company grew from about five or six employees to more than 20. However, he resigned from this career in 1992 following the bursting of the economic bubble.

Next, he worked for two years at Kobe Gyosei Gakkuen, a private high school that specialized in educating special-needs students, where he taught history, English, and bookkeeping. In 1994 he started working as a clerk at a transportation company. This mainly involved various kinds of administrative work and taking care of the drivers. Due to poor health he retired from this position in 1997.

In 1998 he returned to the pearl business, joining the Japan Pearl Exporters Association. At first he just did bookkeeping, but his duties quickly expanded and eventually he became the Executive Director. As such, he engaged in various major activities to promote the export of Japanese Akoya Pearls, established a new pearl inspection system, arranged for international pearl auctions to be held in Kobe, and attended the World Pearl Organization meetings in New York and Tahiti. He also recalls working very hard to enhance the Japanese pearl booth at the Hong Kong Jewelry Show. He retired from this position in 2009 at the age of 69.

However, he continued to be active even in retirement. He was instrumental in establishing the Hyogo Unga Shinjugai Project which he continued to help manage for several years. This organization mainly educates school children about water ecology; for example, the importance of keeping water clean, the roles of marine creatures such as plankton in water ecology, and more specifically, how this relates to the cultivation of pearls. He explains, "Every year, more than 100 children join the project and try their hand at various aspects of operating the farm, harvesting the pearls and cleaning them. In addition, they get to create their own jewelry with the cropped pearls and conduct a pearl fashion show." He adds, "When we started, we initially faced resistance from some pearl company presidents, but we finally succeeded with strong support

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from parent-teacher associations. Now it is very successful. Promoting the understanding of pearls like this in the Pearl City Kobe is the most important work I have ever done in my life, and I am very proud of it.” (Update this information)

Memories about His Mother

Mikio remembers his mother Mitsue as someone who, despite the extreme difficulties and heartbreaks she faced in her life, remained strong and optimistic about the future. As noted earlier, she was only 16 years old when she married. Although she had no training in how to be a housewife and was unable to read or speak English at the time, she travelled alone to Canada to join her husband. After enduring the forced uprooting from the west coast and life in the internment camp during the war, she persevered through the extreme trials she faced living in her husband’s ancestral village in postwar rural Japan. In difficult times she often expressed her enduring optimism with the phrase, “Things will somehow turn out ok” (何とかなるわ). Later she became able to both read and converse quite well in English.

After returning to Japan, in addition to taking care of her family, she worked hard outside the home to supplement her husband’s income. First she got a job working as a housekeeper at the American armed forces camp at Otsu where her husband was also employed. Later, she worked helping the family of the founder of Jinbo Pearl Company where her husband also had started working. Mikio fondly recalls watching a professional baseball game between Hanshin Tigers and Tokyo Giants with her at Koshien Stadium. She possessed a very active curiosity and participated in a variety of activities and hobbies and especially enjoyed cooking and knitting. In her fifties she began to study Chinese poetry recitation (詩吟), and advanced to the top level.

Present Sense of Relation to Canada

Some of the Nikkei exiles interviewed by Kage, who were already teenagers when they were sent to Japan and hence conscious of the injustices they had suffered at the hands of the Canadian government, were very bitter at Canada for years afterwards. In contrast, as noted above, Mikio was so young at the time that his memories even of the internment were mainly pleasant ones—exploring nature, playing and getting into mischief with friends, and enjoying kindergarten life and the kindness of his teachers. Also, his parents did not pass on to him their own anguish from the uprooting and incarceration, and his father rarely even talked about this difficult period, even later in life. Hence Mikio was spared much of the sense of betrayal and resulting anger towards Canada that lingered for many years in the minds of the older exiles.

Although he has never returned to Canada, Mikio has continued to have a deep interest in Canada and Japanese Canadian history, which is attested by his careful preservation of documents, photos, newspaper clippings and other materials related to his family’s time in Canada. He also has continued to read extensively about Japanese Canadian history and related human rights issues. He takes pride in telling people that he was born in Vancouver. He shows no personal bitterness about what his parents suffered in Canada and says, “I am so glad that, in

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spite of everything that happened to my parents, they were finally able to succeed and have a nice life in Japan.”

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The Izumi Sisters

An earlier chapter narrated the life history of Basil Izumi, a second-generation Japanese Canadian who, with his family was exiled to Japan following the war at the age of nine and, at the age of twelve, returned alone to Canada, leaving his parents and two younger sisters in Japan. This chapter picks up the story where that chapter left off, and focuses on the history of the family members Basil left behind in Japan as recollected by his sisters Megumi and Emiko, and their half-sister Junko and picks up where the chapter about Basil left off. For the family's background and life in Canada and life in postwar Japan up to the point when Basil left them and returned to Canada, please refer to the earlier chapter on Basil Izumi.

Following Basil's return to Canada, his father would never have direct contact with him again. His grandmother and aunts in Canada maintained correspondence with his mother, and Basil himself also exchanged a few letters with her at the beginning, but he would not see her again until she visited him in Canada in the mid 1970s. Likewise, his sisters would not meet him again until almost 45 years later in 1993. The sisters recall that both parents keeping in touch with relatives in Canada, and through that correspondence they would get occasional news about how Basil was doing. Megumi recalls:

We did not have contact with Basil directly. We missed him, but there was also our parents' divorce, and perhaps that all the more widened the distance between us... We heard from mother what kinds of work Basil was doing—that he got married, that he became a teacher, that he quit that job, that he moved and got a new job—we heard those things from Mother.

Life in Kyoto

Shortly after Basil returned to Canada, John and his two daughters moved to Kyoto to live with May, close to the American base located near what is now Shimazu Seisakujo, and the family started a new phase of their lives together. Despite having lived in Japan from their earliest childhood, Megumi and Emiko had a strong sense of being different from other children in school and feeling like they belonged to "a strange family." Megumi recalls, "[We were different] in lots of ways. Somehow we felt so. We felt it keenly. As we gradually grew up, we still felt unusual and strange. Thinking about it now, perhaps we should not have felt that way."

This feeling of being different was partly due to some of the "foreign" items they had brought from Canada and were using in Japan. For instance, although they were sleeping on futons, they were using large feather quilts they had brought from Canada to stay warm. They recall feathers being everywhere when these quilts frayed and developed holes. They also recall their mother using a Singer sewing machine they had brought from Canada. In addition, they received some coats with fur collars from relatives in Canada. When the children around them saw them wearing these coats, they teased them and called them Americans.

Likewise, they were similarly teased because their mother May had their hair permed for a school entrance ceremony. Furthermore, May herself also stood out as different from the Japanese mothers of the other school children. Specifically, the girls recall feeling "foreign" at large school activities such as sports events due to their own appearance and their mother's conspicuous appearance. Megumi says:

We were said to look like foreigners when we went to school sports competitions. At the competitions, all the parents would come to see their kids. At those events Mother kind of

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stood out, perhaps because of how she dressed. Maybe it also had something to do with our clothing. Or [we looked different] because we had been in the internment camps, I wonder. We were told that we had the air of foreigners

She also relates a particularly amusing anecdote about how the English spoken by their parents at home made them feel different from their classmates.

When we were in school, there was a katakana spelling test [about English words in Japanese], and I spelled the word ‘cup’ in *katakana* closer to its English pronunciation (カ ッ プ = *kuppu*) rather than how it is pronounced and spelled in Japanese (コ ッ プ = *koppu*), so was marked wrong. Mother complained that カ ッ プ (*kuppu*) is the correct answer, because in our home we pronounced it that way. There were other similar situations.

Another language-related memory is of their feeling embarrassed because their parents would speak English to some friends when they would go as a family to the local *senjo* (public bath) in Kyoto. Megumi explains:

At that time there was a *senjo* nearby. We didn’t have a bath in our house. [Our parents] used to speak English with a woman named Miyauchi san when they were at the *senjo*. I had the feeling they were friends with Miyauchi san, and I wondered if they had been in the camp together although I didn’t hear that they had been friends in Canada. They would suddenly start speaking in English. For us children it was embarrassing. Thinking back on it now, I feel sorry for us children at that time. Mother also spoke English in her sleep.

Sadly, their being conspicuously different invited envy and discrimination from people around them. For instance, the western clothing worn by the family caused envious reactions from others:

We had aunts in Canada, and they sent us western-style clothing... We also received old leather shoes from them, although in those days, leather shoes were not worn in Japan. *Geta* (traditional Japanese wooden sandals) were still worn in schools in those days and kids ran barefoot in the playground. We had leather shoes sent to us from our aunts in Canada, and when we wore them we were bullied... Although we were poor at that time, when we wore coats with fur attached to school, people would say, “Americans!” When we experienced such things, we came to realize that we were somehow really different from other people.

Memories of Their Mother May

After being joined by John and the girls in Kyoto, May continued working as a simultaneous interpreter, translator, and typist at various bases. It seems she was exceptionally skillful as a simultaneous interpreter and could switch seamlessly between English and Japanese. Megumi recalls hearing from May that she had won first prize in several simultaneous interpretation contests held at her workplace. She did well financially as long as the bases remained open.

However, her employment there came to a close when the occupation ended and she subsequently went through a period of economic hardship. At some point around this time John divorced her and left her and the daughters. He remarried and had a third daughter, Junko. May also eventually remarried briefly and had a second son named Katsumi. Her daughters recall her being an extremely hard worker who endured her hardships with fortitude. Megumi explains about this period of May’s life and speculates about possible causes for the divorce as follows:

She was together with us and we endured all our hardships together, always, until she died, right until the end...She was working endlessly from the time when we first came to Japan

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from Canada. Things were good when she was employed in the Occupation forces camps. There was a big camp at what is now Shimazu Seisakujo (in Kyoto)... We moved from Wakayama to a place close to it. At that time, all four of us lived together... Father was working as boiler man at the occupation forces camp. Mother was working as a simultaneous interpreter and a typist. After that she worked at the camp at Otsu, then the camp at Uji. We moved around to various places. Then Father left and mother was alone.... [Soon] that employment [for the occupation forces] disappeared, so she did various kinds of work...she worked as a door-to-door insurance salesperson, did embroidery—she was skilled with her hands, so she did some work for an embroidery company. She was lonely, I think, but she had a relatively calm and optimistic personality. And she was quite tolerant. She endured hardship, when you consider how Father used to go out drinking and so on. I wonder if we had stayed in Canada things would not have turned out this way. After the war ended, everyone became a little strange. After they came to Japan, something (in their relationship) changed away from normal.

In addition to being a hard worker, May was also known for having strong compassion for others and a sense of social justice. Apparently she was fired from one of her part time jobs because she spoke up on behalf of other workers who were being treated unjustly.

Megumi also remembers occasionally going to church with her mother as a child although May's church attendance became more sporadic later in her life. She particularly recalls May taking her to a church on a street corner in Kitadairo in Kyoto, though she does not recall whether it was Anglican like her church in Canada. Many years later Megumi attended the Japanese Anglican church in Vancouver while visiting Basil and recognized the melodies of some of the songs because as a child she had heard them being sung at church and by her mother.

May visited Canada twice and stayed with Basil's family in Vancouver, once in the mid-seventies and again around 1985. While there she expressed her wish to stay in Canada, but the family decided against it as she also had family members (and particularly grandchildren) in Japan, and they worried she would change her mind and decide to again move to Japan, so it seems she gave up on the idea. On September 16, 1991, she passed away in her sleep at the age of 76.

Memories of Their Father John

The Izumi sisters also have various vivid memories of their father John. From their earliest childhood they were impressed by his athleticism and indomitable spirit. Emiko recalls him doing various kinds of competitive sports such as swimming and wrestling and telling the girls how important it is to be able to protect oneself. She says, "He told us that, from when he was small, he got into quarrels with people from various countries, and he won. He entered swimming meets and didn't lose—At least, he said so!" She also remembers seeing him doing bar gymnastic exercises when she was in elementary school, and he continued to do so at least into his fifties.

After the American military bases closed and John lost his employment there, he was hired as a custodian by Kyoto Notre Dame University where he continued working for the rest of his life. His daughters recall him doing various kinds of work at the university. Emiko explains, "He was a boilerman, and he could do simultaneous interpretation. Around that time the chef and some other employees at Notre Dame were foreigners, and he was qualified to be an interpreter.... He (also) worked with garden shrubs and plants, caring for animals, and things like that, kind of like

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a custodian.” Junko adds, “Notre Dame University moved from Shishigatani to where it is now (Sakyo-ku). When it moved, Father planted all the trees one by one. Nowadays they would use an outside contractor for many of the jobs such as painting...but he did all of that.”

Apparently he was in high demand at the university due to his various job skills. Junko recalls:

At that time, Father was the only person at the university who carried a calling bell in case they didn’t know where he was...He always carried the bell. If there was some matter needing attention, they would ask, “Where is Izumi san?” and would try to find him. He was a really hard worker. He kept working well past retirement age.... He was kind toward people, kind to animals. When he took trips far away, he would be called back, for example, to take care of a sick cat. He would even get phone calls while on holiday in Wakayama. He was that kind of person.... He died when he was 73, I think. But he kept working right up to the end.

As noted above, John had divorced May not long after moving to Kyoto to join her and his daughters, remarried, and had another daughter, Junko. Interestingly, Megumi and Emiko noticed a significant change in his personality following the divorce. Megumi recalls:

I don’t know if it was because he felt guilty after separating from Mother, but he was kind after the divorce. Before then, he was short-tempered. They divorced before I entered elementary school, I think. He often came to meet us. Each year on August 16 there is the Daimonji Okuribi Festival in Kyoto. At that time, there was a certain place—we knew that if we went to a certain bridge we could meet him. Without fail he would come there on the 16th. He would look for us while we were watching the burning letters. I remember it, every year. And, as we got older, he often came to our house.

Junko explains how he continued to work even after being diagnosed with terminal cancer:

After surgery, he recovered; however, the cancer came back...[but] to the very end he rode to work on his bicycle, his bicycle! The distance to the school was very far. At the end he lived in Saga, which is at the very west edge [of Kyoto]. Even from there he would ride his bicycle all the way to Sakyoku. He really paid attention to his health. He himself never thought that he would die that way. He said that he would be okay because he had trained his legs by mountain climbing and other kinds of exercise.

As in the case of May, it is not clear to what degree John continued to practice his Anglican faith after returning to Japan. It appears that he became a practicing Catholic while at Notre Dame, a Catholic university. Yet, the woman he remarried was a practicing Zen Buddhist, and it seems that he was also strongly influenced by her beliefs. Junko recalls the following banter between him and her mother:

My mother was Buddhist, a Zen Buddhist. At the end, when he was old, partly in jest she would say, “Will your funeral be in a church or a temple? Do you want a Japanese [or western] ceremony?” He replied, “Either is OK.” He used to say, “All religions are the same. Let’s respect the ancestors. All the religions say similar good things.”

In 1983, at the age of 73, John passed away. His funeral was conducted in a typical Zen Buddhist manner by a priest at Tenryu Temple in Arashiyama but was attended by many Catholic nuns from Notre Dame University. The importance of the role that he had played at Notre Dame was demonstrated by the principal, Sister Beatrice, setting up a picture of him and holding a memorial service for him every Easter.

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Why John and May Never Moved Back to Canada

It remains a mystery why John and May never returned to Canada when it became possible to do so despite their English skills and diverse range of work skills. May stayed in contact with her mother and sisters and would have known that the conditions in Canada were much better than those in postwar Japan. Unlike May, John did not have family in Canada but his close friend James Murakami had established a successful photography studio in Canada and stayed in close contact with him. John's former employer, Mr. Campbell of Campbell Photography Studio in Vancouver continued to send him Christmas cards and stayed in contact with him for many years. So, it would seem that there were good reasons for the family to return.

Basil has no recollection of John ever raising the subject during the three years they were together in Wakayama. His sisters also have no recollection of it being discussed by him. Megumi wonders if she and Emiko, especially after they were settled in school, were a hindrance to their parents moving back to Canada. Both sisters recall becoming naturalized Japanese citizens and renouncing dual citizenship when they were in grade six of elementary school as a requisite for entering junior high school.

Megumi does think John perhaps had thoughts of returning to Canada as he grew older. And, according to Junko, on at least one occasion he said so. She explains, "When he remarried with my mother, he said Japan was no good and that he wanted to go to Canada. But my mother had never lived outside Kyoto and she said she would not go with him, so he didn't go."

In her later life, May did express her wish to return to Canada on several occasions. Megumi vaguely recalls her complaining about life in Japan to her relatives in Canada and saying she wanted to move back there. While visiting Basil's family in Canada she clearly stated that she wanted to move to Canada and live with his family, although Basil and May's sisters doubted that she would have wanted to stay once she started to miss her children and grandchildren in Japan.

Attending Redress Explanation Meeting

After the Canadian government's apology in 1988 for Canada's unjust treatment of Japanese Canadians during the war and offer of financial redress, May, Megumi, and Emiko attended a redress explanation meeting at the New Otani Hotel in Osaka. They had been previously contacted by Basil who informed them about the redress movement in Canada, and that they could apply for redress compensation although living in Japan. They took some photo albums with them and showed them to one of the delegation members. At his request, they handed him two photo albums of which he made photocopies and then returned them at the end of the meeting.

Reestablishment of Communication Between the Sisters and Basil

After Basil left his family in Wakayama to return to Canada in 1949, his sisters did not see him again until 1993, when both visited him in Canada. Basil rented a van and took them around to the various camps in which they had been incarcerated as children. Emiko recalls feeling surprised because the houses in the camps felt smaller than they had imagined from seeing the photos of when they had lived there, and it was hard to imagine that this was really the place where their family had lived during the war.

Basil had always been hesitant to visit Japan, partly due to his indignation that Japan had started the war and had never clearly admitted its responsibility and also because he held some

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complicated feelings towards his parents. However, his daughter Seiko and a cousin visited Japan in 1992 and were shown around by Megumi and Emiko. Basil felt his attitude begin to change as a result of that visit. In 1994, he and his son finally went to Japan and visited Megumi and Emiko. He says he was glad that he made this visit in spite of his earlier misgivings.

Present Situation of Megumi, Emiko, and Junko

Both Megumi and Emiko married Japanese nationals and live near Osaka. In 1964 Megumi married Shigeo Totani, whose family had a business making futons (Japanese mattresses) in the city of Hirakata. They had two sons. Shigeo passed away in 2018. In 1971 Emiko married Shingo Wakabe, whose family business was designing baseball caps. They also had two sons and resided in Sakai city. John's daughter from his second marriage, Junko, is married, has a son and lives in Kyoto.

As far as Megumi and Emiko know, none of their close relatives are presently living in Shimosato although they think the family house is still standing and they do have some relatives living in a nearby town called Nikawa. Their grandmother was their last connection to Shimosato and they occasionally used to visit her there with their children while she was still alive. Interestingly, they point out that she became a 'kind grandmother' and they blame the stress of the war and the dire conditions following the war for her severe treatment of them as children. Megumi says, "That is war—everyone becomes a devil, perhaps."

Megumi notes that, like her father John and her brother Basil, several of John's grandchildren became involved in education. One of her sons teaches in the high school of Kyoto Gaidai and is leader of the swimming club there. The other son teaches in a special needs school in Ishikawa prefecture. Previous to that he was working in a special needs school affiliated with Kanazawa University. Her granddaughter Haruka is aiming to become an English teacher and several years ago went to Vancouver and worked at a Japanese school there for several months. Junko's son also visited Basil's family in Vancouver in 1996, and again with Junko and her mother. Megumi and her husband visited Basil again in 1998. Most recently Megumi and Emiko visited Basil in 2024. These days Basil and his sisters continue to stay in touch, communicating by email in Japanese using *Romaji* (English alphabet).

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Tak Matsuba

Takeshi (Tak) Matsuba was born on December 5, 1926 in Vancouver to Kamejiro and Jiyo Matsuba. Kamejiro was from Mio in Wakayama, and Jiyo was from a nearby village called Fuji. Tak had two younger sisters, Masumi (Marie) and Mikiyo (Miki), and two younger brothers, Noboru (Gabby) and Takumi. All were born in Vancouver, except Takumi, who was born in the Lemon Creek internment camp.

Tak believes Kikumatsu went to Canada shortly before or after 1900, followed later by Kamejiro who was 17. They resided at 151 East Cordova Street in a two-story building where they owned a retail shop which sold dry goods and Japanese foodstuffs. They rented out a spare room to a single Japanese man. In 1935, at the age of 51, Kikumatsu passed away from pulmonary tuberculosis and Kamejiro took over the shop.

As far as Tak recalls, his family enjoyed their lives in Vancouver. Kamejiro spoke English well enough to interpret for others who needed help. He never heard his mother speaking English but “she seemed to understand everything her children were saying, especially when we were up to no good!”

Tak attended a Methodist church kindergarten followed by Strathcona Elementary School and Grandview High School of Commerce. He also enrolled in the Vancouver Japanese Language School. Unfortunately, the war and uprooting interrupted his schooling and he could not finish high school. He does not recall having any particular future dreams at the time:

It was so long ago. I was still in my early teens (so) most likely I was more keenly interested in going out and ‘playing’ with friends than anything else...Like most kids of that time, my life outside school prior to World War II was centered around the Powell Street Grounds playing baseball, softball and soccer. I also played basketball at the United Church gym.⁵³

He does not have many memories of experiencing discrimination before the internment, but does remember a lot of the people in the community, including his parents, talking about it.

When I was being raised in Vancouver, I was never allowed to forget my ancestry. I was “a Jap” now and forever. My parents raised me on the basis that we had two strikes against us, so we had to be on our best behavior at all times. Never do anything to let the white population have an excuse to fault us.

He does have one especially vivid memory of he and members of his basketball team trying to enter a bowling ally “but they would not let us bowl because we were ‘Japs’. We told them we were Canadians first, but they just wouldn’t allow us to play.”

Tak still remembers first hearing the news of the bombing of Pearl Harbor: “It was a Sunday and I was with friends out on Powell Street on our way home from playing badminton at the Japanese Language School when we heard the news from a radio in a parked car. It had a very

⁵³ Norm Masaji Ibuki, “[Tak Matsuba’s Odyssey from Vancouver to Osaka - Part 1](#),” *Discover Nikkei*, May 19, 2014.

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sobering effect on all of us.”⁵⁴ Sometime later the order for the uprooting followed. Tak vaguely remembers rushing to pack their bags and being allowed to take very little with them.

Tak’s family were sent directly to the Lemon Creek internment camp. He recalls the train journey from Vancouver to Slocan city being very long. His parents showed little if any emotion at the time. “It must have been devastating to lose almost everything they had worked for all their lives to achieve, but in retrospect, they didn’t show it too much. Being born in the Meiji Era, they had that stoicism of ‘gaman’ and ‘shikataganai,’ so they seemed to accept almost whatever came along,” he says.⁵⁵

His memories of life in the camp are mostly good.

Being a teenager, I was carefree and intent on having a good time. As teenagers are wont, I looked at the good side of things and managed to find something of interest. I was fortunate that there were a number of friends in Lemon Creek whom I already knew from the Vancouver days. Of course, I made many more new friends and these friendships have lasted to this day. We used to hold dance parties and I had a fairly good collection of records which were very useful and appreciated by friends. However, I was too bashful and never really learned how to dance properly, something I now regret. In the winter time, the shore side of the river froze and we could ice skate, but we had to be careful not to go too far from shore because the river was flowing and the ice got thinner at the far edges. Some guys used to fall in and we had to build fires to dry and warm them. We sometimes stole the railway fence posts to fuel the fires. I can’t recall for sure, but quite possibly sometimes railway ties were also pilfered. Another wintertime favorite was sleighing. There was some danger in this because the best place was the nearby highway. There was quite a steep incline and the traffic had packed down the snow, forming a very slick surface that was good for sleighing. We had to station guards at the curves to signal that the way was clear of any oncoming traffic. The elders did not look too kindly on this sport. I was not and still am not a very religious person but got involved in the camp with the Buddhist Youth Group and we used to perform plays on the stage in the Buddhist Church to entertain the internees. These were almost all in the Japanese language and in retrospect, this helped me polish my Japanese. I didn’t know then, but in later life, it helped me survive the early years in Japan. The authorities would not allow us to have cameras, but the Buddhist minister built a camera, using a celluloid soap case for the body, and gave it to me. I was able to use it to take quite a few photos but regret that I have lost the camera and the photos. I am not sure where or how I lost them, either in the confusion of being shipped to Japan or during the turmoil of the Hanshin Earthquake.”

He recalls the names of two of his teachers, Ms. Hamilton and Ms. Hurd. About the former he says, “I didn’t know that Miss Hamilton had been so active in girls’ education in Japan prior to the War. In retrospect, I was not a good student and talked back a lot. I now regret it and have the greatest respect for the teachers, especially Ms. Hamilton for the good work she did in Japan against such odds. It is a wonder that she would continue in the education field after such an experience.” Despite his admission about his shortcomings as a high school student, during the last months of the internment he was recruited to help with the education of some elementary students who were still in the Lemon Creek camp.

⁵⁴ Norm Masaji Ibuki in “[Tak Matsuba’s Odyssey from Vancouver to Osaka - Part 1](#),” *Discover Nikkei*, May 19, 2014.

⁵⁵ Quoted by Norm Masaji Ibuki in “[Tak Matsuba - Part 1](#),” *Discover Nikkei*, May 19, 2014.

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With the end of the war and people relocating or being shipped to Japan, teachers and students were leaving Lemon Creek, but there were still a number of students who were waiting for their departure dates. The principal at that time was a lady friend of mine and she approached me to help her manage the remaining students. I was not qualified to be a regular teacher, but she wouldn't take no for an answer and I finally agreed. I did not really teach anything, but acted more like a watchman over the kids. I recall that at one time I took a bunch of comic books to school and let the students pass the time reading comics. I was there to oversee the students in school, not so much to study, but to keep them out of mischief. It was a short-lived experience for me. I cannot recall of how long, but a few months at most.

Regarding his overall impression of his life in Canada, Tak adds:

I was 15 years old when the Canadian government put me in the internment camp. Four years later, I was shipped to Japan. Actually, my life in Canada ended when I was 15. Lemon Creek was not Canada. Those four years in Lemon Creek were like living in a cocoon. Of course, when I emerged from that cocoon, the outside world was quite different and it took me a while to adjust.

Exile of the Matsuba Family to Japan

Tak was 19 when his family was exiled to Japan. One reason his father chose being sent to Japan was uncertainty about what would happen if they moved to eastern Canada. They were also concerned about the welfare of close relatives in Japan with whom they had lost contact during the war. In addition, his father still owned a house in Mio whereas in Canada he had lost everything.

I think the decision was mainly due to the fact that we had no assets (in Canada), but dad had a house he owned in Japan and at least that was a roof over our heads, whereas going to eastern Canada meant too many unknowns: Will we be welcome? How will we support ourselves without a place to live, etc.? Also, I think my parents were concerned about how their parents were faring. We learned later that they were all well, which was a great relief... When we arrived in Japan the biological parents of both my father and mother were still in good health. My father's biological father had returned to Japan before the war.

Tak does not recall whether he himself was against going to Japan or not. "My siblings and I just did as our parents decided. It was tough going at times, but youth was on our side and we made the best of things. We never regretted the decision." He has several recollections of the voyage:

Quite a number of passengers suffered seasickness. I didn't and was involved in comforting those who did. I don't remember the purpose, but I had a portable typewriter and was requested to type up a list of all the passengers... During the voyage, I befriended the ship's chef. He took a liking to me and, knowing the conditions in Japan from his previous visits, tried very hard to get me to stay on board and not land at Japan. The chef was like a second in command of the ship next to the captain, and since I would not take his advice, he put together a very large bag full of rolls from the bakery and gave it to me. This fed our family for a few days after landing.

Tak also recalls the awful conditions, particularly the food, during his time at the repatriation center at Kurihama upon arriving in Japan.

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We arrived at Kurihama, near Tokyo. It was August and it was hot and humid with a lot of mosquitos. Our holding quarters were in a large wooden building... There were mosquito nettings and we slept inside the netting. I don't remember much about the food except that there was very little and it was hard to tell what it was. There was a soup-like dish we used to call "dishwater."

He also remembers the arduous train journey from Tokyo to Wakayama.

The trains were crowded and everybody was fighting to get on. Some even climbed through the windows instead of the doors. There were many tunnels en route and soot from the coal burners filtered into the coaches. We also had to keep a close watch on our baggage lest someone steal it.

Tak's parents had very little money when they arrived in Wakayama. His father turned to farming and raised rice and vegetables on the family's land in Miomura, but the situation was not good. He says, "At first, it was a matter of finding work so that we could live. Nothing else came into my mind."

In contrast to many exiles, Tak does not recall being discriminated against by relatives and fellow-villagers, or being bullied by other teenagers. Because he had studied Japanese at the Vancouver Japanese Language School and practiced it as a member of the Buddhist youth group at Lemon Creek, he did not have serious problems with daily communication. Also, because so many people had emigrated to Canada from Mio, the people of the village were relatively used to household members coming back and forth from Canada and hence were more accepting than those of other villages. Yet, there was "some feeling of envy on the part of the locals because what little we had brought from Canada was still very desirable to the locals who had less." However, he struggled with the difficult living conditions. There was no piped water or plumbing system—so no flushing toilet, and the heating was poor.

Employment with the US Occupation Forces

Realizing that he had no economic prospects in Mio, after only a month he went to Tokyo and found employment with the Occupation Forces base at what is now Haneda Airport. As room and board were included, he did not suffer severe hunger and he was able to send some of his earnings to his parents.

Despite having a basic grounding in spoken Japanese, he did occasionally experience some difficulty with the language during the early years and continually had to consult dictionaries for both English and Japanese at his work. Eventually he came to feel more proficient though he never felt he had reached the point that he could stop studying. As it was necessary for him to make a living, continuing his education was out of the question. He says, "Instead of going to school, I tried to teach myself. I am a very curious person by nature and asked my friends a lot of questions. Also, I learned by osmosis."

Officially, his main work was to keep statistical records of personnel and cargo moving in and out of Japan. He recalls,

They tested me for my typing ability which I passed with high marks and I was assigned to Haneda Air Base. Although I was hired as a clerk typist, I never did any typing, but my responsibilities were as a statistician, keeping a record of passengers and cargo arriving and departing from the base. I did not care what kind of job they gave me as I was just happy to be hired. At a time when food and housing were scarce in Japan, my job came with a bed in a dormitory and I could eat three meals a day at the Air Force mess hall, so I

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could send a large part of my earnings to my parents in Wakayama to support them and my siblings who were in school.

Tak was also used frequently as an interpreter, a job which sometimes entailed considerable discomfort:

I was not trained to be an interpreter, but in those days there were so few who could interpret that even someone like me with a limited Japanese language capability was useful. I always did the best I could to be of help and enjoyed helping, but there was one case where I was asked to interpret at a court martial. As things proceeded, the prosecutor would ask me to ask a question of the accused. I was told to reply in the first person. In other words, he would accuse the defendant of a crime and when the defendant replied, I would have to say, 'Yes, I did' or 'No, I didn't' I didn't like that at all. I felt like I was the person on trial. That was one of the rare times I didn't enjoy helping.

Being known as courtroom interpreter also led to other uncomfortable requests for help:

I had an aunt who was a school teacher in the Haneda area and one time one of her former pupils was arrested by the police and was in custody at the police station. I used to accompany the U.S. Military Police to the station when U.S. soldiers and Japanese civilians were involved in a crime case and I was a familiar figure in the area. Word got around to my aunt to ask my help in getting the former pupil released. I didn't do anything to help, but for some reason, the student was released and the village thugs thought I had helped. After that, whenever I was walking through the village, young thugs would come up to me and thank me. That was uncomfortable for me in that, first of all, I didn't have anything to do with the release and secondly, I was still a naïve young man and afraid to talk with the thugs, even if they meant well.

Some other uncomfortable situations occurred when the Military Police needed Tak's interpreting services and asked him to accompany them on night raids on black marketers.

It was after my working hours and I went to the Military Police Offices where they gave me a handgun. I promptly gave it back, telling them that I had never handled guns and I would be very dangerous with one. During the occupation days, flints for cigarette lighters were sold by watch sales and repair shops. Flints were imported and so much in demand that there was a profitable black market. That night, I went with the patrol unit into the nearby village and we raided a watch shop. We pried open the door and went upstairs where the proprietor and his wife were sleeping. The proprietor knew what his misdemeanor was and was resigned to the fact (of his arrest), but his wife was scared to be awakened by a group of American soldiers and was shaking with fear. I really felt sorry for her.

At another time, I was called in to go on a raid to nearby base of a U.S. Army Engineering Unit. This was an all colored soldiers unit and they were smuggling prostitutes into their barracks. We arrested several soldiers and women and the next day I had to go and help with the investigations where I oversaw one of the women write an account of what had transpired. I was not that good at writing Japanese, but the woman had very little education due to the war, so I sometimes had to correct her kanji. The officer in charge saw me doing so and thought I was helping her write the account whereas I was only helping her with a few kanji characters. I was starting to be frequently asked to help the Military Police so finally my commanding officer had to tell them to stop. He felt it was not fair for them to take so much time away from my regular job.

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Through his work, Tak was able to develop meaningful relationships with members of the occupying forces.

My main job was to keep records of troop and cargo movement, but it was my nature not to say no when asked to help out elsewhere and I made many friends among the officers. At one time, an officer came to my office and we chatted and in the course of our conversation, he asked what my neck size was. It seemed odd that he should ask my neck size, and I can't recall now, but at that time, I probably thought there were going to be some excess uniforms and he was getting a shirt for me. It turned out that, at Christmas time he came to my office with a huge package which was a gift for me. I was very surprised and opened it to find a shirt, sweater, and cardigan. In those days, decent clothing was scarce and the officer and his friends had ordered from a mail order catalog for me. Needless to say, I appreciated that very much.

Likewise, his improving skills as an interpreter and willingness to be of help to anyone made him a valued assistant to Japanese American members of the occupying forces as well as white soldiers with limited literacy in English.

There were Japanese American soldiers at the base. They had very limited Japanese language skills, so quite often, when their Japanese relatives visited them, I was asked to go with them to help with the language. At first I was just an interpreter, but after a few meetings the families often got to know me better than the relatives they were meeting. With one family, I became good friends and I was not sure whether they came in order to visit their relative or to visit with me. Another experience was with a white American soldier friend who was from the southern part of the US. To my great surprise, he asked me to write a letter to his mother. He told me very little about what to write so I had to ask him questions and coax information from him before I could write a letter. I was a fairly fast typist so I could type up the letters for him and I got the feeling that he had very little education and couldn't write.

During this time, Tak lost his younger brother Gabby. After Tak had moved to Tokyo in 1946 and found employment with the US occupation forces there, Gabby started working in 1947 at an Occupation Forces base in Osaka. Like Tak, he also developed good friendships with members of the American military. However, he later became ill with spinal meningitis. During his illness, some members of the Military Police who had become his friends gave him medicine which they had apparently confiscated off the black market. Unfortunately, however, Gabby passed away in 1949. Tak reminisces wistfully, "Gabby was a good student and excelled in studies and sports. He was quite a good swimmer, he could draw well, did some carving. Hate to admit it, but he beat me all around. In my business career, I often wished he had not died so early. He would have been a good partner. He was the most talented of all of us."

Tak remembers missing his life and friends in Canada, especially the latter. "I missed my friends more than the life... 'Life in Canada' to me was as a boy living in an almost completely Japanese community from birth at 1926 until 1942 when they shipped me to Lemon Creek internment camp. And then I came straight to Japan from Lemon Creek."

He does not recall his parents talking much about Canada after they returned to Japan, and when they did talk other topics predominated. Likewise, they never discussed whether Tak should return to Canada. He says, "I think my parents wanted me to make my own life choices." He himself never really felt like living in Canada again, partly due to the financial and other formidable obstacles which he felt would be waiting for him if he ever moved there.

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However, his siblings and parents eventually would leave Japan again—not for Canada, but for Hawaii. His sister Masumi (Marie) lived seven years in Japan and moved to Hawaii after marrying an American serviceman. Another sister, Mikiyo (Miki), stayed nine years and was still single when she went to Hawaii, where she ended up marrying the brother of Marie's husband. Tak's younger brother, Takumi, lived fourteen years in Japan where he finished junior high school before he was sponsored by his sisters to immigrate to Hawaii. Likewise, the parents eventually followed their children to Hawaii. Later they moved with Takumi to San Francisco where he attended university. He graduated as an electronics engineer, but ended up in the restaurant business, becoming the owner of a very successful Japanese restaurant called the Bushitei.

Career in the Private Sector

As the Japanese economy began to re-emerge during the postwar years, there was an urgent need for employees who could speak English well. This became a lifesaving economic opportunity for many of the exiles, even those lacking a strong formal education. Tak was one of those who made the best of this situation, using a combination of native wit, natural curiosity, good social skills, and a willingness to offer his assistance to anyone who needed it.

After four years of working for the Occupation Forces, he was beginning to feel restless and anxious about his future. He was introduced by an American army officer to Amerex Trading Company, which was affiliated with the Sogo Department Store. He worked there from 1950 to 1952.

As time went by I started to feel that I was leading a protected life and that the real world was outside the Occupation Forces. I cannot recall how it came about, but I must have mentioned this to one of the officers and one day he asked me if I wanted to try for an outside job and if so, he could introduce me to a Japanese business executive. But, it was on the proviso that I not tell anyone that he had helped me get a job outside of the Occupation Forces lest he get in trouble with his superiors who valued my services and wouldn't want to see me leave.

I was beginning to think that the occupation would not last forever and that my future was elsewhere, so I took him up on it and he introduced me to the Japanese manager of Amerex Trading Company, owned and operated by some Jewish Americans who had fled Russia after World War II and emigrated to the U.S.A. I was hired and started working in a civilian environment. The main business of the company was to import supplies, mainly foodstuffs for sale to specialty shops which at that time catered to foreigners who were not affiliated with the Occupation Forces. Being naturalized Americans, the president and vice president of the company were proficient in the English language, but it was not their mother tongue. One day, they called me into their office and said that they couldn't find in the dictionary a particular word in a letter they had received. I took a look at it and told them that it was a misspelt word and it should have been spelt so and so. I can't recall what the word was, but they soon found it in the dictionary. That happening helped me later in the office. Whenever the Japanese manager would ask me to translate at times long and not really necessary material, the president would tell the manager not to "burden Tak with such minor chores as we have more important things for him to do.

In 1952, two years after I started working at the company, I was sent to Osaka as manager of a joint business specialty store with a Japanese department store. At this point, perhaps I

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should explain the term, “specialty store.” In those days, there were PXs (post exchanges) which were stores for occupation force personnel, civilians (civil service personnel) and their dependents, where they could purchase all the necessities of life, but there was a foreign civilian group who did not come under the category of ‘occupation force civilians.’ They were non-Japanese who were living in Japan when the War ended. Some were Italian and German military personnel who were stranded in Japan and continued to live there. Specialty stores were set up to supply the needs of this third-party group and the currency used was the U.S. dollars script. To deal with the banks in script, there was a need for a foreigner to sign checks, etc., and that is probably how I got the job.

In 1952 Tak started working for the Sogo Department Store chain in Osaka where he continued for seven years. It was here that he met his wife. They would have 3 daughters to whom they gave names that sound both English and Japanese: Amy, Alisa, and Serena.

The present Japanese department chain store, Sogo, with which the joint specialty shop was established, had their main store taken over by the Occupation Forces and was being used as a PX. As time went by and the peace treaty was signed, the PX was returned to the Japanese owners and the specialty shop was closed, and I was invited by Sogo to become their employee, which I accepted. This really started my career in the Japanese business world. I worked there from November 1952 to June 1959. I don’t know what went on behind the scenes, but the Japanese manager of Amerex Trading Co. later ended up becoming a vice president of Sogo Department Store.

After seven years with Sogo, in 1959 Tak moved to the textile export division of a medium sized trading company called Santai Trading Company. He would stay there until 1977. As he explains, this job involved a wide variety of business endeavors and interesting experiences.

While working in Tokyo at Amerex Trading Co., I had met many Japanese businessmen and one of them became a director of the department store. He was also president of his own trading company, Santai Trading Co., and in 1959, he asked me to join his company, which I did and worked there from July 1959 to July 1977.

At Santai I was involved in exports and imports. The company started importing blue denim fabrics from the US to be made into jeans in Japan. This business took off and we were so successful that we were importing denim fabrics by the container loads.

Eventually, Japanese weavers learned how to make blue denims and were exporting the fabric to U.S. and Europe. In my opinion, Santai was one of the pioneers of the Japanese jeans market.

Another project I was involved in at Santai was the lumber business. We started a joint venture company with a Japanese lumber company to manufacture door jambs. The equipment and know-how to make the jambs were supplied by an American company. Our Japanese partner in the joint venture was well versed in the local lumber industry and our American suppliers had the manufacturing know-how. However, the Japanese partner had no experience in working with a foreign company and the American company had no experience in Japan, so we were an important link.

One of my responsibilities was to accompany the president of Santai on his trips overseas. He had never been overseas before and was looking forward to his first overseas visit, but had some qualms. He told me that he was concerned lest he get lost. I told him that if he got lost, I would be the one most concerned so he should stay by me. We went to New

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York and from there to Florida and on to Santo Domingo in the Dominican Republic where we had an office staffed by a man we had sent from Japan.

Once we were invited to the Japanese employee's home for a Japanese dinner. We were there for about an hour when our hosts started to worry. It turned out that they had ordered some fish from a Japanese retiree living there who liked to fish and took orders to supplement his income, but on this occasion he couldn't catch anything for a long time. Finally he came back successful and we were able to enjoy sashimi.

On one of my frequent business trips I was visiting our liaison office in New York. The manager was driving me through Long Island when another car rammed us on the driver's side. Fortunately, the accident occurred right in front of a doctor's house and he came out and laid the manager, who was unconscious, on the ground and placed a pillow under his head. The ambulance took us to a hospital and the manager's damaged spleen was taken out. I had a few stitches, but nothing serious like the manager's injuries.

Since the manager was going to be hospitalized for a long time and his family had just arrived in a foreign country, I had to extend my visit to take care of the office and his family. So, what started as a one month visit lasted for six months before I could return to Japan. However, it was not all bad since it gave me an opportunity to visit the New York World's Fair which was being held during this time.

In 1977 Tak moved to Fujicopian, a company which now manufactures various kinds of stationery and printing supplies as well as ink cartridges, etc. for computers and high tech business machines. He would stay there until retiring at age 78. He was placed in charge of foreign affairs and travelled overseas a lot as he worked to establish subsidiaries and technology licensees in various countries including the US, the UK, Hong Kong, Malaysia, France and others.

Ever since I started working, I was also moonlighting to supplement my income to support my family. All the companies I helped were involved in export or import from overseas and English was the language used in communications. I could type, so I was very fast at writing business letters. I also helped in the business negotiations, by letter or telephone. When the business friends visited Japan, I would help with the negotiations and in the evenings I would be involved in entertaining them as well. In those days, salaries were not very high as profits were kept in the company. Hence moonlighting was very lucrative for me and one of the presidents of a company for which I moonlighted asked me to join his company. I had been helping him for 17 years and he knew me well.

He used to say that the interview took 17 years and we couldn't find anything wrong with each other. We agreed on a handshake and I joined the company in August 1977. In March, 1978, I was elected to the board of directors of the company as manager of the Foreign Affairs Department.

I served five presidents while at Fujicopian. My responsibilities also included overseas trips with the then president and our wives. One trip was to sign a very large and lucrative financing contract undertaken with German and Japanese banks. While we men worked, the banks arranged for chauffeur-driven cars with interpreters for our wives and they were entertained royally. Every evening we would be invited to dinner at the best restaurants. The contract was signed in an old castle on the Rhine and they flew Japanese and German flags and there were rumors the next day that the Japanese had bought another castle!

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My wife enjoyed those trips which included opening ceremonies of our subsidiary companies in England and the U.S.A. She enjoyed the sightseeing and being so nicely entertained. Of course, the best part was that she didn't have to do any housework during these trips. We ate at the best restaurants and the hotel took care of our other needs like laundry.

Around 1988, shortly before the Berlin Wall came down, Tak visited Berlin with a group of tourists. He was surprised at how the people he saw in East Germany were always somber faced and never smiled. The East German officer accompanying their group did numerous headcounts, specifically after every site they visited to make sure no one was missing from the group. At one point, when they were at Checkpoint Charlie undergoing a customs check, a cat suddenly dashed into the room. To break the tension, Tak made a joke, asking if the cat was escaping East Germany and if they were going to catch it. Apparently the other members of the tour group laughed, but the East German border guards did not, either because they did not understand the joke or they were just not amused. Tak later realized that his joke was a dangerous mistake and regretted it.

He also remembers watching people boating on a lake on the east-west border. The lake was divided into east and west by a line of ropes and floats. There were two guard boats patrolling the east side of the lake, while on the west side he could see several pleasure boats. Whenever the pleasure boats would approach the line of floats on border, the guard boats on the east side would rush to intercept them lest they crossed, and the pleasure boats would of course do a U-turn back to the west in time to avoid being caught.

Tak frequently made business trips to New York, during which he would often stop in Toronto and Vancouver where he met up with old Japanese Canadian friends and attended special events such as school and internment camp reunions. When he reached retirement age (65), he was asked to stay on at Fujicopian as an advisor which he did until finally retiring at age 78.

Formation of Exiles' Groups in Tokyo and Osaka

Following the official apology by Canada in 1988 to Japanese Canadians, a delegation was sent by the Canadian government to Japan to explain the terms of redress to the Japanese Canadian exiles still living there. These explanation meetings brought together many exiles who had not seen each other since the internment. Tak says that they had some idea of others who had been deported to Japan, but many had lost contact with each other and did not know where in Japan others were located.

When Tatsuo Kage and the Canadian delegation came to Japan to explain to us regarding the redress compensation program, they first came to Tokyo and contacted Japanese Canadians there. There were probably some Japanese Canadians back in Canada who knew Japanese Canadians in Japan and provided the contact information. Anyway, this led to word getting around that there would be an explanation meeting and all those interested should attend (ads were placed in newspapers as well). At the meeting, many ran into old friends, some of whom they thought weren't even in Japan, and for future liaison, they probably figured they should form some sort of organization. I can't recall how it came about exactly, but there were a number of ex-Lemon Creekers in Tokyo whom I knew and one of them was a classmate from Vancouver days. One chap, Kaz Ide, who was my younger brother Gabby's pal in Lemon Creek days, was very active in the organization and

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I think he was the first president. There was another ex-Lemon Creeker, named Lloyd Kumagai, also in Tokyo, and they both contacted us in the Kansai region and invited us to join the association. At that time, we were still waiting for more redress information and application papers, and things were being organized so more people could be more expeditiously contacted. The original organization had a membership of about 70 or 80 persons from all over Japan.

Eventually Tak and some other exiles living in the Kansai region banded together and formed a small Kansai branch, in which Tak played a leading role. He explains about its formation and the relationships of some of the leading members as follows:

We formed a Kansai chapter (about 20 members) and Tom Mizuguchi and I, together with another chap, Kiyoshi Muraki, used to go to Tokyo to attend the meetings twice a year in the spring and autumn. We were sort of self-appointed directors. Later I had to resign due to my business commitments requiring many overseas trips which resulted in my absence from Japan when the meetings were held. The Tokyo and Kansai groups continued as social groups after redress. Tom and I, as sort of caretakers, tried to keep the Kansai group going. We would arrange for the meeting place and would send out notices to all the members. We used to get together at hotel restaurants in Osaka and, in the later years, we used the Kobe Club quite a bit. Fuji Fujino was a member of the Kobe Club, so we could take advantage of his membership privileges. I tried to keep the group together by writing a sort of circular letter addressed to all who attended our luncheons. Later, as we got older, some could not attend, others passed away and the organization went out of existence. I believe that Fujino-san and Hosoi-san, who were both important members and were my seniors, had been stranded in Japan when the war started. They had been brought here by their parents and the war started before they could return. My recollection is that I was introduced to Fujino-san at the now defunct Osaka Grand Hotel by a mutual friend. It turned out that his older brother, Abe Korenaga, was an Asahi baseball star and of course as a kid I had been his fan. There were a lot of Lemon Creekers so I knew most of them and had helped put the Kansai group together but had to resign my responsibilities due to my job requiring frequent overseas trips and I was starting to miss meetings. However, I continued to be a member.

Life after Retirement and Thoughts about Canada

Tak kept active after his retirement from Fujicopian and made several travels with his wife. She unexpectedly passed away due to complications resulting from the treatment of esophageal cancer in 2015. Tak still tried stay socially active into his early nineties but felt hindered by his loss of hearing. After his wife's passing, he lived with one of his daughter's family in Nishinomiya, a suburb of Osaka. All of three daughters are married to Japanese nationals.

Reflecting on his internment and exile from Canada, Tak says he does not feel any bitterness towards Canada now, although his indignation sometimes surfaces when talking about the experience of being exiled. He vividly recalls attending the meeting held by a Canadian government delegation explaining that he, along with other Japanese Canadian exiles, was eligible for redress, and the subsequent process of filling out the required forms and showing proof of citizenship. He believes in putting the past behind and looking ahead, but he hopes that young Japanese Canadians will remember what happened to their community and "will work to

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ensure that something like that will never happen again, not only to Japanese Canadians, but to other minorities in Canada as well.”⁵⁶

He still has Canadian citizenship (living in Japan under a permanent residency visa) and hence feels that he is a Canadian “because of my birthright.” He thinks he might have wished to return to Canada during the first few difficult years in Japan, but after ten or so years had passed, he came to feel quite comfortable in Japan. He says he doesn’t think he will ever feel completely Japanese, but on the other hand, thinks he would find it very difficult to ever feel completely Canadian, partly because of his lack of contact with Canadian society even while a child and teenager in Canada.

All those years we were in Lemon Creek camp, I was isolated from Canadian society, so I hardly knew what a truly Canadian society was when I was growing up, and I became an adult after I got to Japan, so it’s difficult to say. However, I guess I have to say I feel more Canadian than Japanese because when I’m thinking, I’m thinking in English. My wife used to tell me I talk in my sleep in English.⁵⁷

This ambiguous sense of national identity was also reflected in an interview with Norm Ibuki in 2014 when he noted, “When forced to live in a ‘foreign country,’ the language, customs, food, etc. can make things unbelievably difficult. Even for second generation Nikkei with the advantage of racial origin, the conditions in Japan were so severe that I think many could never adapt. Although I have lived in Japan for so long, at times I get the feeling that I am not completely used to the country.”⁵⁸

⁵⁶ Norm Masaji Ibuki in “[Tak Matsuba’s Odyssey from Vancouver to Osaka - Part 2](#),” *Discover Nikkei*, May 20, 2014.

⁵⁷ In *Japanese-Canadian Stories from Japan*: compiled by Nobuko Nakayama and Jean Maeda. Tokyo, 2011, p. 29.

⁵⁸ Norm Masaji Ibuki in “[Tak Matsuba’s Odyssey from Vancouver to Osaka - Part 2](#),” *Discover Nikkei*, May 20, 2014.

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POSTSCRIPT

(not yet written)

New information gained from my interviews (e.g.)

- Unexpected acts of kindness and loyalty
- Divorce and broken families (Kazuko Makihara's parents, John and May Izumi)
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Little sermon on resilience, racism

Echo Kage's comment about what the exiles who stayed in Japan might have accomplished or what their families would have contributed to Canada if they had not been exiled

Joy Kogawa's comment that when you try to hurt your enemy you are hurting yourself or your own side.

Relevance to today's racism and deportation issues

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